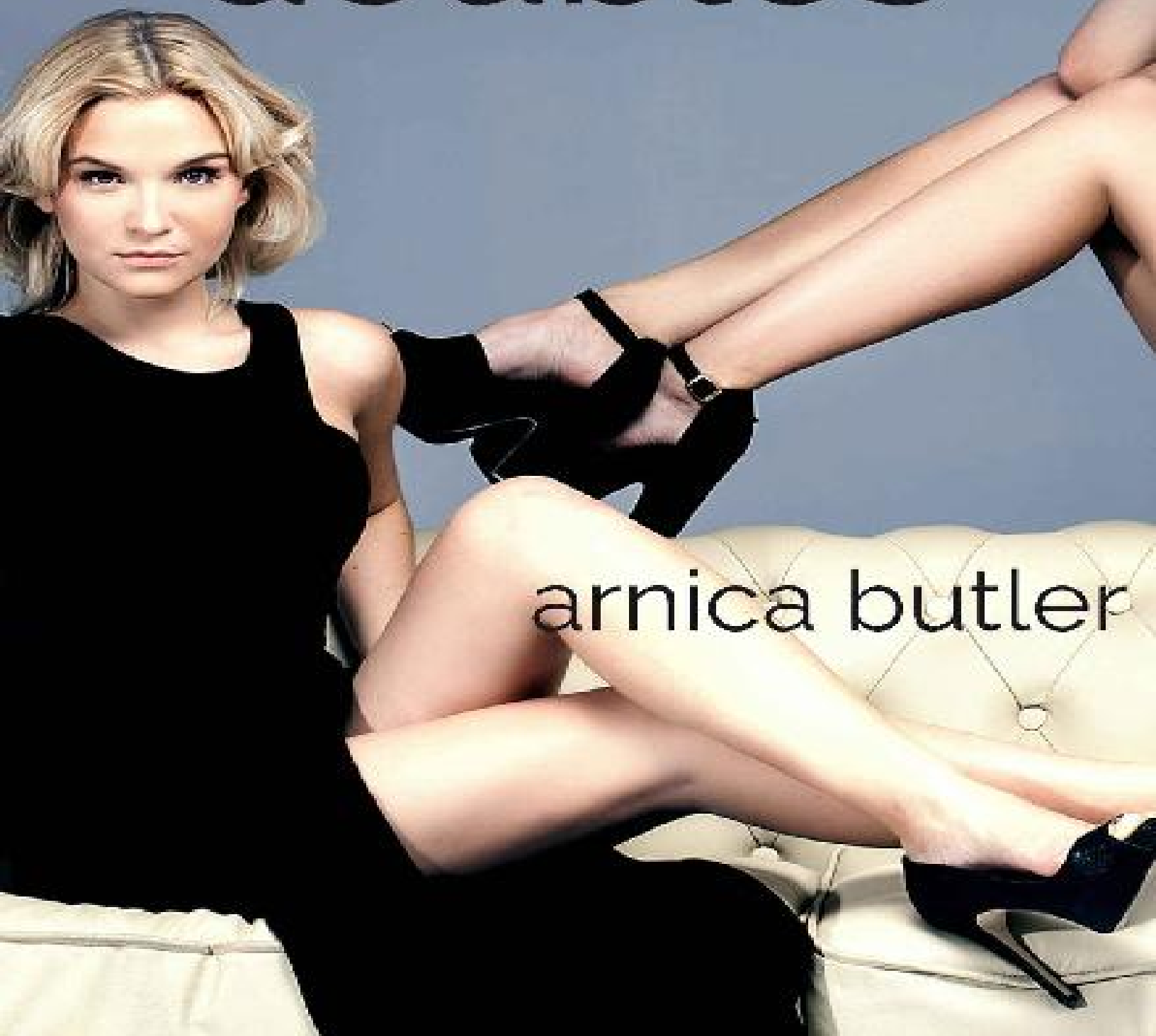


mixed doubles



arnica butler

MIXED DOUBLES

A Wife-Sharing Romance

By Arnica Butler

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CHAPTER 1

“Is that going to be a problem?”

Scarlett’s question shook me out of my reverie. I was staring openly at her figure by the window, mired in a bittersweet, pining reflection of my love for her. She was staring out into the snowy backyard with a distant expression. Scarlett was thinking about something intently, and I could only guess at what it was.

Until she spoke, my money had been on her thinking about the six feet and four inches of tanned Italian muscle, dark wavy hair, and occasionally stubble-dusted jawline of her “tennis instructor,” Alessandro. I had sipped my coffee, entertaining the simultaneously painful and arousing idea that her mouth was watering for his cock, or that she was privately re-enacting the way he manhandled her in bed.

“What?” I said, setting down my coffee and addressing her question after a lengthy pause.

She was already gesturing into the backyard. She gave a sigh of impatience, which meant she had already told me “what,” possibly more than once, and I hadn’t listened.

“That pool thing, it looks like it’s going to break. *Is it supposed to be like that?*”

Scarlett and I had recently purchased a lovely house in a charming Santa Fe neighborhood. We had been delighted, at the time of purchase, that the house had a pool. Like most transplants to Santa Fe, we had nurtured the mistaken belief that Santa Fe was like all of New Mexico, and very very hot. We spent our first summer making much ado about the relatively few hot days, shivering with determination while sunning ourselves, as we believed we should, next to our pool. We quickly realized the pool would have been much more useful in a Chicago summer, but we maintained the facade right through a rainy July, all the way to August, when a sprinkling of high-altitude snow laid the deception too bare for even our stubborn imaginations.

We were even more shocked, in winter, when Santa Fe turned out to be snowy and quite cold. It had nothing on Chicago, but it was chilly, and

our pool required maintenance and closing down. We were now utterly perplexed by the pool, and wished we didn't have one.

I rose from my chair and stood next to Scarlett. She had her sunny blonde hair in a professional twist, and was wearing a smart navy suit she had recently purchased. It was crisp, clean, professional. She even had stockings on.

All so *very* professional.

Except I knew that the stockings were thigh-high and made of silk, with intricate nude lace at the top, matching her panties, which were also quite elaborate and lacy. Designed to tease a lover.

I hadn't bought them for her. I hadn't even seen them on her. The lover they would entice was not me.

I glanced down at the vague outline of lace beneath her white blouse, her pert breasts pressing against the cups, almost overflowing. Her flawless skin, now a creamy white with little remaining of the tan she'd acquired playing tennis all summer, was kissed by a healthy pink glow. She had painted her lips with a drab, professional mauve, but a hint of bright pink in the center of her mouth made her teacup lips look ripe and youthful. A dusting of gray shadow and thick black mascara made the gray-blue of her eyes pop.

To someone who didn't know her very well, there was nothing different from the usual about Scarlett's appearance. If you didn't know, as I did, about the expensive new underwear, you might miss all the little details – the stain of pink, the smattering of eye shadow, the very faint whiff of perfume – that were *not* usual for Scarlett.

"You want me to call the pool guy again?" I asked.

Scarlett's mouth twisted into a half-smirk. She played absent-mindedly with the turquoise pendant I had given her, sliding it sensually along the silver chain. There was an erotic appeal to the conflagration of secret underwear beneath her getup, and her inclusion of the pendant, a stunning chunk of polished turquoise, almost indigo blue in color, and shot through with such large veins of coppery red metal that it looked as if someone had splattered paint on rust. It had delighted Scarlett, and I was very proud of it because I had picked it out myself.

"Ugh. I'm sure it's fine," she breathed. She looked up at the clock, then jumped. "Shoot. I have to go."

She leaned toward me to give me a quick kiss. Because I had gotten a little wound up watching her, speculating about her wayward thoughts, thinking about her thigh-high stockings, I reached around her waist and pulled her toward me.

She relented, melting into my embrace, kissing me wetly. She opened her mouth to let me explore hers with my tongue, and I felt her soft belly relax against me.

Then her hand was on my chest, her lips tugging away from me, making a noise, making an excuse. “Uh, honey, I have to...” She kissed me again, and then pushed away. “I have a hearing. I have to run.”

She hurried around the kitchen and scooped up her things. I watched her, fascinated. She had her briefcase, and she even opened it to check inside. She smoothed her hair and her suit in front of the mirror, showed her teeth to make sure no lipstick had gotten on them, and then shimmied into a coat.

“No hat?” I asked, spinning a woolen hat she had tossed on the counter on my fingers. Playfully, smiling at her. Messing with her, just a little.

She looked at me, pulling up her collar and straightening her coat around her shoulders. “With this hairdo?” she scoffed, her voice friendly. Her eyes were shifty, though, going from her phone to me and around the house.

“It’s cold,” I countered.

“I’ll have to man up,” she quipped. “Okay. Bye. Don’t forget I’ll probably be late tonight.”

Oh, I haven’t forgotten.

“Sure. I’ll just get some takeout.”

I watched her as she slid her fingers over her phone, a worried expression on her face. For a moment, I could almost believe that the frown was due to a deluge of emails about labor disputes and union negotiations, for the busyness of her understaffed and overworked law firm, Katherman and Sanchez.

But Scarlett wasn’t the kind of lawyer to get so flustered that she would let that go. The comment about the takeout, that is. I waited, sipping my coffee, hoping that the cold ache in my lower abdomen had not spread so obviously to my crotch. Scarlett turned, and put her hand on the door, opened her mouth to say something, and then seemed to think better of it.

“Yeah,” she began, and then gave her head a light shake. “Wait. Takeout?”

She looked at me.

I looked right back at her.

“That’s rude,” she said, smiling, trying to make a joke. I wondered if she suspected that I was up to something, or if she was just so caught up in her own little world that she didn’t notice these things. I slurped my coffee as I looked at her over the rim of the mug.

“Them’s the breaks,” I said.

It isn’t nearly as rude, I challenged her in my mind, as lying to your husband about your Italian lover. Is it?

My stomach knotted up again, the now-familiar wrenching coiling tightly, cold and hot at the same time, as Scarlett blinked, started to cock her head slightly, and then was distracted by the buzzing phone in her hand. She shrugged, turned, said something like “okay, bye,” and then disappeared out the door.

I waited, listening to the car start up, the garage door close, and then a few beats more. Blood was pulsing in my ears, and a curtain of a sentiment I have yet to name was falling down, blurring my vision.

It would pass.

My hands were shaky as I reached for my phone, but by the time I began to swipe at the screen, they were steady again.

I swept through the countless, useless, one-time apps I had piled up on my phone to get to my current addiction, the app I used day and night, the app that was taking away time from work, driving me crazy.

Highster Mobile.

I wasn’t proud of myself, but then, Scarlett was no angel either.

I swept through her messages, all neatly displayed on the control panel of my app. I preferred to use HM on my laptop – the preference curiously similar to my preference for watching porn on my laptop, the sensation almost equal.

I scanned the messages. I knew Alessandro’s number by heart, though the man suspiciously changed numbers as often as every two weeks.

Whatever. His sultry, surly, Italian smarminess was simple enough to detect.

My heart fell.

No new message from Alessandro. Just the message from last night:

[Alessandro]: Still on for tomorrow afternoon?

[Scarlett]: Yes. 4:30

I swept down, down, down to where the messages were more incriminating, where more innuendo was exchanged. Lately, and I was sure this was because the guilt was eating away at her, Scarlett's messages to Alessandro had an almost exasperated, professional tone to them.

But I knew that what Alessandro was doing with my wife – and what my wife was doing with Alessandro – was *far* from professional.

I briefly looked at the GPS locator, at the other scans I could do of my wife's phone, letting the tantalizing thrill of voyeurism course through me. I could look at these things all day, while I daydreamed about what she was going to do, how she was going to lie, how she was going to cover her lies up.

Almost ten minutes disappeared this way, before I shook myself out of my reverie, and put away my phone.

I had a job to get to as well. And Scarlett wouldn't be telling me lies any time soon.

I had to wait for it.

*

It wasn't unknown to me that my wife was sleeping with Alessandro, her erstwhile tennis instructor. It wasn't even devastating: she had the affair (the first part of the affair, anyway) with him with my blessing, even my encouragement.

Her interest in Alessandro had been, originally, purely an interest in receiving tennis lessons, and those lessons had been a gift to me.

That it had mutated into an affair, with me watching and encouraging, was unexpected for both of us. That Scarlett had enjoyed pushing her sexual boundaries to include Alessandro's manhandling and anal sex, had been even more surprising.

But then she had confided that she felt out of control. On the trip to Paris to see the French Open – Scarlett's original gift for me, the motive for her tennis instruction at the beginning – I had staged catching Alessandro and my wife in the act, and that had been our way of ending the affair.

But Scarlett, my wife of more than ten years, the woman I was planning to have a baby with, had somehow gotten entangled with Alessandro again. The story behind that was unknown to me, because this time around, my wife, for whatever reason, had chosen not to tell me about it.

At first, I had caught only a few stray text messages that seemed to be from Alessandro. She had deleted his name from her phone, and he had acquired a new number. I only figured out that it was him when he used his pet name for her.

Gattina.

The messages between them had begun as you'd suspect they would: Alessandro trying to be cute, flirting with Scarlett, and Scarlett not really taking the bait.

Though, it must be pointed out: Scarlett didn't exactly put her foot down. She led him along. She responded without ever telling him to fuck off.

In the beginning, I enjoyed just watching it unfold, assuming that eventually Scarlett would tell me about it. I was sort of hoping she would go back to having an affair with him; her previous trysts had injected new life into our marriage, invigorated our sex life, and erased the rift that had formed between us when we moved to Santa Fe.

I didn't *want* to be the kind of man who was hoping that, but that's just the kind of man I was.

Back when it started up again, I had assumed that she would tell me about it, that maybe this time around she could gain some control over him, and we could enjoy her relationship with him a little more.

Instead of that happening, though, Scarlett dove deep into her affair and into secrecy.

The messages between her and Alessandro, which I had enjoyed reading while she was in the shower or asleep, disappeared from her phone one day.

But Scarlett's strange behavior did not disappear, so the explanation was not that the affair with Alessandro had ended. In fact, her behavior became stranger – and stranger still, she seemed to believe that I hadn't noticed. She was often late with an excuse that didn't hold water, distracted for reasons that made no sense. She was anxious, flighty, lost in another world. She was wearing clothing I had never seen before; sexier suits that

fit more snugly and plunged more deeply than Scarlett ordinarily chose. Racy underwear sets beneath her slowly crumbling professional veneer. She kept her legs and her bush waxed, and even preemptively delivered an excuse for it – a sure sign of a guilty conscience. (The excuse for this being that she just really liked the bare skin of her full wax, but now that we knew there were not endless hot days to sunbathe in Santa Fe, the reason was flimsy).

The question for me then became: was it fair to begrudge her an affair with a man I had encouraged her to have an affair with the first time around? Was it fair to be angry with her for hiding it, when I had known about it for some time, and said nothing, because I was getting off on her sneaking around? Was what I was doing any better? Jailbreaking her phone, installing spy software, reading her messages, sometimes even following her to locations where her GPS signal glowed like a wet, throbbing pussy, hoping to see her or catch her?

I didn't *like* what was happening: there should be no mistake about that. The complicity we had shared was gone; the connection the affair had woven between us, back when Scarlett told me everything, was broken; and that meant there was something dark between us now.

That doesn't mean it didn't thrill me, almost as much, if not more, than what had happened between Scarlett and Alessandro before.

What kind of man that made me, I know not. It was slipping out of *my* control. Now that I had a taste for something like that, something so forbidden and slippery, so likely to get out of my grasp, I could understand better why Scarlett had started crying the night I had "caught" her with Alessandro, why she had confessed to feeling out of control. I could understand her frustration, her helplessness, her exasperation with herself.

And I could also understand now, why she had gone back to him.

CHAPTER 2

It was a fortunate circumstance that things were really cracking at Copeland, Copper, & Heim, where I was a contract lawyer and therefore the sort of robotnik who spent hours in meetings and then even more hours poring over the details embedded in vast, thousand-page long contracts.

It might sound boring to you, but I loved the precision of the law. I also really enjoyed writing a clean, bulletproof contract. Even if I would never be the one to scrutinize it in court, and no one would ever stand up and applaud my work, I enjoyed fantasizing about the low whistle other attorneys would surely let out when they read my flawless, elegant clauses.

It was enough to take my mind off my wife, in any case. Up until the afternoon, when I couldn't help my inclination to spice things up for myself, and interject myself in Scarlett's affair as an active participant.

I sat down in my office with the door closed and the shades drawn, a signal to all that I would breathe fire at anyone who interrupted me. I picked up the phone and called Katherman & Sanchez.

Katherman & Sanchez was no Copeland, Copper & Heim. They represented several unions, and handled a lot of labor disputes.

Alicia Upsala-Perez, a bilingual woman of forty-two who had been a receptionist in a labor office for her entire adult life, answered the phone with a healthy dose of preemptive skepticism, making it clear, in the space of seventeen connotation-laden words, that:

1) You had better be born in Mexico if you let so much as an "hola" come out of your mouth

2) She was not a pharmacist, so you had better not be calling about your oxy prescription and

3) You had better be nice, or you would be on hold for the rest of your life and until the sun exploded.

"Katherman and Sanchez, Alicia Upsala-Perez speaking, please hold one moment and have your file number ready. Favor de esperar."

Katherman & Sanchez played a wild mixture of soft jazz, whitewashed Tejano with no accordions, and vaguely native sounding music that for some reason involved metal flutes. I assumed most people found it highly offensive for one reason or another, and I once dedicated a

whole evening to searching for the source of such a disgusting mix online, to no avail.

Alicia Upsala-Perez was back again.

“Alicia,” I said, trying out a new voice for Alicia, whose frightening veneer I had thus far been unable to crack. It’s a perverse goal of mine to make any woman I meet like me.

Today, I envisioned myself sounding like George Clooney. “It’s Will Green. I want to talk to Scarlett, but I don’t want to interrupt anything. Is she available?”

“Putting you through.”

To be fair, my George Clooney sounded more like Used Car Salesman, but that’s because I am not an especially smooth guy.

An acoustic version of a Selena song filled the headset for a few moments, and then Scarlett answered, her voice bemused.

“Hey,” she said. “You failed to impress Alicia yet again.”

“Can’t win ‘em all.”

“Can’t win *at* all with Alicia. She’s heard it all.”

“I’m sure.”

There was a long pause, the thick rustle of papers and files as Scarlett, I was sure, leaned on her shoulder to press the phone into her ear and tried to get some work done while she waited for me to speak.

“So,” she said, after five seconds. “To what do I owe this pleasure?”

Scarlett owed this pleasure, I thought deliciously, to the fact that I knew she was heading to the country club to do something with Alessandro, and I was going to have fun making her squirm about it.

“I have a meeting in five, Will,” Scarlett said impatiently, when I didn’t immediately dive in.

“Oh. Sorry,” I said. “I am also working late, I just got slammed with this filing for Breck Co. So... I’m getting take-out. I thought I’d stop by with some for you. Tell me your takeout desires.”

This was all lies, of course. I was not working late, I was not offering her take-out, and I knew she wasn’t working late, either. I just wanted to make her squirm.

I pictured Scarlett, her hands freezing on her files, her stomach plummeting to the floor, her eyes moving as she flung her hands into the whirlwind of thoughts in her mind, her heart accelerating and a bead of sweat forming just below her earlobe.

Anyone else would not have detected the mere seconds of fluster that filled the silence on the end of the line, but those people do not know Scarlett like I do. Scarlett generally has an answer for everything, because her sharp legal mind is always several steps and thousands of potential outcomes ahead of anything you would dare to think of. It's very hard to throw her off.

But this is in Scarlett's known universe, where I do not have access to her phone, where she has set her messenger to automatically delete all messages within one minute of reading them, where she has done that to all of her messages so as not to raise suspicion about the one number she actually wants to hide, in the event I *am* prying into her phone.

But in the real world, I am one sneaky, underhanded step ahead of Scarlett, and I see her messages anyway.

I would never, in Scarlett's world, suggest to bring takeout. I'm simply not that thoughtful. Scarlett would never do that for me, either: we are our own lawyers, with our own business, and we do not prop each other up with food or snacks, or even all that much sympathy, when we are crushed by a trial or a tight deadline. It has been this way since law school.

I breathed in the pleasure of Scarlett's wildly floundering mind, her silence, her lack of answer. My own stomach contorted as it plummeted from some great height...

But only for a second.

"Uh... Gosh. Sweetie. That's... nice. Weird. But nice. But, um..." Another pause, she was looking for the right words, the right lie, running through a final check to see if it would be detected, trip her up, come back to haunt her. This took only a fraction of a second, but I sensed it.

"...these guys have gone above and beyond, if you can believe it, and ordered in."

I smiled. So devious.

"Katherman and Sanchez ordered food?" I said, sarcastically.

"We gave up the good fight and started chasing ambulances. It happens to the best of us."

She was back. Brilliantly witty, deflecting the conversation. I waited, interested in what kind of frosting she would put on this lie. For Scarlett's one tell, if it could be called that, was that she always had to go the extra mile.

“It’s pizza,” she said, as though confiding something to me. “But I don’t want to discourage this sort of thing, so I’d better eat it. Stand by, though, for the next one?”

It’s difficult to describe how Scarlett’s lies made me feel. It was a delicate mixture of intense pain, weep-worthy sadness, and scorching arousal that made me get an erection, right there in the afternoon in my office, amid heaps of contracts.

My chest was cool and constricted as I breathed into the phone: “Oh yeah. You better not discourage them.”

“Thanks, though.”

Scarlett’s voice almost cracked at the end, and I felt the hot breath of vindication on my neck. She felt guilty.

“I’ll see you around nine?” Scarlett said. “Did you start working on something?”

I hadn’t, but I laughed like I had. *You caught me*, my chuckle said. “See you around nine,” I said slowly. “Don’t work too hard.”

My heart went soaring across the universe as I waited for her reply. Would she tell me she loved me, her voice hollow, pouring vinegar on my wounds? Maybe she would start to cry, break down and finally tell me.

“K. Oh! Gotta run. Bye.”

A wave of rage washed over me when the phone clicked in my ear, the plastic of the cradle snapping sharply as she set it down. And then the cool fingers of jealousy, slipping up and over my balls, gripping them, squeezing life into my cock, even while my heart fell back down to earth with a painful thud.

*

I already had my laptop out, my HM app open. I spun to the right in my chair and stared at the screen, my thumb to my lip.

The empty columns began to fill, a faint beep notifying me of their arrival in real time. No more than a few seconds passed from when she hung up with me and the messages began to fly, from her to Alessandro:

I’ll be there a little late.

I stared at the message. Booooring.

I need to confess, at this point, that nothing Scarlett had done, nothing I had uncovered, was perfectly damning evidence. Taken together, though, the clothes and the lies, the texts and the suspicious behavior, all *pointed* to Scarlett having an affair. Sometimes I wondered if I wasn't losing my mind a little, imagining things that weren't there, things that weren't happening...

As usual, my thoughts spiraled the same way:

What if she's just innocently meeting someone for tennis lessons or something else, and this isn't even Alessandro? What if it is Alessandro and they've just decided to be friends?

But what about the evaporating messages?

Maybe that's an accident, and she doesn't even know they're doing that?

What about the lies?

Maybe she doesn't want you to think she's having an affair, so she didn't want to tell you she's just being friendly. Maybe she thought you would pressure her into an affair.

There was always a brief silence in my head for a moment when I got to this point, while I circled around the thought I disliked as much as I loved, that I pulled toward me like a pyromaniac does a hot coal, letting it burn me while I gazed at its incredible potential:

Oh yeah? What about the birth control, then?

And as usual, with that single thought, that reminder, I was brought down to earth like a crashing plane, attempting to land, the truth inevitable as the fire in one engine: my wife was cheating on me, and she was lying about it, and there was no acrobatic feat of the mind that could get around this one, big, lie:

The birth control.

After purchasing the house, and after Scarlett concluded her affair with Alessandro in France, we had decided to take the plunge and start trying to have a baby. Scarlett tossed her Nuva-Ring, and we proceeded to await the day when she would tell me she was expecting and our lives were changed forever.

I started suspecting her affair with Alessandro long before I made the discovery that she was renewing her prescription, but once discovered, there was really no denying to myself that she was fucking him.

Scarlett had a prescription for Ventolin, a pretty standard inhaler prescribed to people with mild to moderate asthma. Scarlett hadn't used her

inhaler in the entire time I'd been married to her, so I probably wouldn't have even been able to tell someone she had asthma. But forest fires had made the air smokey, she caught a cold, and she had gone to her doctor to renew the prescription. Then she had lost the inhaler and called me to ask me to pick one up on my way home, one Saturday night when she seemed to legitimately be working late, because the pharmacy would be closed the next morning.

So I had. Except that I had just asked the pharmacist to renew Scarlett's prescription, assuming there was only one in question.

It was a sunny Saturday, the pharmacy droning the same kind of whitewashed jazz that might mingle in with Katherman & Sanchez's sanitized Tejano tunes. The pharmacist, a middle-aged white woman with a stern expression and Brillo-pad of hair, screwed her face up to ask me:

"Now, that's the Levora, or the Ventolin?"

I blinked slowly, and the pharmacist, who was impatient in the way that only pharmacists can be, waited only half a second before giving me a look she reserved for all idiots who did not know their drug names, before saying: "Levora's the birth control, Ventolin's the inhaler."

I am, admittedly, not a man who knows much about birth control, but I am a man who at least remembered that I had agreed with my wife to stop using birth control, and that the name of the birth control she was using was not Levora.

But I am also a lawyer, and though I am not a courtroom lawyer, I am able to keep my shit together when someone throws me a curve ball, because believe it or not, this has happened once or twice in high-stakes contract law.

"The... Ventolin," I managed to say.

She tapped away and used her eyes to direct me to a seat to wait.

I only had about five minutes, breathing heavily and probably sweating, to contemplate my next move. Levora, Levora... I took out my phone.

A pill. A low-estrogen birth control pill.

Had I heard this wrong?

No, I hadn't heard it wrong.

My skin was turning hot and red, the heat creeping up the side of my face. My chest was crushed by an invisible fist inside of me, and it was tightening its grip.

“Greene,” another pharmacist said lazily.

I wiped my brow. This woman was blonde, younger, and slightly less hardened into the pharmacist mold. Her brow furrowed. “Are you feeling all right?” she asked me.

“I think I might be coming down with something,” I gasped. She took a step backward and her hand twitched as I took the bag from her. She held my debit card like it was covered in piss.

“I’m just thinking,” I said, looking at the wall of bottles behind her, “I might get in big trouble if I got the wrong thing...I’m sure she said Ventolin, but can you do me a favor and check and see when she refilled that Levora prescription. She’d kill me if I got it wrong.”

I got an annoyed stare for what felt like an eternity, but then she spun the bag around and started tapping on her computer. “Looks like she refilled it last week with the Ventolin, too. She called and said she lost the inhaler and you would be picking it up.”

I looked at her blankly, my head swimming, my heart pulverizing, blood rushing so loudly in my ears I had to lip-read the rest:

“The Ventolin is the right one.”

I’m not sure if I thanked her.

Probably not.

*

An ordinary man might have confronted his wife about this, but I am not an ordinary man. I am a deeply perverse man, and I instead dug into the internet, titillating myself with the information about the pill my wife had chosen. I took to searching for her hiding place for the pills, which I didn’t discover.

Then I mused about how devious she was, my Scarlett.

Nuva-Ring would have been a no-go, because I would have felt the ring inside of her. But a pill, a low-dose pill like Levora, she could easily hide.

This was the kind of exquisite pain I secretly enjoyed: Scarlett, each day at some appointed time, taking a tiny pill, choosing to continue the lie to her husband. It was like having someone apply a lemon zester to the inside of my chest, while rolling my balls around in their mouth.

So back in my office. I waited for the messages, and then finally, some action.

CHAPTER 3

A map on the right-hand side of the HM dashboard showed me Scarlett's location. I watched it blink away, moving slowly, some tremendous delay occasionally freezing it in improbable locations. Until at last, at 4:45pm, her phone, and presumably Scarlett herself, blinked from the sweeping curve of road and green square on the map, delineating the boundaries of the Mountain Vista Country Club.

Where Katherman & Sanchez, rag-tag labor lawyer team of feisty women, almost certainly would not even consider, let alone be able to afford, having any kind of meeting about anything at all.

But where tennis lessons, and so much more, were quite willingly provided by one tall, athletic, meat-headed Italian.

Just to fuck with Scarlett – or perhaps with myself – I took out my phone and sent her a message. I watched my own words materialize on the HM dashboard, my own phone number in the sender column, the time stamp seconds after I sent it.

“Amazing,” I said, really in awe of the technology.

Last chance. I could still bring you something.

I stared at the screen, seeing through the words and columns, times and dates. I pictured Scarlett, sitting in her car, reading my message.

What expression did she wear when she read a message from me at a time like this? Did she frown, and furrow her brow guiltily? Was Scarlett brought nearly to tears by her lying, cheating treachery? Did she think twice about what she was going to do?

Or was she a horrible, slutty bitch, who laughed at the message, or worse yet, rolled her eyes? Was she indifferent, her lips in a pout, a shrug tossed off her shoulders as she tossed the phone back into her purse?

I was left to imagine it all, because Scarlett, my cheating, whoreish wife, perhaps in an effort to be realistic, and perhaps because she was already dripping wet and gagging for Alessandro's cock, never wrote back to that message.

I fiddled with my contracts until six o'clock.

You might be wondering why I didn't get in my car, and drive to Mountain Vista, catch my wife at whatever she was doing, and get this all over with. Or why I didn't, say, leave her a note on the steering wheel: *I know what you're doing*.

I don't have all the answers.

The truth was, I didn't *want* Scarlett to find out that I knew she was having an affair. For the same reason I kept the birth control quiet, and jerked off in the shower thinking about how she was popping her pill every morning. I *enjoyed* raking myself over the coals like this. Somehow, the anguish fed the thrill I got from it all.

So I didn't drive to Mountain Vista. Instead, I went home, parked my car in the garage, got into some comfortable sweatpants, and took out my laptop, to enjoy whatever spectacle of messages would come through while Scarlett conducted her affair this evening.

I watched some porn while I waited, because I had discovered some delightful videos that included a dark-haired man banging the fuck out of a blonde who somewhat looked like Scarlett, and with the volume off I could almost pretend it was her, letting Alessandro fuck her ass raw.

He had used these exact words when he had fucked her in France, with me hiding behind a closet and staring at his long, veined cock sinking into my wife's ass, sawing in and out of her tender little peach of a bottom, stretching her asshole to a red, engorged gape.

After all, if Alessandro and my wife were out together, they would not be sending each other any messages. If tonight was like other nights, she would meet him at the club, where they presumably had some kind of legitimate contact with each other, and then they would travel to another location.

I assumed this was the location of Alessandro's apartment, based on Google street view. Other places, I had checked out. Sometimes they went to dinner, though not very often. Sometimes they just stayed at the club, which indicated to me that Scarlett wasn't fully committed to her affair, that she felt guilty enough about it that she wanted to resist it occasionally, or at least lie to herself that she wasn't doing it *this time*, or anymore.

Back to the point. I jerked off to this video, assuming it would be a while before any juicy tidbits came through to me from the HM app. I took a break, and saw Scarlett's phone was moving, heading toward Alessandro's

house. I stared at it on the screen, got up to make myself a drink, and came back to my computer in the office, planning to stare at the blinking phone as it glowed from the block where Alessandro lived, for half an hour, an hour, maybe an hour and a half, while my wife sucked on his cock and spread her legs and took his whole fat shaft in her pussy, and probably her ass, moaning and sweating and rolling around on his sheets.

Then I would watch her returning, and she would come through the door, smelling like a fresh shower, a foreign soap beneath the reapplication of her new perfume, her panties and nylons carefully rearranged on her body. Often they were a different pair, a pair that had not been torn off by Alessandro, a pair without stains from his cum. I wondered how she pulled it all off.

When she got home, the game would begin again: maybe tonight I would try to have sex with her, and she would relent, or she would not let me. I loved it either way: her reasons for not having sex were elaborate, her maneuvers to hide the evidence of just having fucked Alessandro were equally interesting. Sometimes she came home and threw herself at me, so I wouldn't have time to turn on the lights. Sometimes she got right to work sucking my cock, swallowing my cum (it was never a very long affair, when I was this worked up), and then claimed to not want me to reciprocate.

I enjoyed watching her squirm out of that scenario immensely.

I took a sip of my drink, and the alcohol caught in my throat, burning, when I saw that her phone was already moving. Traveling down Cerillos Road.

She turned on Sierra Drive.

Into our subdivision.

Well, well, well, I thought.

I wondered if maybe tonight was the night that Scarlett's conscience had finally gotten the better of her. Was she on her way home, tears streaming from her eyes, to tell me the truth and confess to being a cheating whore?

Except she thinks you're working late.

I was certainly happy with myself moments later, for having had that thought. It was that single thought that motivated me to rise from my den of porn and Highster Mobile, through the kitchen, where I stopped at the recessed bar partway in the kitchen and the living room, to pour myself a

glass of whiskey before walking to the foyer, where a long, warped glass window looked out to the front.

And it was only because I was there, and not in my office, that I saw the bent and distorted image of Alessandro's car, not our Camry. It rolled up to the curb, paused, and then moved on, so I scurried to the living room to peek out from behind the Venetian blinds to the street.

Alessandro's car came to a stop at the end of the street.

Alessandro emerged first, but the passenger door opened and my wife's navy pumps, followed by her long, lean legs, tumbled from the car.

"Jesus," I said. I jumped back, and my whiskey spilled over the edge of the glass.

My heart was pounding wildly.

"Fuck," I whispered. "Fuck, fuck, fuck."

I scanned the house. No time. What should I do? What were *they* doing?

Some reptilian part of my brain took over for me, even while my analytical brain was struggling to keep up with the times. Reptilian-brain made my legs move, taking me back to the office, turning off the light, pushing the door mostly closed (but not all the way), ensconcing my body beneath the desk, whiskey all the while in hand.

Analytical brain caught up as I sat there, trying not to pant like a wild boar, listening to my wife enter through the front door.

Not the garage.

She would not see my car.

I heard her giggle, then I heard the dull muffle, the clatter of shoes, the occasional wet smack – the sounds of two people mashing against each other, kissing, groping, moving clumsily toward the hall.

I couldn't see anything from beneath the desk in the room I used as an office. The desk had a modesty panel almost all the way to the floor. I curled up and pressed my head to the floor, but all I got for my trouble was a view of their shadows as they tumbled past the door.

Holy shit.

Holy shit.

I heard Scarlett's voice, murmuring sexily but insistently, the words unintelligible.

It was followed by the low rumble of Alessandro's voice.

Then quiet, a sticky, wet quiet as their lips met and their skin slapped together. They banged into a wall so hard that the whole house shook.

I crawled out from under the desk, my heart pounding. A weird calm was taking over my body, and I started to get the tunnel vision I had gotten before, in France.

After all, this was my house. My wife. If I got caught as I walked toward her and her lover, that was her problem, not mine.

Not that I wanted to get caught. I knew that I didn't.

I wanted to see what they were doing.

It was almost too lucky, so lucky that I wondered in the back of my mind if my wife hadn't actually been planning this all along, giving me a thrill, taking me for a ride, and then coming home so that I could catch her in the act with Alessandro.

And then I heard his voice, as I approached the office door, very distinctly. The baritone was emanating from the guest bedroom.

"Gattina, this is not your bedroom. I want to fuck you in your bed."

I heard Scarlett scoff. It was a familiar sound, one she reserved for absolutely stupid ideas.

There was a silence, and I was left to imagine what Scarlett was doing. Was she shaking her head? Chewing on her lip, her eyes lighting up with fear?

Whatever Scarlett was doing, her panther of a lover seemed to be purring. "Gattina, gattina, gattina," he was saying. His words were rolling my cock out like a drawbridge.

And then no more words.

I leaned against the wall to peer out the gap in the partially open door, but my view was of the dark blue-green hallway, a flickering shadow from down the hall. I could hear them moving in the guest bedroom.

I didn't hesitate, not even to think about all of the poor outcomes in this situation. I didn't want them to know I was there, but I was not particularly afraid of getting caught, so my pulse was wild only with anticipation and desire, not fear or nervousness. The thrill was unparalleled. It was almost like playing a video game, but a very real one.

The folding closet door in the guest bedroom rattled and creaked with the sound of their bodies smashing into it. I heard Scarlett complain, but half-heartedly, and then more negotiation between them. Scarlett was saying "no," and Alessandro was egging her on to do something. I assumed

it was sexual, having forgotten by then what he had said to her just moments before.

I stopped about two feet from the doorway to the guest bedroom. It was open, the lights off, the room fairly dark on the inside with the blinds drawn. I could hear their breath, the brushing of their skin against each other, the rumple of clothing and sheets as they moved just feet away from me.

The bed took on some weight. It was an old piece, and the real wood creaked when someone lay down in it. My heart filled my throat as I waited to hear it sawing away, but instead I heard Alessandro's deep, masculine exhale, followed by a wet sound.

At first it could have been anything, but the wet sound turned to a clear sucking noise, and then an even clearer gagging sound. This went on for what seemed like an eternity, and then I heard Alessandro's voice, strained with the force of a building orgasm.

"Yeah, gattina, suck it, take it all the way in, suck on my cock, *cagna...*" He inhaled sharply and let out a string of filthy sounding cusswords as the sucking sound turned to unfiltered sloshing. As I listened, I stepped closer to the doorframe, and slowly rolled my head around until I caught a glimpse of precisely what I wanted to see and no more:

Alessandro's head was out of the view I took in, and Scarlett was facing his cock, on her knees, her mouth stuffed full of his thick meat until her lips were stretched. He had his fingers buried and wound in her hair, using her head like a toy, pushing and pulling her on his cock as his abdomen strained and twitched. Scarlett was straining to look up at him, making the eye contact I knew he demanded of her. He thrust his cock deep into her throat and pushed her head down to his pelvis as his thighs tensed and he groaned loudly, yelling something in Italian and bursting inside of my wife's mouth.

"Show it to me, *cagna*, open your mouth and show me before you swallow."

His meaty tennis arm, a fibrous, veined mass, pushed her head back and she opened her mouth obediently. I could not see his face, but he leaned forward, and I knew he was peering into her throat to see a ball of his white cum nestled in the soft pink of her throat.

He drew a finger over her lips and rose to standing, drawing his still-hard cock over her mouth. I gaped at my wife, her blue eyes open and

gazing at Alessandro's face, seeking approval. The last thing I saw, before I realized that they would soon catch sight of my profile along the edge of the door, was Alessandro slapping her lips with his thick cock as she blinked up at him. A spray of cum, like spit, splashed over her face, probably into her eyes.

"No, no, no, gattina, not yet," I heard him purr.

My wife made a sound I had never heard, nor imagined her making, a sort of whining complaint sound, with a hint of something pornographic in it.

"You want me to fuck you and make you come, gattina? Hmm?"

I don't know why I had the presence of mind to start moving backward, staring into the hallway, my vision pulsing and turning the light green, as though I had just come in from outside. But I stepped backward, slowly, deliberately, the image of my wife's face being splattered with cum from Alessandro's slapping cock burning across my field of vision.

"Alessan-" my wife whispered.

Alessandro growled something I could not hear. Scarlett started to say something and then gasped, and I heard their bodies move again as I picked up the pace of my retreat. They were coming back to the hallway.

I ducked back into the office and pushed the door to the same degree of openness it had been at before.

Their footsteps, their meshing bodies, and Scarlett's decreasingly protesting sounds, came close, and then suddenly moved away. Their footsteps were heavy and prominent, wet kissing sounds beneath their drum. Headed away, past the guest bedroom.

There was only one thing in that direction.

Our bedroom.

"Ale-" I heard my wife say. "He could come home at any minute."

"Shh, shh," Alessandro was saying over her voice. There was a pause. "*That's* what I thought. *That's* what you like."

The next few minutes happened in both slow-motion, and in quick flashes that made it seem as though mere seconds transpired. I was both intensely there, and somehow floating above it all.

I moved down the hallway, after waiting a certain amount of time I could never, ever guess about – long enough that they were fully involved again by the time I got there, not long enough that it was over.

My ears were throbbing, blood having pressurized in my body to such a degree that I was practically deaf, the tinny ring like a waterfall in my ears. My vision was acute and narrowed, blurry and sharp, as I moved without feeling my feet to the door of our bedroom.

Our bedroom.

It was open to the hallway. The large, floor-to-ceiling windows that let out to the back porch were open as well, any neighbor on the second floor of the house backing our lot could have had an eyeful of what I saw, vaguely reflected in the glass: Alessandro's chiseled chest, swaying back and forth as he hammered into my wife. His thighs obscured by her ass, her body bent over submissively, chest against the sheets – *our sheets* – taking her lover's thrusts with mewls of pained pleasure.

From where I stood, I could see Alessandro's great, thick thighs, strained in a crouch, his ass rolling forward and back, his cock stickily plunging into the center of my wife's ass. I stared at his phallus, stretching her open and sawing into her silky back door.

He pummeled her for a while, and then slowed suddenly, drawing the tremendous length of his dick slowly out, then dipping in at leisure, as Scarlett mewled into the sheets, grasping at them wildly and bunching them up in her fists.

Alessandro had her by the hips, and she was like a rag doll as he pulled and pushed her however he chose to. Her only reaction was to howl or moan, depending on the speed with which he fucked her.

"Such a little slut," he breathed, putting a hand on her ass and pulling one cheek away from his sawing dick to watch himself plunging into her. "You like it in the ass, don't you, little *cagna*?"

Scarlett didn't respond, but Alessandro did not seem to care. "Oh yeah, that's what you like, you little whore. Are you ready to get all filled up? Can you take it if I fuck my cum into your little buco. Hmm?"

Scarlett tossed her head on the bed.

"Do you want to come, you little slut?"

"Yes," Scarlett panted, her voice begging and submissive.

"If you want to come then you need to bounce on my cock and get all filled up." He reached forward for her hair and pulled her up to her hands and knees, crawling forward on our bed. He leaned back on his heels and drew Scarlett into a sitting position on his lap.

“Oh!” Scarlett gasped. In the window, her tits bounced and her pussy glistened, and I could see the pink column of Alessandro's cock as she bounced and bounced on his dick.

He slid his hands to her breasts and pinched her nipples, making her gasp. She bounced harder, howling now, and Alessandro leaned back on one hand, his face smug, letting her ride him. She was sweating, desperate to come, and moved wildly to get him off. At last he gripped her hip with one hand and thrust up, deeper inside of her, pulling her against his pelvis as he yelled loudly.

He thrust up inside of Scarlett three times, depositing the last squirts of his load into her ass, before pushing her forward and flipping her like a rag doll onto her back. When his cock slid out of her ass a squelch of cum erupted from inside.

“You want to come now, gattina? Have you been a good enough little slut? Hmm?”

“Please,” Scarlett begged him. Through Alessandro's legs I could see her soaked pussy, throbbing with desire, and her distended asshole, closing up, cum leaking onto the sheets.

It was at this point – disappointingly not until this moment – that I remembered I had a phone in my possession, because it vibrated against my thigh.

Scarlett was spreading her legs, panting, her face almost tortured with her need for release. She drew her hand down to her pussy but Alessandro smacked it away. “Not yet,” he said, holding his cock in his hand, moving his grip up and down his shaft, his gaze on my wife and her suffering.

My hand was steady as a rock as I took the phone out of my pocket and filmed the final minutes of this scene: Alessandro pushing my wife's legs, one by one, up to her ears. Alessandro taking his time as she moaned and looked down at his hands, as he dipped his fingers into her gaping asshole and then back to her mouth, making her suck his cum from them before he finally slipped his free hand into her pussy and her ass, two fingers in each hole, and rubbed her clit with his thumb until her legs shook violently and her back arched, and the juices from her pussy and ass squelched and spurted onto our sheets.

Alessandro watched my wife come with amusement, smiling at her gaping holes, all his seed spilling from inside of her, her smeared makeup and her utterly destroyed hair. All of it oozing onto the sheets of our bed.

I was so transfixed by the scene that I almost remained there, filming, until they turned to look at me. Scarlett's shaking legs floated down, and Alessandro pulled his hand from inside of her. There was a brief moment as she shuddered on the sheets, still racked by her orgasm, but she ended it abruptly, gasping and turning on her side to look at the clock.

I was already retreating, the phone still capturing video but being tucked into my pocket.

I tucked into the office and stood behind the door, my chest heaving and my heart kicking me so hard I was a little concerned I would have a cardiac event.

"We have to go," Scarlett kept repeating. Alessandro had a calm, casual drawl as he evidently did not hurry as requested. "I thought he was working late," he purred.

"Seriously, Ale, get up. Get moving..." Scarlett's feet thumped in the master bedroom, her voice growing distant as she disappeared into a closet, or the bathroom. She sighed with exasperation. "Sheets, sheets."

Alessandro said something else, and she shot at him like a machine gun. "Okay. You know what? Get up, get your clothes on. We don't have time for this. I need your help with the sheets. Go, move."

Another sigh, and I could almost see her, staring at the sodden sheets, unsure of what to do to cover her tracks. Would I suspect something if the sheets were new? Would I notice?

Thinking about her racing thoughts at that moment made my cock almost explode.

To enhance my fun, I sent her a text.

[Me]: *Almost home, you want anything from Cela's?*

Cela's was a block away, a small grocery store with a killer takeout deli where we bought most of our midweek groceries. The question was ingenious: it was a common request, above any kind of suspicion, and it would make her think I was less than five minutes away.

I heard her phone ping, her footsteps thunder into the guest bedroom. "Fuck. Go. Go.. leave that."

"You want me to leave it -"

"Just. Go. In the car. Now. He's coming home. Go!"

I stared at the wall in front of me as my unflappable wife Scarlett scurried down the hallway of her own house, probably slipping into her clothes and pulling her back, wild-eyed, her mind racing, her footsteps panicked, her voice shattered.

And me?

I was getting off on it like I have never gotten off on anything in my whole life.

The door slammed so hard it shook the house.

There is a thrill I think it might be next to impossible to describe, in calmly exiting one room of your house to walk, slowly, down the hall to your own bedroom and survey the rumpled sheets of your own bed, where your wife just let another man fuck her in the ass. A thrill of a very particular kind in leaning down and swiping a finger over a wet spot, bringing it to your nose, and inhaling the scent of what they had just done: metallic ass, briny cum, and honey-sweet pussy.

I pulled out my phone, replayed the brief video I had taken, which was blurry and dark and probably unintelligible as porn to anyone but me. I held it in my left hand while I jerked off with my right, spraying my cum all over the sheets that Scarlett would have to find some way to explain.

After I came, I probably would have felt empty, but the pain that usually rose up inside of me when I jerked off to thoughts of Alessandro and Scarlett these days did not come: maybe precisely because I still had more delicious infidelity, more lies and more squirming coming my way.

And I planned to fuck Scarlett tonight in the one hole Alessandro hadn't, until she couldn't walk.

CHAPTER 4

Scarlett had sent me a message about one minute after she left.

I sat down in the office, zipping up my pants, thinking ahead to what Scarlett might do to avert disaster, intrigued that the blip on the screen did not seem to be headed to the club.

I raised my eyebrows, and looked at the text she'd sent me, as displayed by Highster Mobile.

[Scarlett]: *Are you still there? I am desperate for a salad.
Does your offer to bring something by still stand?*

Clever, clever girl.

I was relieved Scarlett was thinking so quickly on her feet. Oh sure, I was angry, but I was also relieved, because now this game could continue. She seemed to have a plan to save herself, which meant that I might get to enjoy the sweet pain of her affair even longer.

I can go back, I typed, deliberately cryptic. I hoped she was biting her nails to the quick, wondering if I was in the house right now, headed down the hallway. Would I see the sodden sheets? She had hastily thrown them across the bed the way they might have been in the morning – even I didn't know. All she had to do was wait for them to dry, and she stood a chance of me not knowing what she had done.

[Scarlett]: *Yes please. Do you mind bringing it?*

I looked at the blip on the screen.

She wasn't taking any chances. She had Alessandro driving her to her office. It was a clever scheme, because her car, if it were there, would be in the small lot in the back, blocked from view by the other buildings that shared it. I wouldn't notice that it wasn't there unless I went looking for it, which in Scarlett's game world, I had no reason to do.

She would turn on the lights in her office, pretend to be working, and accept my salad.

And if I suspected nothing, as I had no reason to, I would give it to her and let her get back to work.

And by the time I got home, the sheets would be dry.

I smiled.

Surely there was more to her plan than that.

No problem, I wrote. The usual from Cela's?

There was a long, beautiful pause, which I savored and filled with images of Scarlett kissing Alessandro goodbye, or swatting him away and shame-walking up to the front door of the darkened building where she worked. The blip was at her office now, glowing with her lies.

[Scarlett]: *Right-o. The usual.*

This, I knew, was Scarlett being funny: I didn't remember her "usual" anything. I waited, smiling a pained smile, thinking about how devious my wife was, how diabolical to be sending me these cute messages just ten minutes after letting herself be utterly violated in *our bed*.

[Scarlett]: *Mixed greens and some kind of creamy dressing on the side*

A flash of her throat full of cum filled my head, as I typed, *OK*, and strolled to the car.

It seemed to have been Alessandro's idea to come back to our house, though I wondered what had transpired that led them there, as opposed to their usual love nest. Scarlett had been resistant to fucking in our bedroom. Not resistant *enough*, but I had gotten the impression it hadn't been her idea.

Alessandro seemed to hold some kind of power over her: power to get her to subjugate herself to him, to bend to his will and humiliate herself. Power to get her to do things she would never do with me, to violate the oaths of our marriage and the unspoken rules about her having an affair with him, and to take wild, terrible chances.

Even more confusing to me, though admittedly erotic: she seemed to love being fucked in the ass, slapped by his cock, having her hair pulled, thrown about like a rag doll.

She *liked* being treated like a cheap whore. That much was obvious from the scene I had just witnessed, and it turned me on.

Was that the appeal? I knew I couldn't give that kind of physical relationship to her: I could engage in some rougher sex, or have too many drinks and get a little wild, but I couldn't manhandle her like Alessandro, or convincingly call her a whore, and I definitely couldn't make her show me a glob of cum in her throat. It just didn't... fit.

This awful and delightful cocktail of emotions brewed inside of me as I drove to her office. I was so caught up in my thoughts about Scarlett's mindset, that I was five minutes into my drive – which is halfway to anywhere in Santa Fe – when I realized that I hadn't even stopped to get the salad.

I sighed. Even if this was all just an elaborate ruse, I needed to keep up the appearance of *my* ruse. Back I went.

What was she doing right now? Was she frantically cleaning herself up in the office bathroom? Tapping her pen against her desk and plotting her next move? Did she feel guilty for what she had just done, guilty for having sex in our bed? Did she feel guilty for lying and cheating?

Or was it as thrilling to her to lie to me, as it was to me to hear her lies?

The possibility existed that Scarlett was just as perverse as I was. What if *she* was the one who wanted to flirt with danger by fucking at our house?

Would that be all that bad?

After all, her first affair with Alessandro had been done with my blessing. She probably didn't think she really had that much to lose if I found out.

My heart sank a little, strangely enough, upon having this realization.

Alessandro, after all, had turned out to be a chickenshit in France. He had run like a baby gigolo when I had appeared in the hotel room. Would *he* really be so bold as to play tonight's game, to run the risk of being caught again?

When I thought of things that way, it made more sense that Scarlett was the one driving the riskier aspects of this affair. But I didn't know for sure.

And curiously enough, I *enjoyed* not knowing. After all, it would have been a simple matter to actually find out. I didn't take that step – of simply

confronting my wife – and it wasn't because I was shocked by her affair.

It was because I liked the way jealousy and the unknown coiled inside my gut; I loved to read her messages and watch her flounder to cover up her anal sex, and the perverse matings with Alessandro.

I pulled up to the law offices of Katherman & Sanchez. It was a duplex building, converted from an old house. The light brown adobe exterior was framed by tasteful, arid landscaping: wild grass, small native shrubs, and rocks. The adjoining offices belonged to a cheap car insurance company. Most of the two businesses' clients were shared.

The lights blazed inside Katherman & Sanchez. I texted Scarlett.

[Me]: *I'm here.*

I parked, skipped up the steps, and waited at the front door.

I was impressed with my wife when she opened the door for me. She looked exactly as she had this morning: mauve lipstick, hair neatly piled on her head, hose and sensible navy pumps in perfect order. Somehow her blouse was wrinkle-free, the lacy bra notwithstanding.

She answered the door unhurried, smiling with what looked like relief.

It was fake, and I knew that, so the expression looked more perturbed than relieved, but – had I not known all that I knew – I would have found it to be a believable smile from a salad-craving woman whose husband had just saved the day with some vegetables.

"Thank god," she said, swinging the door open for me and reaching for the salad. "That pizza was *awful*."

It was some act.

Really.

Some act.

The performance was seamless. I almost doubted myself for a moment, or that I had seen what I had seen.

Maybe I *was* losing it, imagining things, totally nuts.

"Where from?" I asked, referring to the pizza. Playing my part.

"Huh?" she said, peering into the salad container even though it was transparent.

"The pizza," I said calmly, studying her face. "So I don't ever order from there," I added.

I didn't want to seem suspicious. I just wanted to rattle her a little.

Scarlett took a carrot stick from the top of the salad and bit into it. "You never order pizza," she countered, a smile on her face. She was leaning playfully against the door, smiling at me over the carrot.

Wow, I thought. She was really something.

I stood with my hands in my pockets, waiting for Scarlett to make the next move. I wondered what her plan was: clearly she had summoned me here to her office to get me out of the house, away from our cum-stained sheets. Now that she had accomplished that mission, what was her next move? Would she send me home, and pretend to work late, and hope that the sheets simply drying out would be enough to cover her tracks? She would be relying on my lack of observation, and perhaps suspecting that I wouldn't go straight to bed. It was quite a gamble, but I probably underestimated how little I noticed.

When I wasn't suspicious.

Scarlett looked at me, and batted her eyes a little. "You want to come in? I can offer you a cup of really good coffee. Suzanne brought it back from Costa Rica."

"You keep any whiskey in this joint?" I asked, weighing my options, trying to think ahead of Scarlett. Did she expect me to say yes? Where would she go from there?

Or did she expect me to say no?

Either way, she would have a plan for it. Scarlett was way too quick a thinker, and I could tell by the gleam in her eyes, the playful way she was swinging the door lightly with her hips, that she was ready for whatever I volleyed back to her.

In fact, she had the same expression on her face that she did when she played against me at tennis. I could almost see her twirling a racket in her hands, slightly crouched, a smile on her lips, shifting from side to side, waiting.

"This is not Swanky and Swankier," she said, pushing away from the door and letting it swing toward me, scooting me into the building. "All we have is coffee. And leftover pizza. But you're in luck, because the coffee is good."

I followed her. There wasn't much of an option, the way she had swung the door at me. Also, I wanted to see where she was taking this.

I was leafing through my memories of the evening: she *had* gone to the club, I knew, and then she had arrived at our house in Alessandro's vehicle, after a brief stop at his place. The phone had traveled directly to the office from our house, so she couldn't have retrieved her car, whether it was at Alessandro's place or the club.

So what was she luring me into the office for?

Also, she was taking a big risk with this pizza offer.

I had my mouth open to ask for some of this "terrible pizza," and to watch her fall all over herself lying about it or making an excuse for why it wasn't there, but I stopped myself. For one thing, I didn't much like pizza, so she would be alerted to something being off. And she would not likely be able to cover up that lie, so then our game – her game – would probably have to come to an end.

Which, I realized yet again, was not what I wanted.

I followed her to the kitchen – a room behind the false walls built into the old home, which had been the real kitchen prior to the home's conversion. It was behind the last false wall that the refurbishing had ended; the kitchen was outdated, Formica-covered, and sported linoleum floors.

They did, however, have a gleaming stainless-steel espresso machine.

Scarlett started making me coffee, calm as a cucumber. Her hands did not shake as she measured the ground beans into the machine. She positioned a cup neatly under the drip and leaned lightly on the machine as she turned to me. "You all wrapped up on the Breck Co. thing?"

"Attorney-client privilege," I said, investigating a package of cookies on the counter. Italian. Very fancy. I wondered if all this crap was from Alessandro.

"What's with all the espresso and Italian biscuit action here?" I asked, biting into one of the biscuits. It was buttery, very European and fancy.

Scarlett blinked slowly. "The coffee is Costa Rican," she said, in a measured voice.

This was an awkward moment. Her response, as she knew, was a bit too defensive, and she had said it because the biscuits were Italian.

She recovered nicely, after a few beats of awkwardness. "We're trying to project a more cosmopolitan appearance," she quipped, turning back to the espresso machine to turn it off. "To ourselves. To take our minds off our reality." She fiercely unscrewed the portafilter and smashed it abruptly against the sink, dumping the coffee grounds.

“Should you...?” I asked, referring to the grounds in the sink.

“Good for the pipes,” she said, handing me my espresso. “That’s how you want it, right? I can make a latte, but... not very well. Also, I think the milk’s gone bad.” She gave me a sexy, jocular smile. “Your call.”

I accepted the espresso and took a sip, watching her as I did. She blew a stray lock of hair away from her eyes, and her fingers, resting on the countertop, tapped quickly in succession before she stopped them.

She was nervous.

“You’re not having one?” I asked.

“I’ve had like a hundred, my pulse is probably 180,” she answered quickly.

My mind blossomed, I saw a perfect opportunity, and I could not help but seize it.

“I thought you weren’t supposed to have caffeine, if you’re, you know, trying to get pregnant.”

I looked down to set my espresso on a tiny plate she had handed me, then looked up in time to watch her blanch, thrown off for just a microsecond. Her lips moved to say one thing, and then decided against it.

She turned to the counter and brushed her hair away quickly. “That’s been debunked. It’s not like alcohol, either.”

She turned back to me, leaning her hip suggestively against the counter. She had recovered fully from this blip and was back in her fine, lying form. “You want to have a seat, cowboy?”

“What do you mean, debunked?” I persisted.

Scarlett folded her arms across her chest. “Debunked. It’s not true. You can have caffeine and it’s fine. The study that’s based on was done in England in like the 70’s and the girls were all drinking coffee *and* smoking.”

“Huh.”

Scarlett squinted slightly at me. “Yeah. Huh. Here, have another biscuit.”

She took one and set it on the plate, then picked up her salad and walked to a small table at the end of the narrow kitchen and plopped down.

“I’d better -” I started to say, “I had better go,” but Scarlett interrupted me.

“Shoot. Can you bring me a fork? They’re in a drawer below the espresso machine.”

I set down my espresso cup and plate, and took a fork to her.

"Thanks," she said, beaming up at me. "Have a seat."

"Oh, I really have to... get home. I have a few things to do there."

I heard her shoe clatter to the floor, followed by the feel of her foot against my calf. "You could stay here and do it," she purred. "We could pull an all-nighter. It would be like back in law school."

Her words worked their way into my chest, and then burst into tendrils of seductive, nostalgic yearning. She was leaning on her hand, the fork swinging beneath her grip like a pendulum, a sweet smile on her face.

It was diabolical, whatever she was doing, I reminded myself. Trying to keep me here, to distract me from the physical evidence of her ass-fucking romp with her Italian lover, trying to seduce me with the good old times and an obvious promise of sex, in order to keep me from seeing the tangled, cum-stained sheets in our own bed.

What would she do when I said "no?"

At the same time, what would she do if I said "yes?" Her car could not possibly be here. If I stayed, what would she do when it was time to drive herself home?

"Hmm," I said, sounding tempted, because I was.

She crunched on a piece of salad.

"How much more do you have to do?" I asked, trying to sound innocent.

She shrugged. "I don't know. I guess... really I could just take it home, and come in early tomorrow for the rest." She rested her head on her hand, and played with her salad with the other. "I don't know why I didn't think of that."

I did.

But now, I didn't understand where she was going with this *at all*.

"So you want to go home?" I asked. I sounded genuinely confused, because I was genuinely confused.

"I know, I'm sorry I made you bring this salad all the way out here, but now that I think about it, I really need to take a break. I don't think I can just keep going straight through."

This was hardly plausible. Scarlett could stay awake for 165 hours if she needed to. Which she never did, because she thought and worked so fast, and was so good on her feet, that she didn't ever need that kind of time.

“So... you want to go home?”

Her foot moved up and down my calf again. “It could be more fun...” she said, seductively.

I didn’t need too much more than that to get myself all fired up again, and not thinking very clearly about anything but sinking into my wife’s cheating cunt.

“Sounds good,” I said. Through the pounding, blurry thoughts in my mind, I remembered she didn’t have her car. How *would* she make up for that?

“I’ll just... go home, then,” I said.

“Yeah. I’ll pack up and be right behind you,” she said.

I wavered a little. Did I want to put obstacles in her way, trip her up, make her plan not work? Or did I want to follow to where she was leading me, and then watch her scramble to enact her plan and cover up her lies?

What would she expect me to do? *Think, Will. Pretend that you don’t suspect anything or know anything. What would you do, right now?*

“You want me to wait for you?” I asked.

She folded up the salad box. “I mean, you can. I just have to pack up some stuff.”

“I’ll wait.”

Scarlett shrugged. This was a surprise. She didn’t care if I waited.

What could that mean?

How the hell was she going to cover up her car not being here?

“I’ll clean up the kitchen,” I said, still marveling at her.

“Great. Take this salad home, too, would you?” She stood up, smoothing out her skirt, and leaned down to kiss me.

It wasn’t an ordinary peck, but a very suggestive, very sensual kiss. She moved her mouth over my lips, pulling me closer to her, into her wet mouth, insinuating that there would be more where that came from. “I’ll be like five minutes.”

When she stepped away from me, she dropped her eyes to my crotch. The table hid my erection, but she smiled, as if she could see right through it. She *winked* at me as she walked into her office.

*

I sat down in the car in a huff. It was cold enough that I could vaguely see my breath. I didn't have my gloves, and the steering wheel was icy-cold. I blew on my hands, but it didn't take long for my car to warm up.

I had gone out the front door. Scarlett had gone out the back, to the parking lot.

I pulled up to the alleyway out of which her car would have to emerge. As I waited, lights off, on the side of the road, I pulled out my phone to load Highster Mobile. I was as caught up in her car retrieval plan as if she were a magician and I wanted to learn her tricks.

I squinted, and then stared, when Scarlett's car rolled out of the alleyway, in exactly the amount of time I would have expected it to take for her to go to the back alley and start her car.

Like it had been there all along.

I set the phone down and threw my car into gear as Scarlett turned into traffic. I took a different route, flipping a u-turn after she had gone around a slight bend in the road. I wanted to arrive first, now that this extra layer of intrigue had been thrown into the game.

How? How? How did she have her car?

I threw my glance down at the phone on the seat. I wasn't about to start reading my phone while I was driving, but the temptation was there... maybe when I stopped at the next light.

Yes. That would be it. There would be a tell-tale trail of messages between her and Alessandro, outlining her plan, explaining what was happening.

I had never before wanted two things so badly at the same time: to get home before Scarlett, and to look at my phone. The phone was pulling at my attention. I felt like a teenager, obsessed to the point that I couldn't wait, couldn't use my head to drive safely, I just *had to see*.

I ran a stop sign, the red of the sign flashing to the left of me and sending my heart into my throat. I slammed on the brakes, far too late for it to have made any difference, and then I snapped my attention to the road, breathing heavily.

"Jesus," I said. I had to focus on driving my fucking car.

It was scary enough that I gripped the wheel and drove home, still tempted to look at the phone, but thankfully frightened enough that I could wait.

In fact, I told myself, it was sometimes fun to wait.

Plus I wanted to get home ahead of Scarlett, or at the very least, at the same time, so I could make her squirm and flounder as I headed, most peculiarly, straight the bedroom with the crumpled, wet sheets, to change into some comfy clothes.

I hit all green lights, including the large, lengthy intersection across from our neighborhood, where I saw Scarlett come to a stop behind a van. This put me a full minute ahead of her. If I drove like a crazy person – which I did – I might have 90 seconds on her.

I floored it, tires squealing slightly as I turned corners, and I drove so fast toward the garage after I opened it that I almost scraped off the roof. I hastily parked the car, shaking, and gathered my things clumsily from the back seat before bursting into the kitchen tossing them aside, and practically running to the bedroom.

The lights were off, so at first, as I tumbled into the room panting, pulling at my shirt to begin the charade of getting undressed, I didn't understand what I was looking at.

A trick of the light, I thought, and I fumbled for the switch as I stared at the moonlit blue coverlet, smooth as glass, over the top of the bed.

I flipped the light on.

Made.

The bed was made.

I exhaled loudly, a sort of groan escaping my lungs.

Was I crazy? Was I actually losing my fucking mind?

I spun around, my eyes searching the walls and the ceiling, the door frame, the wood flooring, the fucking *air*, for some sign that I had gotten lost in another dimension.

Then back at the bed.

I shook my head.

This *had* happened.

It had.

I had filmed it, after all.

I fumbled in my pocket, looking for my phone, looking for confirmation.

I heard the garage door opening, the slow steady hum. I remembered closing it – good move – at the exact same time that I remembered I had left my phone in the seat next to me, in my hurry to get in.

The bedroom light was the only light on in the house, I realized next.
What the fuck was going on?

I could hear Scarlett's car.

Think, think, think.

I was totally thrown off my game. I just stood there, my eyes searching the room, as though the answer to the mystery would be found there.

No.

It would be found in the app, in her text messages, in what had transpired since I had gone to the office, while I was driving.

The door opened in the kitchen.

"Will?"

In the meantime... I needed to act normal.

Normal, normal, normal. What was normal?

Scarlett was turning on lights.

Coming my way.

I would not want anyone to think that the following thoughts occurred in linear succession, because it was more like an algae blossom of connected thoughts, manifesting as images and feelings, more like fight-or-flight than anything else. My Reptilian brain, though, really came through for me.

Scarlett will wonder what you're doing standing here, my brain told me. Scarlett will be alerted to the fact that you know. Scarlett would want to know how her ruse played out, however she managed to make it happen. You do not want that. You want to keep playing. You can figure this out later. Right now you need to do something plausible, normal, provide some reason for being in here, no lights on -

Lightning flashed through my head, and my limbs moved me quickly into the bathroom, shutting the door quietly. I locked it, and sat, panting, on the toilet seat.

"Will?" Scarlett called. She had arrived at the bedroom. I imagined her there, hanging on the door frame, surveying the made bed, her heart pounding, guilt eating away at her, fear still gripping her.

It was delicious.

"Will?"

"I'm in here," I called, and I was pleased that my voice sounded off, like I was ill.

It fit into my story so well.

"I just really had to go to the bathroom," I explained.

There was a pause, and steely fingers clawed at the insides of my heart as I pictured her, relief, perhaps, sliding over her features.

"Oh," she said. "You okay?"

"I'll be fine. Just... yeah. I'll be fine."

Another pause.

"Okay," she said, after another pause, deliciously full of possibilities.

"I'll leave you to it."

I heard her footsteps disappear down the hallway. Her shoes were still on, her heels clacking on the wood floor. She had certainly been in a hurry to get here, because even after nearly a year in Santa Fe, her Chicago habits did not die easily. Her shoes came off upon entering the house in winter, even if there was no snow.

Unless there was something pressing enough.

*

The evening proceeded more dully than Scarlett's suggestive whispers at the office might have indicated. I had to stay in the bathroom to calm myself down, and since it was under the pretext that I was feeling ill, it didn't work in my favor, sexually speaking. Scarlett came back into the room, and I heard her say she was just getting some sweats. Then she was gone, and when I came out, she had settled onto the floor of the living room, her feet folded under her, documents spread out on either side of her slim, sweatpants-covered legs.

"You okay?" she asked, looking up at me.

"Yeah," I said lamely. I was making some quick calculations: I had lied to Scarlett and told her I needed to work, as she had lied to me, and so there was no real choice, if we both wanted to keep our lies intact, but to "work."

Also, my ducking into the bathroom had sort of killed the mood.

And then, finally, there was this: I was *dying* to get on my computer, figure out what had happened this evening, and perhaps watch the video I had taken of Scarlett in bed with Alessandro.

"Must have been something I ate," I said.

“You going to bed?” She was looking back at her legal pad now, tapping a pencil on it.

“I have a few things to wrap up,” I said.

She looked up at me, smiling sweetly. “Okay,” she said. She beckoned me to her by extending her hand, flapping it open and closed.

I leaned over and kissed her. “Have a good night,” she breathed, close to my lips. My cock thickened, and I looked at her eyes. We stared at each other for a second. I couldn’t tell what she was after, or whether she was seducing me, so I stood up. “Okay,” I said. “I’ll just... go grab that stuff and be in my office. You want anything? From the kitchen?”

“Nah,” she said, yawning.

And she went back to work.

I grabbed my stuff out of the car – specifically, my phone, which was all I really needed. I had no intention of doing any more work than setting the box of files on my desk so that if Scarlett stopped by and opened the door, it would look like I was working instead of jerking off to her text messages and the video of her fucking Alessandro.

First things first. I was still in my work clothes.

I went back to the bedroom, and found something to change into, but I was more interested in *Scarlett’s* clothes. Where had she put them? Where were her stockings, was she wearing the same panties? Surely cum had leaked into them, surely she wasn’t still wearing them?

I searched the closet, and the hamper, and the drawers, and found only the stockings – smelling of her scent, just vaguely, and otherwise uncompromised – and her navy suit and blouse hanging in the closet with the other dry cleaning. I started to reach into the skirt, to turn it inside-out and find a stain of cum, but I could always do that tomorrow -

I turned around sharply. The sheets. Where were they?

I went back to the hamper, staring into it as though they might somehow be tucked away down there.

But they were not.

I swung my glance all over the room.

This *had been* a mess when I’d left here.

I knew that the only explanation that could possibly make sense was that Alessandro had been sent here to clean things up. It was lurking in the back of my mind all along, but it just seemed so... impractical. Impossible. Crazy.

And so very, very devious.

I went to the office and shut myself in. I still wanted to find those sheets, but more than that, I wanted some insight into how the arrangement was made for Alessandro, my wife's lover, to come back to the place where he'd ass-fucked my wife and clean it up.

Because one very painful truth about that scenario? It made my wife more calculating than I had ever imagined.

And it also meant that Alessandro did not hold all the power in their relationship. Scarlett had enough that she could send him on that errand, and wield it quickly, and count on him doing it.

How out of control could Scarlett be, then?

My chest was cinched tight when I collapsed into the chair. I opened my computer and felt like I hadn't taken a breath for three minutes as I waited for the Highster Mobile screen to materialize, to cough up its secrets.

There were delicious new messages since the last one from Scarlett. And, my favorite, the replay of her travels around town.

I chose the GPS first. Just to drag things out. Indeed, just as I had already seen, Scarlett went to the club, then to Alessandro's house, then to our house, then straight to her office.

I closed my eyes, my heart pounding, and then, enjoying it the way I enjoyed a drink after abstaining, or some horribly unhealthy and delicious food after dieting, I lifted my eyes to read the messages.

There was my last message to Scarlett, and Scarlett's reply, banal exchanges about her Cela's order.

And then:

[Scarlett]: *Go now*

Thirty-six minutes passed between that message and the next: enough time for me to drive for five minutes, turn around, go to Cela's, get a salad, drive to her office, and sit down in the dingy kitchen to talk.

[Alessandro]: *Done. Keys are under mat.*

It was all clear to me, then: I could see it all unfolding. All of it under the careful orchestration of my wife.

She texted back, a mere “*K thanks,*” ten minutes after the last message from Alessandro. Probably while she was getting into her car.

I pictured the entire scenario in my mind. Scarlett, thinking quickly, straightening herself out as she dropped into Alessandro’s car. She had panicked a little, rushed out the door, her eyes wild and her hair even wilder. But then she had pulled it together.

I could see her lowering the sun visor to look at herself in the mirror as she gathered up her hair, patting it neatly into place. Maybe she had wiped her face clean with a napkin, her mind working the whole time.

“This is what we’re going to do,” I could picture her saying to Alessandro.

She sent him to go back to the house as soon as she determined I was on the way to Cela’s. It was risky, but she had probably also instructed Alessandro to make sure I was gone.

And then... what? Had she given him the keys? Told him where the sheets were? Instructed him not to throw them in the hamper?

Yes. She would have thought of everything.

And he had done it.

My eyes drifted down the final message, from Alessandro to Scarlett, in response to her cold, “*K, thanks.*”

[Alessandro]: *Anything for my little gattina. I can smell you on my fingers.*

I almost felt a little sorry for Alessandro, who had received no reply to this message. In fact I guessed that Scarlett had rolled her eyes, composed her hair into an even tidier twist, looked herself in the eye in the rearview mirror, and then put her game face on to drive -

I closed my eyes.

The car.

How had her car been there?

The key is under the mat.

Ah yes. Scarlett would have thought it all through in milliseconds. She would beckon me to bring her a salad, in order to divert me from the house and give her time to be driven to her office. She sent her lover to clean up the house, and then to retrieve her car and park it at the office building while we were inside talking.

Smooth.

My heart was on a rollercoaster: sinking, flying, squeezing, cold and hot. She was such a liar, so hopelessly good at it, so sneaky and diabolical.

Yet – and this may seem very perverse – there was something sort of touching in the way she wanted to cover it up. She wouldn't do that if there wasn't something about it that she knew was wrong, or embarrassing.

A buddy of mine, who had ended up as a prosecutor, had tossed out one of those familiar legal adages that go around in the business, especially the criminal courts, where everyone likes to sum up all of human nature in one pithy statement so it doesn't strangle them with its complexity. It came back to me now, reassuring, if not necessarily the gospel truth:

No one bothers lying to you unless they care.

I stared at the screen full of messages, which was enough to give me a huge erection.

Then, even though Scarlett was right down the hall, even though I could get caught, I took out my phone and replayed the video I had taken that evening.

And, with the modesty panel as my only shield, I jerked off while I did it.

CHAPTER 5

“What do you think?”

Scarlett made a sexy pirouette, her lithe body like liquid in a black dress that clung to her every curve as though it had been dripped onto her. It was a long dress, but as she turned, I saw that a very long slit on the left side cut through the fabric all the way up to just below her ass.

Also, in the right light, it was practically see-through.

The neckline dipped low, and the loose, bunched fabric gave a nice view of the firm roundness of her breasts, and threatened with her every move to slip right off and show me her nipples. It was classy, because it had the expensive sheen of a pricey, designer dress.

But slutty, because...well, it was fucking painted on and see-through at times.

“That’s...” I said, unable to finish my sentence.

Scarlett stopped turning and approached me, her arms out to rest them on my shoulders.

She had gathered her hair in a very Old-Hollywood up-do, and her lips were painted red. I don’t know much about make-up, but she’d done it all in a way that made her look very Greta Garbo.

She puckered her lips, pouting. “It’s a costume party,” she said, a smile threatening to destroy her sultry facade. “You get to dress more slutty for those.”

I noticed, as she came closer to me, the dark brown beauty mark she had painted on her right cheek, over a small mole that was so faint, so peachy-cream colored, that I rarely remembered it was there.

“I just didn’t realize it was so... see-through,” I said.

Scarlett rolled her eyes. “It has fabric sewn in all the right places.”

“Don’t get me wrong,” I said. “You look hot.”

She primped her hair and winked at me. “I’m going to class it up by wearing gloves, too. Don’t forget that.”

I watched her saunter to the dresser and take out a pair of black satin gloves. She did a faux, reverse striptease for me as she put them on.

“Okay,” she said, putting her hands on her hips.

I pulled my jacket on, and she appraised my appearance. I could feel her eyes as they moved up and down my body.

Since she'd re-started her affair with Alessandro, I had to admit, I'd been a little more careful about what I was eating. I hadn't transformed into an Italian Adonis with a six-pack, but I had trimmed up a little.

"You look good," she said. "You're losing weight, aren't you?"

The question sent a little jolt through me, both of pleasure and of exhilaration. I didn't want her to suspect that I knew anything about her and Alessandro, so this made me nervous. But I liked that she was paying attention to me, looking at me lustfully.

She was close to me now, stepping slowly, one foot before the other to make her hips sway sexily. Her hands went to my tie, and I let my own hands drop so that she could tie it for me. I was wearing a pinstripe suit in my attempt to have a "costume." I had a fedora somewhere that I'd add to it.

This kind of kitschy shit just wasn't my thing.

Scarlett's fingers, instead of knotting the tie, slid the silk fabric out of the bend and then pulled it down. I felt it slide across the back of my neck, then fall to the floor. She kept her eyes locked on mine, her movie star makeup sweet-smelling and alluring.

We were almost going to be late for the party as it was, and because it was Dan and Marie's party, it would be more offensive than I wanted to be.

"We're running late," I managed to breathe, but that was all I was able to say, because Scarlett's lips were so very close, and her fingers were working their way down my shirt, flicking the buttons open.

She brushed her lips over mine, playfully, and her hand plunged into my pants, her fingers searching for my cock, which was just now coming to life because this was so unexpected.

"We have time for a little quickie," she said, her fingers closing around me. I pulsed in her hand and she smiled. I leaned toward her, trying to catch her teasing lips with my own mouth.

She nudged me backward, then made me trip into the armchair in the corner. As she walked, she hiked up her paper-thin skirt, which seemed to roll up into a bunch of fabric she could hold in one hand, like a tissue.

As the final inches of material slid up her legs, and she rested her knees on the armchair, the scent of her pussy wafted toward me. I dropped my eyes to see that she had no underwear on, but the view was short

because she was already lowering herself onto my lap while one hand sought my zipper and freed my cock.

Her pussy encased me, her weight settling onto my lap. Her eyes were on mine as she leaned one hand on my shoulder and started to ride me.

I was so shocked I just stared at her as she rocked on top of me. She moved slowly, her eyes falling closed, her mouth partially open. She mewled, and began to fuck me faster.

Then she started to whisper to me. “That’s it, oh, fuck, deeper, oh, you feel so good...”

But with her eyes closed like that, her fingernails digging into my shoulder blade, and her whispered dirty talk, I felt like the woman milking my cock was not really my wife. I stared at her face, knowing that she was probably thinking of someone else, even with my cock deep inside of her.

She bucked wildly, her pussy clenched around me, and I felt the hot explosion of her bursting excitement around my dick. I seized her hips, because I was so close, and now I ached.

Her body went limp and she bounced on me, with my hands on her hips, as I fucked my cum inside of her.

She reanimated quickly, bringing her thumb to her mouth and biting into the flesh pad while smiling. She smoothed one loose strand of hair, and wiped lipstick from my lower lip.

Then she rose from on top of me and smiled, before going to her dresser and getting out a pair of black panties.

I knew a couple of things here: Alessandro and she had not communicated in two days, and I saw no evidence of them having hooked up in a week. My wife was beginning to miss him, I thought. And so she had fucked me to satisfy her yearnings, thinking about Alessandro even as she bounced on my cock.

Not that I was complaining.

I wondered if she had broken it off with Alessandro again. And if she had, if she would ever tell me about her affair. And if she didn’t, if I would ever confront her about it.

I felt a wave of melancholy as she stepped into her panties – her nude, strappy, five-inch heels were still on – and shimmied them up her legs. Whatever she was doing with Alessandro appeared to still involve something athletic, because her legs had only gotten more toned and now looked like an ad for pantyhose.

“I planned that,” she told me, a twinkle in her eye, as though she were reading my thoughts. “Okay. We gotta run, cowboy, or we’ll be late.”

Had she planned it because she wasn’t getting her Alessandro fix? I wondered, as I drove to Dan and Marie’s place. Or was she doing it to cover her tracks?

Scarlett’s affair had erased within me any ability to think that my wife was having sex with me just to have sex with her husband. Either she was doing it because she missed Alessandro, or because she didn’t want me to be suspicious.

The idea that these were the only two reasons for her to fuck me like she just had was both awful and delicious. It squeezed my heart in such a pleasantly painful way that I couldn’t help think like that.

I put my hand on her leg, pushing the delicate dress to the side to pet the length of her thigh. She put her hand on top of mine and interlaced our fingers. She smiled at me, but the smile was difficult to read. If all of this hadn’t been going on, I would have said it was an ordinary, tender smile.

Instead, I saw other things in it: trickery, pity, regret.

I turned into the long driveway to Dan and Marie’s house, a Mexican-style mansion with a courtyard and charming backyard shaded by pine and sage, with a fountain and a stone patio looking out over the barren landscape and the mountains.

They also had another house in Taos, which was a hip, modern, minimalist number, but this house was evidently Marie’s baby.

If by baby you meant that she spent all kinds of money on it and constantly imported decorative tiles from Mexico to refinish her bathrooms and kitchen and stairs and everything else. Or at least this is what I had gathered from Dan.

Scarlett broke from her reverie to comment: “I love this place,” as we drove into the cobblestoned rotunda and wedged our car among the other Lexuses.

My hand was still on her leg. I moved it a little, and she smiled and looked over at me.

Maybe she *had* broken it off with Alessandro. The last messages they had exchanged talked only of meeting times, all of them in the afternoon. She had driven to the club, and not gone anywhere else. Maybe she was sorry, and didn’t know how to ask me for forgiveness.

It was possible to believe all of this in her tender expression. And, it was possible to believe that she was a lying, cheating whore as well.

She leaned over to me, and drew her hand across my cheek to pull me close to her. “You really do look handsome tonight,” she said.

I kissed her hand, decided to believe the best, and we entered Dan and Marie’s house as I floated on this small bubble...

Which was immediately burst.

Marie greeted us at the door.

I hadn’t seen her in a long time, which lodged a little something in the back of my mind.

I stared at her as she walked toward me, (toned) arms wide open. She was dressed in an elegant white dress, more like a ball gown, a fat black ribbon cinching her waist, which looked much narrower.

But something was different about her. Something in her energy had changed, the way some of her fat had turned to muscle: instead of seeming like a late-forties lawyer’s wife who bought Mexican tiles for a hobby, she seemed more like a... more like a....

I pondered this while she enclosed me in her arms. Her lips were bright red, her makeup made her look like Rita Hayworth.

What was it? Her mouth was more open? She smiled more?

Marie was not the kind of woman most people thought of as particularly sexy. She was cute. An attractive wife. But she had the kind of hair, the kind of loose, lumpy pantsuits, the closed manner of being that screamed anything but sex.

I looked at Scarlett, who was also looking at Marie with, I was sure, a similar expression to mine. Marie enclosed her in her arms and then appraised her outfit. “You look hot,” Marie said, and gave Scarlett a wide, fun smile. “Isn’t this fun?” She turned to me. “Will, you need a drink. Get Will a drink,” she said to Dan, who had appeared at some point in this exchange, but who was so bland and unimposing next to his... “new”... wife, that I hadn’t noticed him.

Marie put an arm around Scarlett’s waist and turned her toward the interior of the house.

I looked at Dan, who was his usual dry self. He set a drink, already handy, in my hand, and clinked his glass against mine.

I decided not to ask what it was. Knowing Dan, it was expensive as fuck and would taste fine going down, as most things that cost \$80 for five ounces tended to be.

We turned and watched the ladies head to a lavish, catered table of hors d'oeuvres. Dan sipped his drink.

“That dress is something else,” Dan commented.

There could be little doubt that he was referring to Scarlett, whose dress was, in fact, “something else.” Especially from behind, as we were now viewing it. The cut, and the slit, gave the length of the dress a very narrow, tapered look at the legs, making her firm round butt look even rounder. She was a lot of elegant, sexy lines.

For sure.

Marie was bringing a glass to her lips, and looking a little distracted, her profile to us.

I nodded, to agree with Dan, wondering what was different with Marie and why Dan hadn’t noticed it, when Marie looked over at us.

At me.

And smiled.

And then it hit me.

Beneath the white dress, prom dress or not, Marie was suspending two very large breasts.

I blinked.

They were definitely bigger.

Dan touched my elbow. “Come in here and meet my buddy Al, he’s running a firm out of Denver.”

I followed Dan through the many rooms of his house, all of them dripping with the sort of expensive furnishings that lawyers choose once they’re partners. Scarlett called it “subtle ruling class” deco. Kind of a combo between Texan oil tycoon and snobby British royal.

But because it was New Mexico, Marie had decorated with a Southwestern flair.

Copeland, Copper, & Heim was pretty much an old boys’ club, so after trekking through innumerable subtle ruling-class rooms, while Dan offhandedly pointed out expensive things he’d purchased, I arrived at a regular sausage fest in what looked like a billiard room. Someone offered me a cigar.

I declined, thinking about how Scarlett, had she been on the same tour, would have rolled her eyes every time I looked back at her, and then asked a lot of questions about all of Dan's expensive stuff, feigning interest. It was one of her favorite games now that we consorted with rich people.

Now that we *were* rich people.

There was no escaping the room, or the conversation. Occasionally I saw Scarlett slinking through one of the rooms, and when she caught my eye she raised her eyebrows and made a funny face at me.

It was fun when Scarlett and I went to parties like this one, because even after these months in Santa Fe, we still felt like we were living someone else's life sometimes. We had never been particularly wealthy in Chicago, and we certainly didn't go to parties like this one or belong to a country club, drive a Lexus or have a clothing budget for new, tailored wool suits and \$250 ties.

I liked the complicity between us, when she made a face at me as Marie dragged her around the room.

I also enjoyed the way my wife dragged every man's eyeballs along with her as she nibbled on a cracker or poured herself some champagne and then wriggled her butt out of the room.

An hour or so went by, with me buried in dull conversation, having too much to drink, and eating weird snacks that occasionally came by on platters held by waiters who had magically appeared at some point in the evening.

I decided to use the bathroom, partly because I had to go and partly because I was hoping to return through the rooms closer to the kitchen and find my wife.

As I passed through a dining room, and an inexplicable, linked, second dining room, I saw the curve of Scarlett's body, her black-gray dress, and a wisp of her hair in the kitchen. She was leaning on the tiled counter, her arms moving a little as she talked.

I made a plan to go back that way, sought out the downstairs bathroom, and found an occupied one. I went on a search for a second one, following the instructions of the increasingly unknown and drunk people I met in the corridors and rooms. The ambiance was changing, the volume increasing, the laughter becoming sloppier, as more guests arrived and more wine was poured. People were standing closer to each other, clustering in groups.

It was going to be a good party.

I searched the whole downstairs and didn't find anything that would qualify as a bathroom, so I trotted up the tiled staircase to the upstairs when a pinched-faced guest pointed at the ceiling in answer to my question.

I wanted to see what was up there, anyway.

Most of the lights were out, but some light spilled from a few rooms, indicating others were exploring up there as well. I caught a glimpse of tile and a bathtub as I passed an open bedroom door, and I really had to pee, so I cut through the room and into the bathroom.

When I slammed the door I realized I was a little drunk.

I shut the second door to the bathroom more quietly, taking a long time to figure out the intricate lock. I was in a good mood, so I smiled at myself in the mirror and whistled. I'd go back down, find Scarlett, make some jokes, have some more drinks and some small talk, and then we'd go home with one of Dan's drivers and have sex. It was going to be a good evening. The alcohol and the buzz were working wonders on me. Scarlett had probably dropped Alessandro, and I had that inflated, optimistic drunken high going, so I was sure I could live with it even if she never told me.

I think I looked into the toilet and told it, "but she probably will."

I steadied myself as I flushed. Wow. Pretty drunk somehow.

The second door I had locked which I assumed led to another bedroom that shared the bathroom, rattled. I heard a female laugh, and I smiled to myself. "Right out," I said, and I meant to be loud but probably wasn't.

I opened the door I had come through. Then, realizing that the person at the other door would probably want to come through there, I reached to unlock it.

The bathroom was long, for some reason, I didn't feel like walking to the door so I just waved my fingers at it to indicate it was unlocked, before strolling out into the other bedroom.

I heard the laugh again, and then a lower male voice, and I smiled to myself again. So many middle-aged people acting like they were at a frat party.

The female voice was not Scarlett's: by now, I knew the sound of my own wife's laugh in another room. I kept walking, heading toward the stairs, when I distinctly heard: *gattina*.

I froze, and then stepped back into the bedroom I had accessed the bathroom from. A long hallway connected the upstairs rooms, I was about halfway down it. There was a light on in the room I was in, but not the rooms going down the hall in the direction of the voices.

In the direction of Alessandro's voice.

Gattina.

My gut coiled, cold settled into my limbs.

Was he here? Was that Scarlett?

I was sure, *sure* it was not Scarlett. The voice was higher, squeakier, missing the slight nasal quality that Scarlett's had, the one that made her sound a little like a smoker.

But "gattina." That was Alessandro, and I would know the baritone rumble of his slick Italian voice anywhere.

I pressed myself up against the wall and looked around frantically. Turning the light off was probably a no-go, and there was no place to hide in this room. The bathroom door was slightly open, the light out, and the other side of the bathroom unlocked.

I waited, listening.

The door to the bedroom shut, and I heard the sound of a body thumping against a wall. I could no longer hear what they were doing through the heavy door.

I looked at the bathroom, which beckoned me: I could go in there, turn the handle, open the door a crack, listen in.

If I got caught I could claim to be locking the door. Lost.

It was a great plan, because I was extremely intoxicated and could not think of any way it could go wrong or why I shouldn't do it. And I was deeply curious about who was in there, utterly confused about what I was hearing, and still slightly suspicious that Scarlett was in there, even though it was so clearly not her voice.

I decided to shut the door to the room I was in and lock it. Then I crept to the bathroom. I turned off the light in the bedroom after flicking on the bathroom light.

I paused, listening: whatever the people in the next room were doing, it involved a lot of dull thuds, so it wasn't too hard to figure out they were occupied.

I looked at the door handle, plunged myself into darkness, and crept toward the door, with my fingers outstretched so that I could brush the

wood with them when I reached it. From there, I slid my hand down, slowly, my breath shaking and my heart pounding, my cock completely erect. I didn't want to make the door rattle, so I had to move excruciatingly slow.

Finally, I felt the cooler metal of the handle, and I stepped a little closer to get my fingers in a good grip around it and slowly, slowly pull it down.

I knew it was the sort of handle that would slam back up if released, making a clatter, so I held it firmly as I tugged at the door, opening it just an inch.

The door was an expensive, well-oiled, perfectly engineered masterpiece, so it slipped open quiet as death.

Through the small opening I had made, a dim light peeked in. Panting, wet slaps, and then voices, poured into the bathroom. They were whispering, moaning, slapping their wet skin together, but I could make no sense of what they were saying, much less identify them positively.

I listened, cock aching, trying to think of a way to edge in and look at them, when I heard them groan with a simultaneous climax. The huffing and panting slowed, the slapping of skin against skin wound down, and I heard a few more wet kisses.

Then a female voice – definitely *not* Scarlett. “Okay, go, scoot, downstairs. I’ll come down in a minute.”

I heard movement, and in spite of being very drunk, I thought quickly. She was coming toward the bathroom.

I abandoned the handle, making sure to release it slowly. I heard the clang of a belt buckle as I turned into the very dimly lit bathroom. I saw the tub, tall and large with a tiled side and a curtain hanging over half of the recess into which it was set.

I remembered the bedroom: it was a no-go. No place to hide, except behind the bed, which would look a little weird if I got caught there.

I calculated quickly, without really thinking, and my Reptilian mind acted for me, moving me like a panther or a ninja or something right into the bathtub recess and behind the curtain. It turned out there was a ledge on that half of the tub, but my mind was so quick it launched me onto it quiet as a mouse and I curled up there, behind the curtain, pretty well hidden except that I was breathing pretty fast.

The door handle jiggled, the light came on, I closed my eyes against the horrible reality that the shower curtain might be too sheer.

The woman entered.

I heard another wet kiss, then she said, impatiently and tenderly at the same time. "Go. Seriously. Get down there, you first, I have to get back."

She laughed lightly, they kissed again.

I was working on not breathing like a pig, my mind reeling. My legs already hurt.

I heard drawers opening, the sound of hair being brushed. A click of lipstick. A whispered, *dammit*. She spent what seemed like an eternity in there. I wanted desperately to see who it was, confirm that it wasn't Scarlett, and see who the harlot was who was evidently fucking Alessandro... but I couldn't move or I was going to spill off the ledge, where, I had just noticed, glass shampoo and conditioner bottles were precariously perched in front of me. It was a miracle I hadn't knocked them off.

At long last, the woman gave a contented sigh. I prayed even though I am an atheist that she would leave. My legs were throbbing, I was dizzy, the shampoo bottles (who puts glass in a fucking shower?) were taunting me, and I was flying on adrenaline, booze, and arousal, while being wildly afraid of getting caught.

She left through the door I had entered by.

I caught only a glimpse of her as she exited.

White dress.

Black sash.

Red hair.

Marie.

CHAPTER 6

It was such a shock that, even though my legs were screaming, and my feet had long ago gone numb, I just sat there, crouched on the bathtub ledge, still trying not to breathe too hard. My mind was spinning.

At last, I was prodded into action by a peal of laughter from downstairs, which reminded me of the absurd predicament I was in, and how much more absurd it would be to be sitting there again if another person came up the stairs.

I un-stuck my feet, which I could not feel, and they jerked out, knocking one of the glass shampoo bottles over, which I fortunately caught in my hand. The pain began right after a wave of mild tangling, and I grimaced as I tried to stand in the tub.

No dice. My ankle folded and I had to lean on the side of the tub.

Some voices were coming from the direction of the bedroom. It was a large house, and things carried and bounced with the tile everywhere, so they might not have been beating down the door, but I needed to get myself out of the tub.

I swung my legs like a paraplegic and leaned forward, hissing because my feet were now screaming back to life and felt like someone had sewn some hot coals inside of them. I managed to shut the door and lock it.

Annoyed – very annoyed – I stared at the door to the bedroom where Alessandro and Marie had been.

Oh fuck it. At least I was out of the tub.

Alessandro and Marie.

Alessandro and Marie.

Wow. I wondered if Scarlett knew about this.

The voices were on the other side of the door, in the bedroom I had crept through. Someone rattled the door.

“Occupied,” I said grumpily.

I looked over at the ledge where I had perched. Nice. Shoe prints.

I looked around for something to wipe them off with, but then, because I was feeling devious in a very strange way, I decided to leave them.

After all, Marie would probably never find them (Dan and Marie were housekeeper sort of people)... but if she did...

She would have to wonder.

I waited a good five minutes before descending the stairs, the forces of dread pulling at my feet, and the high, exciting forces of arousal and intrigue tugging at my head, making me buoyant. The party was still in a state of agitation, getting louder and drunker with each passing minute.

I put my hands in my pockets, feeling a little devious, and strolled back to the kitchen, where I found Scarlett, still in the same position, a flute of champagne to her lips and a vacant expression on her face as a woman – probably a wife – talked her ear off about something like draperies or decorating.

I slid up behind her, and put my hands on her waist.

Scarlett's body reacted like a viper. She stiffened, and whipped her head around. For just the briefest of moments, while she was looking at me but didn't recognize who I was, she looked afraid and wild.

She very quickly transformed the expression into a smile. The smile was fluttery, overdone, meant to cover up the expression she had just been wearing. "Oh, *Will*," she exclaimed. Her face fell right after she said it, because she knew that she had made a mistake: why was Scarlett so surprised to see me?

I knew it was because Alessandro was around here somewhere, and I could guess that Scarlett had seen him. I knew it was because my wife was having an affair with him, and Alessandro was the kind of guy to push the envelope, push Scarlett past her boundaries, take chances. He might just do something so brazen as coming up behind her to put his hands on her hips.

"Were you expecting someone else?" I joked. I was on a fishing expedition, watching Scarlett's face for any slip, any tell.

But Scarlett had composed herself by then, and she wasn't going to make any more mistakes. She shook her head and smiled, then turned to the woman next to her. "Cecile. This is my husband, Will. Cecile is an *old friend* of the Copelands. She does *all* of the firm's decorating."

Scarlett had her sing-song, making-fun-of-rich-people-in-front-of-their-faces voice on. She smiled at me as she took a sip of her champagne and Cecile gave me a weak handshake.

"Cecile designed this kitchen," Scarlett continued.

“I like it!” I declared enthusiastically. “It’s very functional.”

Cecile paled. “It’s not the working kitchen,” she said. She promptly made an excuse of a passing tray of canapes, and wriggled away while making a face and mumbling nonsense, which is the way most people at parties like these got out of conversations.

“She did *not* like you,” Scarlett said, being sarcastic and shaking her head.

I stared at my wife. Either she had no idea Alessandro was here, or she was the most magnificent liar I had ever seen.

“So...” I said, casually. “What’s been going on downstairs while I was away?”

I was pretty sure that Scarlett trembled. Her chest froze mid-breath, her sassy champagne-swirling ceased enough to disrupt the wave in her glass.

But, like a glitch in the matrix, it was quickly repaired, and the swirl started up again. “Where were you away?” she asked, equally casually.

I watched her champagne: moving a little too fast now.

I was thoroughly enjoying myself, if I had to be perfectly honest. It was fun, finding the places where Scarlett would crack. Sure, it would have sucked to be oblivious to what she was doing, because I wouldn’t have noticed any of this or added it all together.

But I was not that sort of man, was I?

I was the sort of man who installed spyware on his wife’s phone. So there.

“Upstairs,” I replied.

Scarlett’s light skin flushed at the back of her neck and she reached a gloved hand for the skin there, as it grew hot, maybe itching.

Now she really had me wondering. Had she seen Alessandro here? Did she know about Alessandro and Marie? Had she *seen* Marie go upstairs? Was Alessandro invited to this party, or was he sneaking around with Marie independent of the party?

Scarlett’s mind was churning away. She took a sip of her champagne to give herself a moment to compose her next thought. Her next move.

Her eyes moved past me, to the series of rooms in succession, where most of the people at the party were mingling. When she finished her drink, she set it on the counter, and then, looking like something had just occurred

to her, she leaned toward me. “Oh gosh,” she said. This was her shorthand for “I forgot to tell you...”

She gripped my arm. I looked down at her gloved hand on my suit jacket, and something about it was very arousing.

“So listen. I’m not sure, but I think I saw Alessandro at this party.”

I made a face. It wasn’t hard to look at least a little surprised, because I hadn’t actually expected her to come out with that.

“Alessandro-Alessandro?” I asked. “Tennis Alessandro?”

She pressed her lips together and nodded solemnly.

Stop here.

This would be the point in a movie where the frame froze, and the narrator came in to explain that he was really, really confused, because there was no other way to convey it.

There’s a really bad thing that happens when you entangle yourself in a web of lies this intricate. Sooner or later – or at least, I think this is true of most people – you’re going to have a moment where you need to have a reaction to something, but you have no idea which one it is supposed to be.

This was one such moment for me.

I was thrown into a vortex for a few seconds. I could suddenly no longer remember which aspects of Alessandro and Scarlett’s affairs were known to Scarlett to be known to me, and which weren’t. Nothing? Everything?

No... just part of it.

But which part?

And at the same time, throwing a wrench into the gears of my mind, was the enormous problem of not knowing what Scarlett knew about Marie, and knowing, as I did, about Marie and Alessandro. The gears were full of gum because of that.

So I stood there, blinking.

And this, I know, probably alerted Scarlett to the fact that something was up with *me*, or at least put her on guard.

What I should have done, immediately, was say: “What is he doing here?”

But I waited too long, searched for that comment in the overstuffed couch of my brain, and Scarlett became curious and impatient. The curiosity twitched at her lips. Her eyes moved, reading my face.

“What is *he* doing here?” I finally managed to say.

Scarlett paused, I’m sure because *I* had just thrown a wrench into *her* machinery by arousing her suspicions.

Then she leaned even closer, and I thought maybe some incredible, sexy secret would leave her lips, because she was moving them together, sliding them slightly from side to side. My heart raced: maybe this would be a confession, maybe another lie, maybe a bad lie that would get her caught.

“I think,” she said. A minute pause hovered in the air, empty of sound and laden with possibilities. My stomach knotted tightly, my heart enlarged and stopped in my chest. Scarlett breathed: “I think Marie is taking lessons with him again.”

Her face gave away no hint of innuendo, no indication that she had any other knowledge about Marie or Alessandro than this mundane tidbit.

What a letdown.

I grabbed a wine glass from a passing tray. Scarlett’s eyes went wide. “I think that’s -”

I took a sip.

“... used,” she finished.

I shrugged. I really was quite drunk.

But my mind was putting everything together now: Marie, Alessandro, Scarlett... I was thinking about my next play. “So, does Mr. Fancy-Pants know you’re here? That we’re here?”

For good measure, I snagged a cracker from another passing tray. “This is a good spot,” I commented, realizing that all the caterers were coming out of what must have been the “working kitchen” right next to us.

Scarlett shook her head, pressing her lips together and suppressing a smile.

She always did love that I made her laugh.

I inspected the crackers.

“That one’s fine,” she said, rolling her eyes.

I ate it. “So. How ‘bout it? Has he seen you?”

Scarlett was shaking her head slowly. “You’re so *drunk*,” she laughed.

Deflecting. Nice move. She was also doing it so charmingly that I really didn’t feel like fucking with her half as much as I had before I went down there. The feeling I’d had upstairs was returning as well. It was an odd combination of sympathy for Scarlett, and competitive fury.

Why would Alessandro be fucking Marie, when he could have Scarlett?

And that's when a few observations that had been floating around in my head, unconnected, came together to form a clear image. I blurted:

"Do you think Marie's had a boob job?"

Scarlett was turning a sort of storm-gathering white, and her features became stony and sharp. Even more terrifyingly, her eyes seemed to turn black.

Whoa, I thought. *I have touched some kind of nerve.*

But I didn't get to find out where Scarlett was headed with that evil demeanor, because her eyes suddenly went wide in response to something over my shoulder. Her hand flew to my forearm, and her face turned into a gelatinous mess for a second while she broke into a ridiculous smile. "Look who it *iiiiis*," a feminine voice squealed behind me.

As I turned, the red hair, the white dress, the black sash, materialized at once.

Marie.

Another quarter-turn and I saw *him* out of the corner of my eye. His tall frame loomed, his black, wavy hair shone, and he was the kind of person who projected himself, enlarging his already substantial physical presence.

Alessandro.

I had a wild desire to move my eyes wildly to and from each person. I was brimming over with all the secrets I knew about these people, and I had no idea how much each of them knew about the other. So I looked straight ahead and sipped on my used glass of wine in order to stay out of the fray.

"*There* you are, Will," Marie crooned at me. She touched my arm. She was pulling Alessandro behind her. "Alessandro, you remember Scarlett, of course, and this is her husband *Will*, I can't remember if you two ever met or not? Anyway, Will is the one who was singing your praises so much, and Scarlett was *so* good in France, that I decided to go back to Alessandro and take more lessons!"

Marie began this announcement looking at and speaking to Alessandro, but finished, as a lot of drunk people do, by telling the story to everyone present and practically yelling.

I had a really hard time keeping my features from playing out like a game of Asteroids on an old Atari.

“We’ve met,” Alessandro said. He was next to me now, Marie holding his left arm. Alessandro wedged his right arm into the loose circle we’d formed and awkwardly turned it toward me. I looked at him as I shook his hand.

I squeezed it pretty hard. “Good to see you, Alessandro,” I hissed. Marie beamed.

I let my eyes drop to her mid-chest.

Definitely a boob job.

“Scarlett and I have been -” Marie began.

But before she could get another word out, Scarlett gave out a yelp, threw herself forward, and dropped her glass on the floor. “Ooop!” she yelled.

The glass shattered, because everything in Marie’s house was made of tile, and there was a resulting chaos, and flurry of apologies and caterers rushing to the scene like it was a three-alarm fire, so Marie never got to finish her sentence.

And Scarlett had plenty of time, standing next to me, feigning confusion and watching the caterers jump around frantically, to think of a reason she had so suddenly and violently jumped and thrown her glass on the floor.

“What happened?” I asked, genuinely curious about what she would come up with.

I looked at Alessandro, who had an amused smile on his lips.

Scarlett brought her hand to her mouth and shook her head. “I’m so embarrassed,” she said. “I just... *fell out* of these crazy shoes.”

I could feel Alessandro’s smug smile on my left. Scarlett was statuesque – and perfectly stable – in her high heels. Marie looked sympathetic. She took Scarlett’s hand. “Let’s go get you another champagne.”

I was certain that Marie was about to leave me with my wife’s lover, and I was already thinking of things to say to him. But Marie looked behind her as she walked away, and Alessandro shrugged, gave me a nod, and followed her.

I thanked the caterers, and then asked them to bring me a Scotch on their way back out.

I found Scarlett outside some time later, warming herself under one of the many heat lamps Dan and Marie had placed around the courtyard.

Alessandro was inside, I knew, because I saw him talking to a gaggle of women, all of whom had flocked around like moths to a flame. Marie had installed herself in a corner of that room, keeping up the wives' half of the conversation with one of Dan's associates. She kept giving what I'm sure she thought were secretive, steamy looks in Alessandro's direction.

Alessandro, for his part, was a real pro, and he managed to cast sizzling glances in her direction without Dan, or his harem of ladies, seeing a thing.

You'd have to be attuned to it to see it. And I was.

So was Scarlett, who had gotten involved in her own conversation in an adjacent room, where she had a clear view of Alessandro and Marie, and the sizzling looks the two were exchanging.

I snuck up on Scarlett, hoping to make her nervous again, but she reacted mildly to me touching the back of her arm and moving my mouth quickly to the back of her neck. I was pleased to see a wave of goosebumps scatter over her skin from neck to shoulder.

"What are you doing out here?" I asked, doing a half-turn and falling into a bench.

Scarlett smiled at me. "You better take it easy," she warned.

"Too late," I said. "I might as well go out with a bang."

Scarlett cocked her head and reached for my drink. Somehow I'd obtained a martini, and I frowned at my poor choices. I was mixing too much. Scarlett raised the glass to her eye level. "You didn't get this off a tray going back to the kitchen, did you?" she asked, suspiciously.

I shook my head.

"Do you think *you* should have any more? I mean, after that fall."

I watched her. She took a sip of the martini and set the empty glass on the ledge of the round rock wall we were near. She shook her head.

I liked that she stared at the glass, and that her mind was obviously weighed down by the guilt of lying to me. I could always tell when something bothered Scarlett: she couldn't stop thinking about it, or make it look like she wasn't. In fact, her cool-as-a-cucumber attitude to this point had been disturbing. I was a little relieved to see that at least somewhere inside, she felt bad for all her deception.

She took a deep breath, and I felt like she was on the verge of telling me something, when I heard Marie's voice again. I turned to my right to see Marie and Dan coming through the doors to the back patio area, the same pair they had been talking to in tow.

Scarlett's mouth, which had been poised just moments before for what I was almost certain was going to be a confession, closed reluctantly. She smiled at Marie.

I stood up, feeling like we should join them – if anything because Dan was looking imminently bored and one could always score brownie points with him by rescuing him from a boring conversation. I smoothed my pants, noticing that I had left my suit jacket somewhere.

Man, was I drunk.

Dan caught my eye and motioned for me to come over. I looked at Scarlett, making her accompany me by giving her "the look."

Dan and the friend, whose name I listened to but did not commit to memory, were having a conversation about yachts. It turned into a conversation about money. Scarlett was hijacked by the wife, so she couldn't intervene when Dan said:

"Marie is spending a *fortune* on her hobbies. Candles, tennis lessons – well, you know about that, Will."

He delivered this final comment knowingly before taking a sip of his whiskey.

Scarlett, whose left profile was turned to me, visibly stiffened. I could almost see her blood pumping faster, her heart throbbing in her chest. Her cheeks went bright pink for a few seconds.

"Will's wife, this is her, right here – she's the one who got us into this mess," Dan continued.

Scarlett was now pivoting toward us, leaving her conversation as politely as she could, but with an obvious desperation to get in on whatever Dan and I were talking about.

"What's that, Dan?" Scarlett said. Her voice was sweet, but there was a hurried cadence to it that signaled alarm. "Complaining that I'm so good at tennis that your wife went back to lessons?"

Dan raised his eyebrows at me. "No. No," he said, sarcastically. "I *love* dishing out a grand worth of lessons every month." He took a sip of his drink and pointed at his companion. "And half of those are a *class* discount. Imagine, if they were all individual lessons."

Scarlett was on edge, waiting for Dan's next comment. Her eyes were bright and her pupils dilated: she was ready to pounce. Dan seemed to be on the verge of saying something Scarlett didn't want him to say.

I wondered if she was going to stage another fall from her shoes, or something more interesting.

And I also wondered what it was that Dan might say that had Scarlett so knotted up.

"You know," Dan said, shaking his ice in his glass. He crunched loudly into an ice cube. "If I didn't know better, I'd say this was *your* plan all along."

He was looking at me. Scarlett was trying to restrain herself, and I could practically *feel* the energy buzzing off of her.

"How's that?" I asked casually. I let my eyes dash to Scarlett, who was apoplectic.

"It's gotta be a relief to you to pay half the price for these things," he said.

Scarlett's hand shot out to my forearm, and she squeezed it tightly. I looked at her, amused, and she gave three very fervent, but microscopic shakes of the head. Her eyes were pleading, and her lips were pressed together.

I took a deep breath and paused, before turning back to Dan. "Well," I said. "The discount's really Scarlett's."

"I forgot your wife has a job," Dan said. "Mine's just out there... spending money...."

Scarlett rolled her eyes, and turned back to her conversation with the wife of Dan's business associate, but not before giving me a silent expression of gratitude.

My heart raced with excitement. I wasn't exactly sure what Dan was talking about, and I wasn't going to investigate it, because I was pretending to be clueless about all of Scarlett's antics. I was trying to behave in the way I thought I would behave if I were, in fact, clueless.

It was getting very difficult to sort out what that might be, especially given my level of inebriation, but I felt fairly confident Scarlett wanted me to shut up about the tennis lesson topic. She'd have to come up with some kind of explanation later, which would be fun, especially if she continued to lie to me.

So I quieted down.

Dan leaned in very suddenly to me. “You know how much Marie is costing me right now? That boob job? Like \$35K.”

My mouth opened, but I had no idea what to say.

“Don’t get me wrong, it’s nice, but... you’ve got it made with a gal like Scarlett. First of all, she doesn’t need any work, and second of all, she pays for her own stuff. I got a two-thousand dollar bill from a spa last month.”

I could tell Scarlett was monitoring our conversation.

“For *what?*” I asked, shocked.

Dan shook his empty drink glass again and drank some of the melted water. “Good fuckin’ question, hell if I know. Waxing. Some kind of laser thing. Facials. Hair stuff.” He shrugged and motioned to a caterer to bring him a drink.

“My wife spends about five hundred on that shit a month,” the associate complained.

“Wow,” I said.

I was almost as impressed at Dan’s utter cluelessness as I was at Marie’s spa bill. I studied my boss, wondering if he was just putting on a good show, or if he sincerely had no idea that Marie was cheating on him with her tennis instructor, and that it was a good bet that two thousand dollar spa bill had been spent for Alessandro’s benefit more than anything.

I snuck a glance at Scarlett, who had positioned herself to my left. The woman she was talking to was going on and on, and Scarlett was pretending to be attentive, but she threw a look in my direction.

Don’t say anything, she was saying. Her head shook again, almost imperceptibly.

I took a swig of my whiskey. This was going to be an interesting night.

At about eleven, I was obliterated, and guests were starting to filter out of the house. I procured a ride home with Dan’s driver, and we piled into the car with another couple who were dropped off first.

After they exited, I got back in the car and plopped down next to Scarlett.

“So,” I said jovially. I had been enjoying the look of dread on Scarlett’s face. I rested my hand on her knee, wondering if she was going to come clean about everything now, which was tantalizing but honestly a

little disappointing. Or if – and I knew this was what I was secretly hoping – she would continue to lie, and I would get to continue watching her squirm and feel guilty about her affair.

And spy on her, which I also enjoyed immensely.

I moved my hand so that my fingers were pointed to her inner thigh. I stroked her skin lightly, and I was pleased by the flush that overtook her face. She blew a strand of hair from her face.

“What was all that about?” I asked.

Scarlett looked over at me, a terribly fake look of confusion on her face. “All what?”

“About the tennis. And Marie.”

She looked at me blankly. My heart thudded against the wall of my chest.

So devious.

“With Dan, the conversation about the lessons?”

“Oh,” she said, hesitantly.

“I got the impression you’re taking lessons with Marie.”

I’d had some time to think about this. It *did* seem that something to that effect had also been what Marie had been going to say, just before Scarlett had thrown her glass on the floor to cut Marie off.

Scarlett lowered her eyes, and she found my hand. “Listen, don’t be mad at me,” she said.

The sound of rushing water seemed to fill my ears. My heart sped up, my cock got hard.

“You have to swear that -” she began, whispering, but her eyes flew suddenly to the driver.

She looked at me next, and gave that same little head-shake. “I’ll tell you all about this at home,” she said.

We rode in silence.

I gave the driver a \$20 tip, which seemed a little chintzy, but all I had was a \$20 and a \$100, which seemed extreme. Scarlett shivered and climbed the steps to the house, her heels clacking on the pavement. I followed, my pulse racing wildly.

I opened the door for her and we stepped inside.

“Let’s go to that same little restaurant on the way to Dan and Marie’s for breakfast tomorrow,” she said casually, taking off her shoes. “When we go to get the car.”

I kicked off my own shoes. “Dish the dirt, Scarlett. Stop beating around the bush.”

She looked guiltily at me, then picked up her shoes and arranged them neatly by the door.

“You have to *swear* not to say anything,” she said. She looked up at me. “And you have to promise you’re not going to get mad.”

“I can promise the first one,” I said, and I hoped she didn’t hear my voice shaking. Was she going to confess to me right now?

She stood up from her crouch. She looked uncertain. “Okay, this is really bad. And it all happened before I knew what to do about it, and now I’m just worried that... I don’t know, it might affect you somehow. That’s why I kept it a secret.”

I was genuinely confused again.

“You have to *swear* -”

“I swear, Scarlett,” I said impatiently. “Just tell me already.”

She leaned toward me to whisper. “Marie is having an affair.”

I got the jitters, because that same problem – of not being able to keep all of my deceptions, and Scarlett’s, and Marie’s and Alessandro’s, straight – happened again. I blinked. “An affair,” I repeated.

Scarlett nodded.

So she *knew*.

But how did this fit into what Dan had been alluding to? I racked my brain, but things were spinning too much for me to get a grip on them.

“What does that have to do with -”

“She confided in me,” Scarlett said. She shrugged. “What could I do?”

“With Alessandro?” I said, in disbelief.

Scarlett looked at me. “What?”

“I just can’t believe it,” I said.

“Who said that...?”

I looked at her. “I just inferred it,” I told her. “Isn’t that who it is?”

Scarlett looked troubled. Something I had said had bothered her. I could actually visualize her bookmarking that issue, and moving on in her mind. “I think so,” she said.

“So... Marie just, what, confided in you that she was having an affair with Alessandro?”

Scarlett nodded, but it was pretty obvious that there was more to it than that.

And then you....?" I prompted.

Scarlett shrugged. "I told her I'd cover for her."

"By taking lessons? I don't get this," I said.

I didn't. I was exasperated, and I knew Scarlett was leading me down the garden path, but I was annoyed that I couldn't figure out exactly why or how.

Scarlett sighed. "Look, she confided in me -"

"This is another thing I don't get," I said, suddenly cross. I was drunk, so my emotions were steering like a barge. "You and Marie aren't even good friends."

Scarlett sighed and took a few steps into the living room. She shrugged her light coat off. "Look, Marie came to me and talked to me about it because she thought I'd maybe... she suspected, I guess, that I'd had an affair with Alessandro. And she was just trying to be, I don't know, nice, make sure things had ended, or something like that."

I held my head, to physically demonstrate that I didn't understand what the hell she was talking about. I was still working my way through the first few sentences.

Scarlett seemed exasperated. "You know, like, she wanted to make sure things were over between me and him, before she started screwing him. You get it?" She looked annoyed by having to explain this to me, but in truth, I was thankful she did.

"So then what was I supposed to do?" she continued. "I didn't want to tell her she was *right*, so I told her that we hadn't. Had an affair. Then she was mortified, you know? She couldn't believe she'd told me this, she was worried about what Dan would do, she didn't feel like she could trust me, I'm sure, since I wasn't in the same boat as she was -"

"But you were," I interjected, and then, because I was drunk, I almost added: *but you are*.

"But *she* didn't know that," Scarlett plowed ahead, as though everything she was telling me were the real truth. I fingered my phone in my pocket, to remind myself that no matter how convincing Scarlett seemed, she *was* fucking Alessandro, and I had the video to prove it.

"So... I told her I'd help her cover it up," Scarlett concluded.

I stared at my wife. "Cover it up, how?"

Scarlett pushed her hair back from her face with two hands and emitted a sigh. “Eghhhh,” she said. “Okay. I pretend to be taking lessons with her. Or... I mean, I *am* taking lessons with her. Just, sometimes they go off, and I’m at the club alone.”

She was looking at the floor by the time she finished telling me this.

I closed my eyes, and pressed my fingertips to the lids. I was way too drunk to figure out which parts of Scarlett’s “confession” were truth and which were not. I knew Marie *was* actually having an affair with Alessandro, but so was Scarlett. These were two things I knew for a fact.

As to the rest of this bullshit? I had no idea.

And I certainly didn’t want to trip myself up by saying something.

When I opened my eyes, Scarlett was coming toward me, looking up at me, shorter than me now that she’d taken off her shoes. She looked remorseful, and I wondered how much of that was real and how much was an act.

“Honey,” she said, taking my wrists. “I’m sorry. I didn’t tell you because I didn’t want you thinking...” her voice trailed off.

“What?” I asked, incredulously. “You didn’t want me thinking *what*? That you were having an affair with Alessandro?”

There was a heady silence after I said this, because we both recognized how ridiculous it made her claim sound. And if there is anything that two drunk lawyers having an argument about marital affairs hate, it’s somebody’s claim sounding lame.

Scarlett’s eyes got wet, and she looked like she was about to cry.

For a moment, I started to slide into feeling sorry for her: I can’t take it if Scarlett cries.

But then I reminded myself that my wife was flat-out lying to me right then.

“You know what?” I said, and this was perhaps the smartest thing I’d come up with that night, and it was true: “I’m too drunk for this discussion. I’m going to bed. Tell me all about this tomorrow.”

“Will -”

It was my turn to hold up my hand dismissively.

So I went. To bed. I was bleary-eyed and half-asleep just as I reached the foot of the bed. I don’t know what happened after that.

Well, I don't *know* what happened after that, for sure. But thanks to my spyware, I can make a well-informed wager.

I didn't wake up until 9:00 or so, and when I did, it was one of those syrupy mornings with eyelids stuck together and a terrible taste in my mouth. I didn't open my eyes right away, because I could see the light through my eyelids and feel the headache I was going to have firing up the ovens. I knew that when I moved, my brain was going to roll around like slag in my skull, and my stomach chimed in to let me know it would also be feeling terrible today.

It was then time to search through the memory files, which, thanks to my drinking, were put away in my brain as though everything had been dumped on the floor, swept up hastily, and crammed back in in no particular order.

I knew I was mad at Scarlett, though it took me a while to figure out why, and even longer to sort through the conversations we'd had and determine if I actually had any business being mad at her, or if, as usual, I was in the wrong.

I pushed up on my elbows and blinked at the sheets. This time, I thought almost pleasantly, I was in the clear. Scarlett was the one who had done all the lying, and frankly, from what I could remember, I had been quite reasonable.

I rolled onto my back with a partial smile on my face. It didn't always work out like that.

Scarlett.

I jerked my head to her side of the bed, which was empty. The motion made my head scream angrily at me, and I righted myself too fast, which only made my headache worse and more distributed through my skull.

I smelled coffee. I sat up, which made me feel terrible, so I fell back with a groan.

"God this is going to be a long day," I said.

I wanted to yell out to Scarlett, but I didn't want to provoke my headache, and I certainly didn't feel like getting up.

On the other hand... a raging thirst set in, clutching my throat and rapidly making me feel like I was going to die if I didn't have some water.

"Scarlett?!" I yelled.

My head throbbed, and there was no answer.

“Honey?” I yelled, even louder. “Oh, God,” I said softly, afterward, holding my fingers to my temples.

There was no answer from the house, which was large but carried sound well, and anyhow, Scarlett had ears like a bat. If she wasn’t answering it was because she wasn’t there, or she was so angry at me she wasn’t going to help me anyway.

“I’m... so.... Thirsty...” I yelled, trying to be funny. “I will *die*.”

I slapped some clutter off the bedside table for effect.

If Scarlet had been home, she would have hurried in, and rolled her eyes, and probably forgiven me, because she couldn’t stay mad for -

So she wasn’t there.

A cold rage pushed through me, from the heart to my limbs.

Not here.

So where was she?

I sat up. My brain rolled and my head throbbed as I yelled her name one last time, but now I didn’t care. I hardly even noticed the pain, or the nausea that clutched my stomach when I stood up and strode toward my office. The light was so bright I had to keep my eyes in a squint, and my throat was sticking together with dryness.

But I didn’t care.

I stormed out to the living room, from where you can see pretty much any room in the house. “Scar?!” I yelled.

Nothing.

So I went to the office and fired up my HM app.

The seconds I had to wait while the machine loaded up and started to display the dashboard ticked by like eternities in hell. The headache I had just ignored, and my parched throat, clamored for attention. I had to pee. Why couldn’t my stupid body just reabsorb some of that and solve the damn problem itself?

I stared at the screen, my eyes moving so fast when the dashboard appeared that at first it was just a blur of words.

I settled on the most recent messages. I wiped my eyes.

[Alessandro]: *where did you go gattina. you don't even say goodbye?*

[Alessandro]: *Its not fair to get me so riled up like that and then leave*

[Alessandro]: *at least I have Marie to keep me company*
[Scarlett]: *wait. I'm sorting things with Will*
[Alessandro]: *he's so drunk. Why dont you come and see me gattina*
[Alessandro]: *he will never know or I could come to you*
[Scarlett]: *Wait*
[Alessandro]: *I think it's a very good idea. I will come over there*
[Alessandro]: *That's exactly what you deserve after you left me*
[Scarlett]: *What about Marie? You could always have some of that*
[Alessandro]: *You know I don't want Marie.*
[Alessandro]: *You know you don't want me to settle for Marie*
[Alessandro]: *I only came there tonight to see you*
[Alessandro]: *I'm coming over*
[Scarlett]: *Alessandro*
[Alessandro]: *here I come...*
[Scarlett]: *Do not come over here*
[Alessandro]: *Then you come over here, gattina.*
[Scarlett]: *I can't*
[Alessandro]: *Then I come to you.*
[Alessandro]: *Don't disappoint me.*
[Alessandro]: *I promise you won't be disappointed*
[Scarlett]: *Okay. I'll come*
[Scarlett]: *Give me half an hour*
[Alessandro]: *It won't take that long*

I read, and re-read the messages, trying to reconcile the wife I knew with the wife who was writing to her lover late at night.

A lot of time had passed between Alessandro's second-to-last message, and Scarlett's agreeing to go see him.

Had she struggled with the decision? Had she sat down on the edge of the bed, where I was passed out, and looked over at me, feeling remorse?

Or had her only concern been how to get away with it? Waiting to see if I really was passed out? Maybe she had come into the room and tickled

my feet, tried to wake me up.

I read the messages again. The picture that was emerging of Scarlett was of a woman who was getting coerced by the Italian loverboy, if you took the messages at face value, and you combined them with what Scarlett had claimed to feel when she had broken things off with Alessandro *last time*: out of control, unable to say no.

The conversations Scarlett and I had had the night before came back to me. How much of what she had told me was true? What did Marie *really* have to do with any of this? Alessandro seemed to know that Scarlett knew about Marie, but did Marie really not know about Scarlett? And *why* did Scarlett feel compelled to cover for Marie?

If that was even true, I told myself.

Who knew what was true with Scarlett?

My head felt like it was going under a steamroller.

And where the hell was Scarlett now?

Her phone was traveling down Cerillos Road. Then the dot disappeared. It reappeared somewhere else. Great. A glitch. Not uncommon, but they always seemed to happen right when I needed to know what she was doing.

I rose, with great difficulty, and stumbled into the hallway to search for my own phone. It took almost ten confusing minutes to find it, where I had evidently placed it on the nighttable, but knocked it off when I had pretended to be dying for Scarlett's benefit.

I rolled onto the bed to type, squinting through my headache:

[Me]: *where are you?*

I let the phone fall against my chest. I wished I had taken some Ibuprofen before lying back down. I wished I had consumed some water, and found myself a cold compress, and that my fucking wife was here to do all that for me.

I started to doze off. My phone vibrated on my chest and my hand, and only partially made its way through the haze.

A phone call. Scarlett. Too late, she had hung up.

A message appeared on the screen.

[Scarlett]: *I'm grabbing the car. I also am bringing: Gatorade, Tylenol, Advil, pickles, tacos, and tomato juice for a Bloody Mary. What else do you need?*

I held my phone with so much force applied between my fingers that I was surprised it didn't crack. How could my wife be so deeply infuriating, such a liar and a cheater, and yet also so caring? And what kind of person was I, getting mad at her for lying to me, but perpetuating the lies?

In that moment, upon asking myself that question, I had a brief but enlightening glimpse into how Scarlett must be thinking: after all, if I could be infuriated by her cheating but enabling it because it also turned me on, couldn't Scarlett feel torn by very similar emotions? Couldn't she feel guilty about her cheating (and her lying), but be overpowered by something about Alessandro and unable to stop? And couldn't it be just as hard for her to admit to it – to me, or even to herself – and just as difficult to explain?

After all, I couldn't explain my own behavior to myself. I didn't want to tell Scarlett what I had done. Wouldn't it be safe to assume she felt the same way?

I typed:

[Me]: *that's all perfect. Thanks. Nothing else.*

And then I thought about it for a moment, and typed:

[Me]: *thanks for getting the car*

I closed my eyes.

There was no way of knowing what Scarlett had been up to last night. The only thing I knew for sure is that she had probably done something with Alessandro. I wondered if she had gone to him, then woken up to go and get the car. How had she gotten there? Her car?

I was too tired, too hungover, to think on it much. She wouldn't have driven: a DUI could spell disbarment for a lawyer, and Scarlett wasn't about to take chances on that.

I imagined myself getting the balls to confront Scarlett, right when she came home. I would march out there and tell her to just tell me the truth, and then she would, and this game would be over...

I dozed off right when the inevitable disappointment set in in that fantasy.

And in that disappointment, the kernel of truth:

I didn't really *want* to confront Scarlett about her affair.

Maybe I didn't want it to end. Maybe I was afraid there was more to it than just lust. Maybe I wanted her to feel guilty enough to tell me herself.

Maybe I wanted to see how far she would go, how depraved she would become.

Maybe I just *enjoyed* it.

Maybe all of these things were true.

CHAPTER 7

When Scarlett returned, we had sex, and it was the kind of sex that was hot because Scarlett's mind was on something else. I chickened out of talking to her. And so the game went on.

The affair became a little dull for several weeks, and by dull, I simply mean that Scarlett and Alessandro exchanged only cryptic messages, and did not try to fuck in our house, or do anything particularly innovative. It still got me hot, spying on her, watching her car go to places she was not supposed to be, knowing that she was letting Alessandro fuck her ass raw, or that she was on her knees letting him facefuck her, or that she had her legs spread wide to take his huge cock in her pussy. Who knew what Alessandro was inventing at this point in their relationship?

But then, on a plain old boring Wednesday, their conversation turned wild.

[Alessandro]: *I want you to come and watch us today*

[Scarlett]: *Maybe*

[Alessandro]: *You're going to do it, gattina. Just like we talked about.*

[Scarlett]: *Maybe*

[Alessandro]: *Don't disappoint me, gattina*

There it was again, almost like a threat, as though Alessandro held something over my wife that would instantly make her do crazy things.

It wasn't so much that phrase that intrigued me, however. It was the "come and watch us," that piqued my interest.

I waited for more texts, or for something to happen, but I was disappointed. It wasn't a tennis lesson day, it wasn't a day they usually hooked up.

But then a message materialized on the app:

[Alessandro]: *She's coming at 3 so go early the back door is unlocked*

And then, moments later, Scarlett's car began to move.

I made the kind of excuses that everyone seemed used to me making, and flew out the door, thinking all along: it was two-fifteen, who was "she," and where was Scarlett going?

And what, I wondered even more deliciously, would she be watching?

Scarlett's phone appeared to be on the move, though it was jumping around again on the map and making me swear angrily while "choking" my phone – so much so that I nearly missed my wife driving *past me* as I rounded a corner onto Old Santa Fe.

I looked up at just the right moment, registered our car, and Scarlett's face behind the glare of the sun on the windshield. A shockwave of cold fear enveloped me: was I caught?

The notion was absurd: it was Scarlett who should be feeling like that, Scarlett who could get *caught*. After all, there were a million reasons I might be on this street, and it was Scarlett who was supposed to be at work. Scarlett who was going to watch something.

She was alone in the car, I noted, as I turned around and started to follow her at a safe distance.

As I turned around, I studied the mental image of Scarlett's face in the car.

She'd had the look of a woman obsessed. The same expression, the white-knuckled grip, and the vacant eyes that I imagined *I* had, and had before, while following her around at the beginning of this affair.

I turned the car around, pinpointed the red of the Camry as it headed down Old Pecos, and followed.

She was headed east, toward the mountains. It took only nanoseconds to put it all together: there was little doubt that she was going to *Dan and Marie's house*.

It was the only thing out here.

A cold, fearful excitement began to build in my stomach.

Once she reached their "neighborhood," she wound down the empty roads and past Dan and Marie's, up a hill and down another street that tucked behind a small hill and obscured her car. I drove past this turn-off: out here in this fucking desert of shrubby pines, how were people supposed to hide?

I found a place to park, in front of a large house that gave off the vacant, cold look of a second home that was constantly beautified by the

landscapers and never lived in, and I walked back up the hill, squinting into the dull sun.

There she was, right in the middle of the day, inexplicably wearing a brown sporty outfit, walking down the road and headed straight to Dan and Marie's house.

I followed.

The terrible sea of emotions in my gut only worsened as I saw her hoist herself over the low wall to the courtyard.

I crept – because that's the only word for what I was doing – up to the gates of Dan and Marie's house, where a low stone wall decoratively fenced off the pleasant Spanish-style villa-mansion. There was a gate to the driveway, and it was closed, but one had to do little but step over the stone wall to get in.

Still. It was trespassing, whether it was easy or not.

Trespassing onto my boss's property.

My boss, whose wife was having an affair with my wife's lover.

Seriously, Scarlett? I thought. My heart was beating so fast at this point I was pretty sure I was going to have a heart attack. Everything that had been fun, arousing, and titillating about Scarlett's sneaking around was dissolving in the face of whatever it was she was doing right then.

Which was what, exactly?

I could see the movement of her brown sportswear, and the bobbing of her golden halo of hair, pulled back in a ponytail, at the far end of the rotunda, which led, as I knew from the few parties we'd attended here, to the backyard courtyard area.

She was, I had to admit, well-hidden by the color scheme, her blonde and brown palette blending into the desert hues of the landscape.

But that actually reassured me less: it still didn't explain what the hell she was doing.

I had no desire – a negative desire, you might even say – to hop over the stone wall to my boss's house, following my wife in her trespassing, and running the risk of getting caught by my boss doing something I could not even explain.

No desire.

But as soon as Scarlett disappeared behind the house, my lack of desire was overcome by my need to know what the hell she was doing.

And so I found myself, with extreme misgivings and an even more extreme cardiac arrhythmia, lifting my legs and swinging them over the stone wall. I was annoyed that I was not as flexible or athletic as Scarlett apparently was, and that I needed to sit down to swing my legs over, while she – at least to my recollection – had just hopped over it in a single bound.

Once in the fenced-in area of the yard, there was a little coverage from a few short pines and sages planted along the perimeter of the area, so I crept again, my eyes darting in all directions while seeing nothing, for the backyard. Scarlett had taken a much more direct and exposed route, and she had done so without putting her hands out to both sides and jerking her head back and forth like a cartoonish version of an escaping prisoner in an old movie for children.

It was dawning on me, as I approached the courtyard, that Scarlett seemed to have some knowledge that I did not: that she was perhaps not being as jittery because she knew something I did not.

But the thought could not form fully in my hyperactive brain. I arrived at a thick sage bush and peeked through the sparse foliage at the moving brown of my wife's clothing.

She was standing by the back door – the same one we had exited at the party, which had been left open all night for the guests.

I stared at Scarlett as she moved, like a cat burglar, to press herself up against the adobe finish and then lean in to see into the building.

Then another icy-cold shot coursed through my veins as she rested her hand on the door, pulled down on the handle, and opened it to let herself in.

She moved nimbly, almost as though she had practiced the move. I stared at her form as she snuck into the house, and closed the door gently behind her.

My criminal lawyer buddies all say the same thing. The people who spill their guts, they all knew at the time, that they were making that bad decision, crossing the line, going past the point of no return. Most of them talked to themselves at that moment, told themselves they were going too far.

A lot like I was, at *that* moment.

“Will,” I breathed to myself, “this is too fucking far.”

But I just went ahead, walked right up to the door, crouched like Scarlett, peered inside, saw the empty rooms and a glimpse of the pair of

brown-clad legs ascending the staircase, and... turned the handle to the door.

Sure, I had no idea what was in there. No idea what my wife was doing in there. No idea when Marie or Dan would be home, and no idea what I would say if any of those people caught me.

It seemed to take an eternity to creep through the house. My nerves were so on edge that when a clock chimed I literally almost pissed myself.

During that eternity I had all the time in the world to think about getting caught. By Marie, by Dan, by a housekeeper, by my wife, by anyone else who happened to be here. Plenty of time to think about my career ending and the look on Dan's face when he heard I was creeping around in his house.

Plenty of time, as I rolled my eyes up the staircase and attuned my ears to every little rustle and sound, to think about what my wife might be doing. I imagined the worst: that she had not known about Marie's affair at all and was now here to kill Marie; to the best: she was actually having an affair with Marie.

The sneaking, though. It was the one terrible flaw in every scenario I imagined. Scarlett couldn't be doing anything as legitimate here as having an affair, because she was sneaking around.

The staircase presented a very difficult problem for me. It was the centerpiece of the entryway, exposed for the length of it, and while on it, there was no way to hide from whoever decided to come from the hallway to the right – where I presumed the master bedroom was – and the hallway to the left, where the bedrooms adjoined by the bathroom were, where I had seen Marie and Alessandro at the party.

I chickened out, tucking myself back under the archway to the row of living rooms on the West side of the house.

I checked my phone again, my HP app, to see if maybe Scarlett had sent some kind of message, or received one – anything that would give me a clue about what she was doing here.

But there was nothing.

I wondered how much I'd missed. The texts I intercepted clearly only told one small part of the story. What else had Scarlett been up to while I had been imagining a very narrow, limited world of possibilities based upon her texts?

That's when I heard the voice.

The low, smarmy baritone of none other than Alessandro.

I couldn't quite hear what he said, but it sounded, as usual, sultry and sexual.

The concerns about being caught flew out the window, and I stepped back into the foyer, craning my neck upward. There was no one on the landing, no shadow in the hallway.

Scarlett's voice came from the right side of the landing. "When is she coming?"

She was whispering. Slightly frantic.

I heard Alessandro's voice again, coaxing. Scarlett's whispers, inaudible. A playful slap. More coaxing from Alessandro.

I was led as though by strings on a puppet up the stairs, not even aware that I was moving, or that I was completely exposed on the staircase, or even remembering that I was in the home of my boss and his wife.

I *had* to see what was going on up there, make sense of it somehow. Watch it.

It didn't matter if it didn't make any sense.

"I have to hide before she gets here," Scarlett said, loudly enough that I heard her. Her voice was tense, agitated. The same emotions that had been present in *our* house, indicative that Scarlett was being pushed into doing things that stressed her out.

But at the same time, not so stressed out that she refused to do them. After all, it had been Scarlett's own two feet that had walked her here, her own hands that had opened the door.

"She hasn't texted me yet," Alessandro purred. "Come on, just a little bit."

I ascended, step by step, worried that my rapid breathing was going to echo all over the house.

"Gattina, you know you want to do it, you know you get the big thrill that I do..."

There was a pause, and I crept up a little more.

"That's it, yeah, that's it..." Alessandro breathed.

Then there was only the raunchy, gasping breath of a man getting his cock sucked, and the occasional wet spurt of a woman with a mouthful of cock.

I was close to the landing of the stairs now, with the hallway to the master bedroom, where I could hear that Scarlett and Alessandro were, and

the other hallway to my left. Nowhere to hide. No idea what the arrangements of the master bedroom were.

I froze. Alessandro groaned. “Oh yeah, that’s it, go ahead, go ahead you little slut, suck all the cum from my cock, you know you want to taste it... that’s it, I’ll go for such a long time while you watch me, be a good girl -” he interrupted himself to groan loudly as he came. “Swallow it,” he ordered my wife. “Get it all cleaned up, if you don’t want to get caught, gattina that’s it -”

I heard the cheerful chime of a text message.

“Oh, just in time,” Alessandro breathed. “Here she comes – wait a minute, cagna, not so fast, clean it all up or she’s going to ask me about it, and you wouldn’t want me having to explain that, would you?”

At that exact moment, just as Alessandro’s humiliation of my wife was sinking in and making my cock rock-hard, the flash of a car outside caught my eye. I looked at the distorted glass of the front door window, saw the white of Marie’s car, and put everything together in the blink of an eye.

Without regard for the noise I might be making, panicked and not thinking much more than that, I scrambled to my left and into the bedroom I had first hidden in.

Then, thinking of Scarlett, I hurried through the bathroom and into the bedroom where Alessandro and Marie had fucked at the party.

I stood in the dim light, ears ringing, cock hard, eyes swinging wildly all over the room in search of a place to hide.

The door to the house opened, I heard a thump down the hall, the air pressure changed slightly, and then Marie called out:

“Hello?”

I threw myself on the floor alongside the length of the queen bed in the room. It didn’t hide me from anything, and I saw that there were drawers underneath the bed and nowhere to hide. But it was better than just standing there in the middle of the room.

As long as no one came in here.

“I am up here,” I heard Alessandro call.

All of what happened next I had to imagine. I was lying on the floor, staring at the rug on the wood floor, my eyes closed tightly, praying not to get caught and using my imagination to match the soundtrack I heard to what might be happening in the other room.

I had no idea what had happened to Scarlett. I pictured her tucked away somewhere in the room. She didn't make a sound the whole time, so I figured that she was not an active participant. Combined with the sneaking around, I imagined it meant only one thing: Alessandro had her there to watch him with Marie.

So there was Alessandro, who had just gotten sucked off by my wife and then stashed her somewhere in the room, and now he was fucking Marie, knowing that my wife was crouching in the shadows somewhere, watching them.

And what a show it must have been.

Marie was a wild screamer, and they were at it for a long time. There was a five or six minute, slow-moving buildup, during which very little was said and I had no idea what they were doing. This was followed by five minutes of Marie screeching and mewling, asking Alessandro not to stop, and no sound from the trash-talking Italian. I assumed that he was eating her pussy out, her legs spread and his tongue carving a path through her wet folds and over her clit while she begged him not to stop.

After Marie came, there was another period of quiet, and then Alessandro started to coax her.

"That's it, that's good, get it all in there,"

And then a thump, the sound of a headboard against the wall, more howling and screaming from Marie, and then the slap of skin on skin and both of them yelling loudly as they came, together.

But the action didn't stop there.

As I lay on the floor, breathing heavily, wildly aroused, trying to imagine where my wife was hiding and what she could see or not see of what was transpiring in the master bedroom, the two lovers spoke in low tones to each other for about ten minutes.

I was starting to wonder how I would get out of there. How Scarlett would get out of there, how all of this would end without each and every one of us getting caught. What *would* happen if Dan came home right now? Or Scarlett fell from inside of a closet where she was tucked away? Or someone wandered down to this bedroom and found me on the floor?

I didn't have too much time to wonder about any of that, though, because Marie and Alessandro were back at it again.

From down the hall, I could hear the same coaxing tones of Alessandro's voice. The same resistance – easily overcome – from Marie.

Without hearing what she was saying, exactly, I recognized in her voice the same concern, the same desire to change the location of their tryst, the same fear of being caught. And ultimately, as with my wife, the same capitulation to his desires.

This time, the sex seemed rougher. The sounds that came from the bedroom down the hall were more feral, more of Alessandro grunting than Marie mewling. The slaps of their skin together were harder, there was no dirty talk, and it went on much longer. Marie finally crescendoed in a gasping, howling orgasm, followed about five minutes later by Alessandro.

From the sounds of it, he had manhandled her, much like he did with my wife.

My cock was throbbing painfully beneath my body by then. I had pushed myself up a little to keep my weight from crushing my erection. I was so aroused that I was barely sure I could restrain myself from storming down the hallway, looking for Scarlett, and throwing her on the bed to have my way with her, whether Marie or Alessandro or anyone were watching or not.

But I stayed where I was.

Marie and Alessandro stirred after a few minutes. I heard them talking, murmuring, then Marie saying shortly: “No, Alessandro, we have to go.”

But there was laughter in her voice, and then she giggled, and they kissed and moved around in the bedroom. Finally I heard a shower, then drawers opening and closing, and then Marie and Alessandro’s voices in the hallway.

“Stop it!” Marie said playfully.

Alessandro murmured something, she giggled.

“Where is your car?” Marie asked him.

His voice was low and I could no longer hear what he said clearly: they were descending the stairs. I heard Marie talking, saying something about shopping, moving around downstairs, the opening and closing of the door.

The beep-beep-beep-beep of a security code.

Oh fuck.

Then the two of them were gone.

The sing-song beep of the security code, and all that it indicated for my own escape, washed against the walls of my brain like a wave trapped

in a basin.

God, what the *fuck* was I doing, hiding on the floor of my boss's house, exposed to being caught by my wife, who also wasn't supposed to be here?

And how was I going to get out of this house?

Surely Scarlett knew the code.

I waited.

I heard the soft thump of feet on a floor. I had to strain to hear it, maybe I was imagining it.

And then, suddenly, the door opening again.

Beep-beep-beep-beep.

"I'll lock it up when I find it!" I heard Alessandro yell.

Marie yelled something from her car.

Alessandro's heavy frame thumped up the stairs.

"Phone, phone, phone," he sang.

The sound of a wet kiss, the murmur of his voice.

"Looks like I had it on me all along."

And then, closer to the landing of the hallway. "See you tonight, *gattina*."

My chest squeezed.

My cock pulsed.

Alessandro thumped down the stairs.

The door opened and closed.

No beep.

I closed my eyes.

Now that my escape from this – what? Nightmare? Fevered dream? – seemed possible again, a fresh wave of fear washed over me. For a few moments my doom had seemed preordained, and I had relaxed, like a criminal in jail with a guilty conscience.

But now, I might escape.

I might actually get away with witnessing this multi-layered voyeurism cake, and have the whole evening to ponder and enjoy the very perverted scene I had just witnessed.

Or, I thought, I could go catch my wife right now.

Wouldn't that be an expression to see?

My wife.

I heard her move down the hallway, but then there was nothing.

I rose, crept through the bathroom, and up to the doorway of the bedroom closer to the landing.

From there, I could very distinctly hear it, echoing in Marie's tile hallways: the unmistakable sticky sound of my wife masturbating.

Throwing caution to the wind, (for what could she possibly do if she caught me?), I walked calmly down the hallway to the landing.

Then a little further, until I could see, through a wedge in the doorway and by craning my head at a very uncomfortable angle, my wife's hair splayed out on the bed, her face upturned at the ceiling, looking at the far wall of the room. I could not see her hands, as her fingers sloshed around in her very wet pussy, but I could easily imagine the scene.

I lingered until I saw a shudder go through her – it didn't take long.

And then, suddenly calm, I retreated, and stepped slowly down the stairs. The confidence that I possessed as I did so was conferred by the realization that the worst that could happen if Scarlett saw me is that she would be scared out of her wits and have to confess to me.

And apologize, naturally.

And I could think of a million dirty ways for her to do that, right here on the steps of my boss's house, with her cum-stained mouth and her gushing pussy.

I was so taken by those ideas that I almost turned around.

But I kept going, right back out the door I had come through, turning left instead of right, tucking myself behind the far wing of the house that abutted the stone wall. I sat down on it and waited.

Scarlett snuck out the same way a few minutes later. I stared right at her as she walk-ran, in a weird half-crouch, through the yard, out of sight, to the front.

If she had looked behind her, she would have seen me, staring right at her.

But she didn't.

*

I went back to the office, because I had to finish all the work I had abandoned in order to chase down my wife. After torturous deliberation about where to do it (I couldn't go home, and risk running into Scarlett; I couldn't be caught masturbating in a parked car on a public road; I didn't

want to be jerking off in my office) I locked myself into the single bathroom and held the video of Scarlett fucking Alessandro against the wall as I jacked off and aimed for the toilet.

When the lights started dimming and people started packing up, I ensconced myself in my office with the door locked for good measure, and logged into my Heister Mobile app to tantalize myself with everything that had transpired while I had been following Scarlett. *The coast is clear*, Alessandro had written. *Use the back door*.

And when Scarlett had not responded:

Don't disappoint me, gattina.

I leaned back in my chair, the cold of fear in my veins, the weight of betrayal on my chest like an elephant, my cock hard and dripping precum, and jealousy gnawing at every soft place in my body.

This had all gone too far.

For one thing, I sensed that Scarlett had gotten herself in too deep. I could hear it in her voice, in her hesitation, the mild panic that was creeping in as she did wilder and wilder stunts with Alessandro.

My cock throbbed as I thought of the afternoon and everything it implied: that Scarlett not only knew about Marie, but was willing to hide and watch Alessandro fuck her. Was that *her* perverted fantasy, or his? Or both? Was she doing it because it turned her on, or was she just appeasing the master that Alessandro seemed to have become?

It didn't really matter, though, because now we were in very dangerous waters. It was bad enough that Scarlett was covering up Marie's affair: it was dangerous, with Dan being my boss. But at least if all she had been doing was covering up Marie's affair, there was some hope that even if Dan found out about it, Marie would sort of "owe" Scarlett something.

But this? Sneaking around Marie's house, watching her in the shadows while she had sex with Alessandro? Sucking Alessandro's cock just before Marie showed up?

That, if discovered, spelled the kind of crazy, feminine shitstorm that no one would escape from unharmed.

What the hell was Scarlett doing?

And then there was me: what was I doing? I, too, had crept around Dan and Marie's house (the memory of it, now that I was far away from the intense arousal of the moment, made me shudder with fear). Scarlett would probably be mad at *me* if she knew I was spying on her, and I couldn't even

picture what I would try to say if I got caught by Dan, in his house, spying on my wife, who was spying on Dan's wife, who was fucking the tennis instructor, in their bed, in the afternoon.

"Jesus," I muttered.

I resolved to finish up my work. Once again, Scarlett's affairs with Alessandro were consuming me, and I couldn't afford to be this distracted and behind at my job. Especially not when my wife was trespassing in my boss's house and hiding his wife's affair.

I resolved to put the whole thing on a back burner until I had some time to think of a way out. A good way out, for me just as much as for Scarlett.

But the Highster Mobile app, and all the delicious details it could give me (and the other delicious details it could not) was never far from my mind. The urge to set things up so that Scarlett would do something unfaithful was too great.

I sent her a message, and watched my application pick it up, put it on display for me. Then I stared at the app as her reply materialized on the screen after mine.

I think I'll have to work late tonight

Okay. Want anything for dinner? Or will you be later than that?

I could only see Scarlett's replies now as part of a plan to secure time with Alessandro. Would he go back to our house with her again if I told her I would be very late? Would she dare risk getting caught again, so soon after this afternoon?

I looked at the app. She had gone back to the club, curiously, and it looked like she was there now.

No dinner, probably after nine or so.

It took her forever to write back. A short, cryptic:

OK

The two letters burned a hole through my chest. The pain was delightful, traveling right to my groin as a hot ache. But I was also incensed by the abruptness of the reply, which had come so late. Had she leaned over to show Alessandro the text? Had they looked at each other knowingly, genitals throbbing to life, anxious to drive to my house – our house – and rut like animals in our bed?

My mind was overflowing with ideas about what had transpired there at the club. Did Scarlett re-appear and meet with Marie and Alessandro? Was it part of some act to help cover up Marie's affair?

And then what had happened? How did Scarlett and Alessandro fuck when they were alone together, and not in someone else's house? What kind of filthy things would he get up to with her after this afternoon's escapades? Would he make Scarlett recount what she had seen? Would he be deep in her ass in less than twenty minutes, dirty-talking her as he pounded her raw on our sheets?

I got to work, flitting my eyes to the app every five minutes or so.

When Scarlett's phone at last began to move, it went along a by-now familiar route, and I could almost see it my mind: down Cerillos, a left on Sage, another turn, headed to Alessandro's house.

The car stopped at some point, and Scarlett remained there, glowing. The tracker was only accurate to within twenty feet, so there was no telling if she had gotten out of the car, gone into a building. A romantic date? Stopping for a drink?

I hoped not. I couldn't bear the idea of Scarlett sitting and having a chat with Alessandro.

I pulled the location up on Google to see where it was. It looked like a warehouse of some kind.

Shopping?

It didn't fit.

I looked all around, searching on Street View for the answer. It was such a strange place to stop, where there were no stores or -

It hit me, cold and hot, all at once.

It was the perfect place to stop, if you couldn't wait until you got where you were going. If you were so aroused by the sexy wife of another man, who would sneak into her husband's boss's house to blow you and then watch you fuck another woman, who would let you slam your cock

into her ass as much as you wanted to, that you couldn't wait to get somewhere private to get her lips around your cock.

Another blowjob? Or did Scarlett have her legs on the windshield and Alessandro's cock in her pussy?

Or was she holding onto the headrest, her forehead tapping it slightly with each thrust, her ass getting pummeled from behind?

Fifteen minutes passed, and then she began to move again, turning toward Alessandro's apartment building.

She stayed there only half an hour, and then she began to move again. I tracked her movement, another familiar path: from Alessandro's house, to ours.

I scrambled to gather my things, a plan developing in my mind, made of incoherent thoughts and feelings. I wondered, as I practically ran to my car, if this was the way animals thought: not as ideas, neatly organized, but a series of charged, raw images, ideas distilled, freed of words.

I was all about acting now, not thinking.

*

Scarlett was in the shower. I heard the water running as soon as I opened the door. I had developed an eagle eye, and bat-like hearing, for all things that I *wanted* to hear. Signs of my wife's infidelity, her bad behavior, and her even more whoreish attempts to cover it all up.

Of course she was taking a shower.

I wondered if Alessandro had bothered to take a shower after hammering away at Marie, before sticking it right into Scarlett. I wondered if he had pushed my wife down on her knees to clean his cock off before he turned her around and pushed himself deep inside of her.

My cock was hard again as I whistled down the hallway, imagining Scarlett trying to erase the evidence of her bad deeds. Brushing her teeth, washing her pussy, spinning in soapy circles in the shower in an attempt to cleanse away the evidence of her Italian lover using her body like a five-dollar hooker.

I stripped as I walked, and crept for the second time that day through a bedroom, to a bathroom. I could see Scarlett in the shower, soap indeed streaming down her body, as she rubbed a loofah over her wet skin.

Her eyes were closed, her head leaning back.

I kicked off my boxer shorts, and stepped toward the shower.

Scarlett's eyes flew open in alarm. I wondered for a moment if her first thought was that the insatiable Alessandro had come to her house.

"Jesus!" she yelled. She clutched her hand to her chest. "I didn't hear you at all."

The shock was leaving her quickly, relief flooding her expression.

Probably thinking of how close she had come to getting caught, all day long, all the times she had been fucking Alessandro here, there and everywhere. She couldn't help but feel relief, because it was just me, right where I was supposed to be.

I reached for the shower door.

A new emotion began to creep into Scarlett's face, as I had known – as I had *hoped* – it would.

Discomfort.

For Scarlett could certainly see that I was in a randy mood: my cock was hard, pointed straight in front of me, and there could be no question of my intentions as I climbed into the shower.

How stretched and full of cum was Scarlett's pussy? Was her asshole still gaping from another violation by Alessandro's thick member? How fun would it be to slip into that hot and silky ass of hers, and feel the slick stain of Alessandro's cum, the pulsing engorgement of his abuse? All while Scarlett, my dear, defiled, cheating wife, pretended that nothing was amiss?

My cock pulsed at the idea.

So fun.

I had my hand in her hair, and my mouth on her lips, in seconds. I didn't give her any time to protest, no time to make some excuse or give me a funny look and ask me what I was doing.

I knew that if I could just get that far, she would feel far too guilty to try and stop me. And then she would be terrified that her body would reveal some aspect of her adultery. Maybe this would even force her to confess.

I pushed her back into the tiles. Her body was stiff with tension, even as she kissed me back.

That's it, Scarlett, I thought. She had no real choice but to give in to me, but she was tense with her guilty conscience.

I moved my hand down her hot stomach, while my right hand pinned her left to the tiles. She tried to slip her right hand over mine and reach for

my cock, but I pushed it away impatiently. No, Scarlett, I am going to get my fingers into all of your holes, all of the places you have let Alessandro fuck you today.

Her mouth tasted like toothpaste, and I dove into it deeply, hoping to find some briny droplet of cum, or the taste of Marie's pussy that she had maybe cleaned off of Alessandro's cock.

No such luck.

Her abdomen went stiff beneath my hand as I grazed over her bare cunt. I slid my fingers easily into her folds. The squeaky wet of the water relented to a slippery, sweet pussy-juice-wet, and her hard clit pulsed at my touch.

Guilty, but turned on as hell.

I stroked her pussy, slipped my fingers inside, and pinched her clit between my thumb and the two fingers sunken into her pussy.

I could feel her relaxing, her mouth opening, her body becoming less stiff.

Relief? What was I missing?

I played with her for a while, feeling a different tension build up inside of her, and then I drew my fingers up to my nose to smell them.

Nothing but the scent of her own sweet pussy.

She opened her mouth to let me slide them between her lips, and she sucked her juices from my fingers with relish, her eyes glittering.

I was overcome by an animal desire, hitting me just as I realized that her cheating was hiding somewhere else. And I was going to see it with my own eyes, and she was not going to stop me.

I think I said, "Turn around," as I rolled her against the wall so that her face was on the tile.

The stiffness of fear returned to her body, and she tried to push away from the wall.

I lifted her right hand and placed it on a small tiled ledge built into the shower, where a window looked out onto the backyard. I held it there while I grasped her other flailing arm and put it on her back, then pinched it to her lower back in a kind of vice grip with my fingers on her soft belly.

I pulled her toward me, using my elbow and my back to turn off the water, until her ass was sticking out behind her.

"Will," she said, and it was a bewildered and throaty, fearful half-question.

But she was too late to do anything about it, because I pushed her right hand down firmly on the tile to indicate that she should leave it there, and then I moved my right hand quickly to her pussy, dipped my fingers in again, and felt her body stiffen with desire.

She looked behind her, obediently keeping her hand on the tiles. My left hand still held her arm clamped to her lower back, resting on the shelf of her back and her ass. I finger-fucked her for a while, drawing her slowly out of her concerns to relaxing into her arousal. Her stomach tightened, she bucked against me as her climax neared.

I looked down at my prize: the pink center of her ass. I couldn't see it, and I didn't want to warn her.

I lined my cock up with her sodden entrance and fed it into her pussy. The angle of her body pushed the flesh of her canal onto the top of my cock, a delightful pressure that I had to block from my mind to keep from exploding right then and there.

The wet fingers I had been fucking her cunt with were now liberated and lubed up, and I moved quickly, now that she was pinned there. I released her left hand and pulled her ass apart with my hands, to expose the eyelet of her ass.

My cock pulsed when I saw it: reddened, obviously recently fucked.

Scarlett started to move, trying to get me to saw faster inside of her, her own body very close to tipping over the edge. She must have been so consumed by her needs that she had forgotten that the damning evidence of her whoreishness was on display for me, then and there.

I plunged my fingers into her ass, no warning, no build-up.

Because she had probably let Alessandro fuck her there not even two hours ago, they slipped in easily, her ringlet stretched and supple. She gasped, and threw her head back, squirming and twisting. I realized after a moment that it was probably because her ass was sore from so much abuse, and because she loved it, and she was about to come.

I could feel Alessandro's slimy cum in her ass. Scarlett bucked wildly, mewling now, saying something that I failed to understand because my focus was on one thing only.

She rocked against me, and her body became stiff with a tremendous orgasm coming on. I felt her pussy pulse, and her ass squeezed against my fingers. As she came, I slipped them out, and dipped my left thumb in on

one side of her hole. I pulled them apart as her ass squeezed and pulsed with her orgasm, and she milked the cum from my cock with her pussy.

I had only a second to look inside of her before my vision blurred and I yelled loudly, shoving myself into her pussy as deep as I could go, emptying my own cum inside of her.

But it was long enough, the image burned into my brain:

Scarlett's reddened asshole, stretched to a thin red ring, the hot pink insides wet and pulsing, and from the center, boiling up, erupting like lava from a volcano:

The creamy white load that Alessandro had left inside her.

Scarlett's body was shaking as we leaned against the tiles for a few more moments. She looked down the curvy line of her body, then lifted her eyes to meet mine. She was searching for something, an indication, maybe, of whether the damning evidence of Alessandro's cum in her ass had been detected.

My cock pulsed just thinking about it. God, what a slut. I leaned forward and kissed her, and she seemed relieved that maybe I hadn't noticed. I was very much enjoying, though, that she was reeking with guilt, still unsure if she had gotten away with it or not.

Again, my cock thickened inside of her, and she looked back at me with surprise. She wriggled, trying to get away from me, walking her hands up the tiles and trying to stand, so that my cock would flop out of her.

But thinking of everything she had done, all of her cheating and cover-ups, all the dangerous and reckless things she would do for Alessandro, not to mention the load of cum oozing from her ass – I was hard again, and I did not slip from her pussy. Her body rolled around me.

"Will," she said, looking back at me as I reached forward to get her hair in my fingers. "Again?"

She was smiling, but her smile was reticent. Was she sore from being a whore all day?

She wriggled away as I was thinking about this, making a turn and looking at me disbelievingly as she came to face me. Her eyes dropped to my cock, which was hard again.

I could see a number of emotions playing out on her face: it was clear that for whatever reason, because she was sore, because she was feeling guilty, maybe because she only wanted Alessandro's cock in a public place

where she would get caught, she didn't really *want* to go at it again with me.

But she had no choice, did she? I could see her realize that, a look almost of resignation coming over her face.

"Wow," she said, reaching to grasp my cock in her hand.

Then she reached for the shower door. "Okay, but it's a little awkward in here. Shower sex is not all it's cracked up to be -"

I followed her and pushed her up to the counter, bending her over it until her head was against the mirror. I had a nice view that way, of the curve of her spine as she arched slightly to try and fit against the glass. Her breasts swung in front of her, nipples erect. Water snaked down her skin, mingled with sweat.

I didn't waste any time with that, though, I just got right inside of her. Her pussy was soaked, and the angle of her body against my cock rubbed freshly on new, sensitive sides of my cock. I reached forward and wound my hand in her hair to pull her face up so that she was looking in the mirror.

Her eyes locked on mine as I slammed into her hard. Five deep, dominating thrusts, and I was already going over the edge.

Scarlett's eyes were on mine – what message was I conveying? I don't know. But I held her eyes with my own gaze and fucked my cum into her again, in a matter of minutes.

Then I slid out of her, still panting, and surveyed the red of her asshole, nestled in the white of her skin. Her bright pink pussy lips, distended and swollen, and the white cum trickling down her thighs.

Scarlett was still watching me in the mirror, disbelief and guilt playing with her features. She couldn't deny, though, that she was also aroused, though I assumed that the heat of her infidelity tore at her both ways, as it did to me.

I wiped my mouth, burning one last stare into her. I wondered if she could see it in my eyes. *I know what you did*, I'm sure it teleported to her.

I gave it a few seconds, and then Scarlett dropped her eyes. Maybe she was about to confess to everything: her lips parted, and she was sucking in a deep breath of air.

The words were leaving my mouth before I really knew why.

"I'm starving," I said jovially. "Want to get a late dinner at *El Torito*?"

Scarlett looked up again, more disbelief on her face.

"That's what I *actually* came home for," I added.

And then, realizing that I didn't *want* Scarlett to admit any of this to me just yet, I turned and walked into the bedroom closet, whistling.

*

It was a strange thing, accepting, as I did, that something I really enjoyed was my wife lying to me, sneaking around on me, wriggling in discomfort as she tried to manage her affair with another man. But once I accepted it, everything became a lot more fun for me.

Sinister fun, but fun nonetheless.

I couldn't possibly concoct plans to see Scarlett with Alessandro every time they fucked, though I desperately wanted to. I had to piece together what she was doing from her text messages and her location, and then from the evidence that was left on, or in, her body or her clothes.

Which Scarlett was getting quite adept at hiding.

There was no hiding, though, that Alessandro liked to fuck her in the ass. I wondered if she thought that her ass didn't look raw and abused after that bull threw it into her so enthusiastically.

Or maybe she didn't know I was looking, constantly, for the evidence.

But a man cannot live off his imagination alone, and I started to get more and more bold about almost "catching" her. I started going through her stuff, looking for new lingerie, panties stuffed in her purse, anything at all that I could savor that was real, smelling and feeling of her betrayal.

I lucked out one day when I found her bullet – the one that Alessandro had bought for her, the one that operated remotely – in her purse. She had tucked it away into a box, and the box in a brown bag, so that it looked like a purchase from a pharmacy.

But nothing was safe from me, because I opened everything.

It was morning, so it wasn't hard to see that she had some kind of plan involving Alessandro later in the day. Maybe it involved Marie – though it was a Tuesday, and not the day for their "lessons."

I wondered what devious thing Alessandro would do with that bullet, or when he would make her put it in.

I found out around three, when Alessandro texted her.

We are still on for this afternoon?

Yes

Don't forget to bring your toy. Have it in, I'm going to play with you first

I pictured my wife someplace public, the bullet in her ass, Alessandro watching her squirm as he made it vibrate. Her face would get red, sweat would form on her upper lip. She would shift slightly in her seat and try to keep from revealing her secret.

But what was “this afternoon?” that they were still on for?

I watched her car as it moved from her work, to the historic center.

I located the approximate address on Google street view.

It could have been a lot of things, but as I looked around the area and the streets, I somehow knew: it was the Hilton Santa Fe.

I made my excuses without even thinking about what I was doing. And then I drove straight to the hotel and parked in a lot around the block. I fished a hat out from the trunk of my car – a fedora I had purchased for the costume party, but not the one I had worn.

Now, it would come in handy, along with sunglasses. I put them on, caught my ridiculous reflection in the glass of a boutique, but walked bravely on. Straight ahead, into the Hilton.

I need not have worried about being seen. She was there, at the bar, sitting on a red, high-backed stool. Alessandro was next to her, an arm over the back of the stool, just below Scarlett's shoulders. Possessively.

Another man was at the end of the bar, on the side, but definitively attached to their group.

I walked to a free couch in the lobby, where I had a difficult view of the three of them. I held my phone in front of me as though I were reading it, and watched, my head tipped down and my eyes straining over the rims of my sunglasses.

Scarlett was looking mildly uncomfortable, there was no doubt about it. The third person – also a man with dark hair had an athletic build, a lot like Alessandro's. He sat with his legs spread apart wide, his forearms on the bar, leaning toward Scarlett in an unmistakably hungry way. The coiled strength of his forearms indicated he was also a tennis player.

Alessandro ordered them some more drinks, and the conversation shrunk inward, ever more intimate. Alessandro put his hand on Scarlett's

knee, beginning to stroke it, and then he used his other hand to push her hair back over her shoulder.

This went on for a long time, and there was a definite tension between the three of them.

I stared, and leaned in for another look.

It was hard to tell, but it seemed like the third man had put his hand under the bar, and was reaching for Scarlett's knee.

She was smiling at him.

There was little doubt about what happened next: Alessandro trailed his hand down Scarlett's forearm. For a moment I could not make out what it was between his fingers, but in a flash of recognition it came to me as he slipped it onto the bar and pushed it across toward his friend.

The remote.

The friend took it, and it disappeared from my view, but he was moving his arms like he was examining it.

Scarlett was bouncing her foot beneath the table, giving the third man a sultry look. Almost like she was daring him to do something.

When he did, her eyelids drooped slightly, and her face changed as she tried to maintain composure while he tortured her with the bullet. Her lips parted and I knew her breath was shaky.

Alessandro was amused, watching her reaction, still trailing his fingers along her forearm.

He leaned close to her and whispered something in her ear. He pushed her hair back again and gave his companion a look before he nibbled on my wife's ear. His mouth was moving, surely talking his dirty, humiliating talk into her ear.

I realized then what was happening, and you might find it funny that I did not before. They asked for the check, Scarlett continued to squirm, and Alessandro continued to stroke her like a pet cat. He held up a drink for her and she drank it obediently, squirming some more in the booth.

Then they all stood up, and the stranger took her hand, pulling him close to her, to walk out of the bar with her with a hand slipped around her waist, as though they were a couple.

They rounded the corner, as I stared in disbelief.

And then they got into an elevator, and were gone.

I followed them up, but the elevator had stopped on both floors before coming back down, so I didn't even know for sure what floor they were on. The halls were empty, with no sign of where they had gone. I walked slowly down them, my ears pricked up for hearing the sounds of my wife screaming in pleasure as she was ridden hard by the two hot men.

But I never found them.

I went across the street to a park and found a bench from where I could watch Scarlett's car in the parking lot. Then I came up with the devious plan of calling Scarlett as if there were some emergency, until she picked up.

But she didn't pick up, and the third time I called I started to wonder what I would tell her was so damn important that I had to call three times about it.

She exited the building – alone – about an hour later.

My phone rang, and I watched as she brought it to her ear and crossed the street.

"Hello?" I answered.

"It's me," she said, her voice urgent. She was looking frantically around the lot.

I said nothing.

"You called, like three times?" she said, impatient. "Are you okay?"

I paused, savoring the worry on her face, the way my pause made her stop next to her car and scan the street outside the gates.

"I must have pocket dialed you," I told her.

"Oh," she said. "Oh, okay."

"What's up? You seem a little strange," I ventured.

She sat down in her car, looking at the floor. "No, no," she said unconvincingly. "No, everything's fine."

There was a long pause.

"So you don't need anything?" she asked, at last.

"No, sorry, no emergency here."

There was another long pause, and I thought she sounded like she was getting choked up. "Okay. Well... do you think you'll be home earlier tonight?"

In truth, I really was going to have to work late, thanks to my afternoon adventures. "Oh, I'm so slammed...I really have to -"

"Will," Scarlett interrupted. "I..."

I stopped talking, but her voice trailed off. My heart beat faster, and my chest ached.

“What?” I said, as gently as possible.

“I just... is there any way you could... I need to talk to you.”

I gulped. “Is it serious?” I asked quietly.

There was a long pause, and in the car I saw Scarlett lift her head, and squint, frowning, at the window. Something I had said had tipped her off, something made her sensitive lawyer’s nose sniff a whiff of my own deception.

“Find a way to be home, okay? It’s important.”

“Okay,” I agreed. “Just... can you tell me what it -”

“Just, let’s talk about it at home, okay?”

*

Scarlett was standing in the living room, her eyes a little red, her arms folded over her chest. The kitchen was a slight shambles, like she had been looking for something in the mail.

“What is it?” I asked, trying to make my voice sound as natural as possible. Though at this point, it was rather hard to imagine what that might be.

What if I didn’t know any of this – about Marie, Alessandro, this afternoon? What would my reaction be to Scarlett telling me she wanted to talk?

It had come to me in the car: I would ask her if she was pregnant. That’s what I would really do.

And I hadn’t done that, and now Scarlett knew that something was off.

I wanted to keep up my act, but I just couldn’t. I couldn’t use that question in that way, especially because I knew that in the end, my complicity in her affair, my sneaky phone tapping and following her around, was going to be unearthed.

I found myself thinking the same thing I imagine a lot of criminals do: what the fuck was I thinking was going to happen? Of course I was going to get caught.

I set my briefcase down. Of course, Scarlett was the real offender here.

But I didn't like the sinking sensation in my heart, the bitter taste of shame in my mouth.

Scarlett was shaking as she put her hands on the counter. She shook her head. A fat wet tear rolled out her eye.

"Do you already know about it?" she whispered. "I feel like you do."

I froze. It wasn't what I had expected her to say at all.

I expelled a huge, long breath.

Just like that, it suddenly felt good to be skipping over the lies, and telling the truth.

"I know," I said, and Scarlett looked up at me quickly. Her eyes started to form into an accusatory squint, but then she must have thought better of it, realized that she had little leverage to be sneering at me for lying when she had been the most outrageous, lying whore for months.

Her hands flew to her mouth instead and she covered it.

"I just don't understand *why*," I said.

Scarlett began to shake her head even more furiously, and the tears were really flowing now. "Oh, *God*," she said, running one hand through her hair impatiently. "I don't know! I don't have any idea. I just... got... but now it's..." Her eyes returned to mine, glassy and wet, moving quickly as though in a panic. "Everything just got out of – how much do you know?"

"A lot," I said, approaching the counter, looking down at her hand.

She sniffed. "Will. I didn't want for any of this to happen. I really didn't. I just... it just kind of... and now I don't know what to do to get out of it. I don't know what... I don't know..."

She broke down into tears, and it took a while, with me stiffly rubbing her back, unsure of how I felt, to get her calmed down and coax the story out of her. We went to the bedroom, and sat side by side on the bed.

But it went something like this:

After we returned from France, she was determined not to see Alessandro anymore. He had kind of turned her off by taking off at the hotel like he had, and she had, just as she'd told me at the time, felt like their physical relationship was getting to be too much for her.

But Alessandro was not the kind of man to be brushed off so easily.

She had a strange kind of attraction to him, too. One she didn't particularly know how to explain: she wanted him to pursue her, to be attracted to her, to want to fuck her. She wanted the specific kind of primal sex they had, but also she intensely disliked him in many ways. It reminded her of a high school crush on a jock. She was embarrassed that she liked him, liked fucking him, found him attractive.

So Alessandro had contacted her a few times after we'd returned, and Scarlett had blown him off. But she had put herself, deliberately, in positions where she would see him. Places where she would be able to flirt with the danger, the *possibility*, of Alessandro, but not go all the way again. She was embarrassed that she even thought about it, or thought about him. He was too dominating, and she couldn't believe the things she had done to please him.

The things she *would* do to please him, if he asked. And he almost certainly would.

But, like an addict, she kept circling back into his orbit.

It had been Scarlett, not Marie, who had suggested the tennis lessons anew. Scarlett had been feigning, to Alessandro, herself, and anyone else who found out about it, that the idea had come from Marie. She had interrupted more than one conversation abruptly, like she had at the party, to avoid Marie saying something that would contradict Scarlett's lie: Scarlett had influenced Marie to take the lessons. It was a perfect foil: she would appear to have been dragged, unwillingly, back into Alessandro's orbit by her husband's boss's wife, someone she could hardly say "no" to. And then she would still be there, sweating in tight shirts and short skirts, feeling Alessandro's desire for her, skating around it, skimming the surface of it, but able to always back out because "Marie was watching."

It had been a perfect plan, until Alessandro had started hitting on Marie. And then things had become even wilder when Marie not only allowed Alessandro to hit on her, she threw herself into the relationship with wild abandon. The breast implants, the spa treatments... as I had suspected, and Scarlett knew, had all been for Alessandro. He had Marie wrapped around his little finger, and she was spending money on him like it was going out of style.

It was true that Marie had asked Scarlett if she had had an affair with Alessandro, and that Scarlett had lied and told her she had not. It was also

true that Marie had been horribly embarrassed and begged Scarlett to cover for her.

At that point, even though Scarlett was incensed with Alessandro, and found herself pained by a bizarre form of jealousy, she had also grown to like Marie. She had resolved to cover for Marie, and keep her distance from Alessandro.

In the end, Scarlett was driven mad by a strange vein of jealousy and competitiveness. She loathed herself for it, but she couldn't believe that Alessandro was choosing Marie, of all people, to replace her. Marie was very attractive, but Scarlett wanted to be more so. And Alessandro knew what he was doing: once she gave the green light to Marie, they stopped hiding their flirtation, their physical contact.

From there, Alessandro had just reeled Scarlett right back in. The tension between them built and built: she knew he was looking at her with desire, that everything about his affair with Marie was designed to make her jealous.

The dam had finally broken when she had needed a ride to get back to the office, because her car was broken down and AAA was going to take forever to get there. Or rather, she had contrived to need a ride, not a cab or an Uber, not a lift from Marie.

Alessandro had driven in the wrong direction, back up to the place where Scarlett and I had fucked lustfully in a field. She had pretty much directed him there, after complaining falsely that he was going the wrong way.

From there, it had been a quick descent into depravity. Alessandro kept asking Scarlett to do wilder and wilder things, and she just kept doing them.

"And then," Scarlett concluded, taking a deep breath. She was not particularly tearful, but she had her eyes on the ground in shame, and her expression was one of a person who just doesn't know what to do. "I told him I had to get out of this somehow. He was making me do things-"

"What things?" I interrupted.

I wanted a confession, I wanted the lush details of her infidelity.

Scarlett looked at me, and her face was twisted into a kind of horrified expression. I could see that she understood that if I was going to forgive her, she would have to admit to what she had done. Her cheeks flushed red, and she gave that little shake of her head, the one that was pure,

fantastical denial. It was almost as though she thought that she could shake away the humiliation of telling me the story if only she pretended that it didn't exist. Her mouth opened and closed.

And then she looked down again. She wiped her nose, even though she wasn't crying. "He, um..." she looked back up at him. "Please, if I tell you, do you promise not to hate me? I can't even believe what I've done, I just..." she looked helpless. She looked up at the ceiling. "I don't know why I kept this secret from you, it wasn't to hurt you, it was just to... because I couldn't believe that I was so... so... so..."

"Submissive," I finished for her.

My cock throbbed. I couldn't wait to hear her every delicious detail.

Scarlett looked at me in helpless admission.

"Tell me what happened," I said, forcing calm into my voice. "I want everything."

Scarlett looked at the floor. She didn't know where to start.

"Anal sex?" I said, to get her started.

She nodded.

"But you like that," I suggested. "Don't you?"

Scarlett shrugged and held her hands out. Of course she did, but she didn't want to admit it.

"Did he put your bullet back in?"

She nodded.

"In public places?"

"While playing tennis with Marie."

I savored this for a moment. "Anywhere else?"

"He... so... he wanted me to come and watch him when he was...."

The last part of Scarlett's sentence trailed away. I knew she had said, "with Marie," but I wanted her to say it, loud enough for me to hear it.

"What?"

She looked up at me. "When he was with Marie."

I pretended to be surprised. "How'd that work?"

Scarlett covered her face with her hands. "Oh, God, so this is the thing, this is part of the problem." She drew in a shaky breath, and dropped her hands to her knees.

She was at the point of confession now. It was all going to come out.

Don't worry, I thought, my cock oozing a pearl of pre-cum.

Confession is good for the soul.

“He made me go there and watch them together.”

“Where?”

She let out a sigh and looked at the ceiling. “Ooohhh,” she complained. “At Marie’s house.”

There was a silence. I suppose she thought I was stunned. “He also made me come back here a couple of times,” she said. “He... you remember that night I asked you to bring me food? It was because he had insisted we come here, and then he wanted to come... *here*.” She waved around the bedroom.

“And you did?” I asked.

Scarlett put her hand to her mouth and leaned her elbow on her knee. “I know. It’s terrible. It’s so... I’ve done so many other bad things. I knew I had to stop, I already knew it when he started asking about this stuff, these crazy ideas. But then he told me he would tell Marie, he would tell Marie that I was fucking him all along, that I had watched them together, and that he’d throw you in for good measure. He pretty much... he started blackmailing me I guess.”

You guess? I thought. You’re a fucking lawyer.

“That’s the definition of blackmail.”

She rubbed her face. “I know.”

“But...?”

She sighed. “But, nothing. It is blackmail. It’s... it’s totally wrong and out of control and I hate it now...”

“But you like it.”

She stopped wringing her hands, and the tears that had threatened to overflow suddenly dried up. She sniffed. She shrugged. She shook her head, as if trying to make the world disappear. “I’m such a... I can’t believe this is who I am.”

Then she turned to me. “I’m sorry,” she said. “I should have... I know I should have told you from the beginning.”

I put a hand on her knee, and I moved it quickly up her leg. “I just don’t understand,” I said, and my voice was more aggressive than I had anticipated because I was so hungry to fuck her senseless that I felt like an animal. I pushed her back on the bed and unwrapped her from the tweed skirt she was in. I ripped her blouse open and stared at the black, lacy lingerie she was wearing.

Her eyes fell to my erection, to my hands unbuckling my belt and my pants.

“Spread your legs,” I told her.

She obeyed, her face still wrought with confusion, but hopeful now, that I might forgive her for being such a slut. And I would: I would because it was hot, I would because she had confessed, and I would because I needed her forgiveness for watching her, letting this all go on.

“What did you do this afternoon, you little slut?” I breathed. “Tell me the truth.”

Scarlett had her hands on her bra, fingering the straps, moving them down her body. She reached her navel, then reached forward to grab my cock.

My dick pulsed in her hand, and I grasped her wrist and shook my head: I was so wildly hot that I would probably come in a second if she started to stroke me. And I wanted to *fuck* her, or at least hear this story, before I did.

I reached for her ankles and pushed her legs up, forcing her knees to open. Her bare mound rose in a gentle hill beneath her stained panties. I could smell her scent, but beneath it was the acrid scent of cum.

Scarlett blushed. “Promise me you won’t be mad.”

I pushed one leg up, so that her ankle was next to her ears, and pulled her hand to it to hold it in place. I then used my freed hand to pull her panties away from her pussy, hooking them on the heel of her still-in-place shoes. When I let up the pressure on her right foot, it kicked away slightly, pulling the panties away from her red, engorged pussy.

Creamy white juices oozed from her pussy lips, the inner ones bright, glistening, and ragged from the obvious fucking she’d had.

“Tell me everything and I’ll forgive you,” I said.

She closed her eyes. “He made me fuck his friend,” she whispered.

I pulled on her right heel, and watched as the black panties stretched, the fabric thinning near her ass and cutting in between her buttocks. The hips stretched, the fabric started to tear, and then suddenly it gave.

Scarlett’s shoe flew off, and I grabbed her ankle, pushing her other foot up to her ear. She held it for me with no beckoning necessary, and spread her legs open like a frog so that I could see what I wanted to: the evidence of her cheating, dripping from inside of her.

“Where did he fuck you, Scarlett?”

She closed her eyes again. "We went downtown, we went to -" I touched her pussy, trailing my fingers down to her ass. I could feel that it was gaping, I shivered with delight at the story I knew I was about to hear. "I mean, *where* did he fuck you?"

Scarlett's eyes opened and she met my stare. Her cheeks grew red. "They did it at the same time," she said, Her voice was quiet.

"I want you to say it, Scarlett. Use the word fuck. Tell me where you let them put their cocks, and then tell me how much you liked it."

Scarlett's cheeks deepened in color, and she looked down at my dick again. "Alessandro fucked me in my pussy, and then his friend did, and then Alessandro fucked me in the ass."

My cock almost burst, bobbing wildly, precum dripping out of it almost as if I came.

But I hadn't. The ache in my dick was so intense now, a gentle breeze might have sent me over the edge.

"And...?"

Scarlett looked right at me. "And I liked it."

I drew a finger from her soaked pussy, passing over her clit and making her legs jerk, to her ass. It was stretched, wet, oozing cum like her cheating cunt. My finger disappeared inside of it with almost no pressure.

I started to finger fuck her, watching how her body responded, feeling her muscles contract and relax, the silky, slimy interior of her ass. "Do you have a big load of cum in your ass, Scarlett?"

Her lips parted slightly. Her feet were bobbing with the rhythm of my finger-fucking, one heel on, one heel off. "Yes."

"Say it."

"I have two big loads of cum in my ass."

I flipped her over faster than I could think of anything else to say, and pushed her torso down to the bed. She was the one who pushed her ass up in the air for me, and her hole opened, gaping, reddened, and oozing white cum.

You little slut, I remember thinking, and maybe even saying, as I shoved myself inside of her.

She gasped, but her ass was so slicked up already, and she liked getting fucked there so much, that I didn't hesitate to fuck her raw. After all, she loved it.

There were more details forthcoming over the rest of the evening, which we spent coming back together, at first warlike, then more tenderly, until finally Scarlett had disgorged all that she had done, and I was satisfied that I could forgive her, and tell her about my own sins.

She lay with her head on my chest, and I was stroking the arm she had thrown over me. By then, she had sucked my cock, and I had fucked my cum into her pussy and used her body in terrible ways while making her tell me all the things she had done for Alessandro.

“Something is still bothering you,” she said. She was tired, and how could she not be? I didn’t think she could take any more, and it was almost three in the morning.

I turned my head so I could see her face, and she looked up at me expectantly. “You can’t forgive me,” she said, in a defeated tone.

I shook my head. “I have to tell *you* something,” I said.

Scarlett’s eyes came alive suddenly, and I could feel her pulse start to race.

She propped herself up on her elbow and looked at me.

I took a deep breath. “This might make you mad,” I said. “But I think you’ll understand why I forgive you.”

And then, looking at the ceiling, holding her fingers in my hand, I told her all about how I had suspected her, used Highster Mobile on her phone, and provoked her affair more than I had tried to stop it.

Scarlett pushed herself up and onto her knees, a look of disbelief on her face. Her mouth was open, and rage was rampant on her features. “You mean you -”

“Hold it,” I said, holding up a finger. “Before you fly off the handle, I want you to think for a minute about the things that you’ve done.”

“I felt so *guilty!*” she exclaimed.

Her mouth was open.

This could go any number of ways, I remember thinking. I was really worried it might go very far south, in a big hurry.

“Listen,” I said. “How about we just think about this: we were both doing something kind of wrong. And we were both getting off on it. And we should have just told each other, sure, but let’s be fair. You liked how wrong it was, and sneaking around, as much as I did.”

“You little *shit.*”

There was a smile somewhere on her lips, threatening to emerge.

"I *am* a shit. Totally. I was totally being a shit. But I got off on it, and you... I was there, that day you were hiding at Marie's house. And so -"

"You *what*?!!!"

I shrugged my shoulders. "I followed you. I was in the house."

Her mouth fell open. "No. Way."

"I saw you, at the end. So all I'm saying is..." I reached for her hand, because I wanted to bring things back to where we were buddies again, partners in crime. "We both liked the danger. And we both got off on the secrets and lies. And I'm okay with that, now that we've told each other everything." I pulled her hand toward my lips, and kissed her fingertips. "Be okay with it, too," I said. "Please."

She looked at me blankly for a moment, her mouth still open in disbelief. She made a turn and fell back down to the bed, face-up, next to me.

And then, finally, the smile.

"I cannot *believe*," she said. "That you snuck into their house... you're *kidding*, right?"

"I'm not."

She shook her head, smiling.

We kissed.

"I love you," I said, and I pressed my forehead against hers, and almost got overwhelmed by my sudden emotions. I rolled onto her, my cock incredibly enough, hard again, and I slipped into her sloppy-wet pussy.

"I love you," she said.

We made love, and I knew she was all mine again.

Then we fell asleep.

But when the first rays of light woke us too early, she rolled over onto her back and stared at the ceiling again.

"I still don't know what I'm going to do about this problem with him," she said.

I stared at the ceiling.

"He's got to go," I said.

Scarlett turned to me. "Not -?"

"We just have to find something to make him lose his job. Or something."

"It *can't* involve Marie," Scarlett said. "I don't want her having a problem because of this."

"No," I agreed.

"And he could always tell Dan. About me sneaking into the house and watching."

"Does he have any proof?" I asked.

Scarlett shrugged. "The suggestion is so preposterous, he wouldn't need any, would he? The very idea getting planted in Dan's head would be terrible for you."

We were silent.

"So what can we do?" she said quietly.

I closed my eyes, thinking.

But we were both there at the same time. We looked at each other.

Marie.

She would have to be brought in on it.

I found myself saying it before I could believe it.

"I'll talk to her."

*

Marie, impeccably dressed and pounds thinner than when I first met her, red hair coiffed and makeup flawless, smoothed a cloth napkin over her lap and lifted a glass of water to my own.

I cleared my throat.

Marie had changed a lot since I'd first met her, and it wasn't just the burgeoning breasts under her shifting, crimson, long-sleeved miracle of a dress with a savagely hot dip in the center of her breasts. There was also a sort of wild confidence oozing from her, and a wryness that had never been there before.

She sipped her water.

"I take it this isn't a business meeting," she said dryly. "So I ordered a carafe of wine."

Which came almost instantaneously, as though she possessed the power to summon a waiter from thin air.

The waiter poured the wine, and Marie winked at him as he left.

Marie. She had turned into a cougar, right before my eyes.

She shifted her eyes back to me, and they were steady and watchful. She took a sip of her wine. "Well, Will. Why are we here?"

I cleared my throat and smoothed the tablecloth.

Marie gulped some wine, indelicately, and set her glass down with immeasurable grace. She was disconcerting as fuck. "Does Dan know?" she asked, abruptly. Her tone sounded more annoyed than anything else, like she was asking a mechanic about a car repair.

"Huh?" I gurgled, surprised.

"Oh come off it," she said.

The waiter was back. Marie smiled up at him and handed her menu to him. "Just bring me some kind of salad, with some grilled chicken." The waiter opened his mouth to ask about the dressing, and Marie cut him off. "Oil and vinegar."

I handed him the menu. "I'm good with the wine," I said.

Marie rolled her eyes.

The waiter departed.

"So, cut to the chase," she continued. She crossed her legs and sipped her wine, then set it down, annoyed. "I should have ordered a martini."

Then she looked at me, expectant. Her face told me not to bullshit about the topic of discussion.

"Uh, so... well, actually, I'm just – to make sure we're talking about the same -"

"My affair with Alessandro," she said, waving her hand impatiently. "That's why you're here, because there's no other reason for you to ask me to lunch in such a somber and serious tone. Who told you? Scarlett?"

I held up a finger. "Actually, well, not exactly. I, um, saw you with him. At that party."

Marie narrowed her eyes. "You," she hissed. Then she seemed amused. "I knew someone was in that bathroom. You know you left footprints on everything?"

I made a strange sound. This conversation was not going exactly how I had expected.

Marie pushed her plates away and leaned on the table. Her dress hung low, and I unwittingly admired her new breasts. She noticed, and leaned forward, a smug smile on her lips.

"So what's the deal, Will. Bottom line? Are you here to tell me you have to tell Dan, or that Scarlett can't cover for me anymore, or what?"

I took a breath. Marie was plowing ahead through all the parts of the conversation I had expected to be difficult, and her new personality was disturbing me. I was caught off-guard. “It’s, uh... actually not that, at all -”

“Because I have to be absolutely clear with you about something, Will, and that’s this: Dan and I have a prenup, and *I’m* not getting dicked around on it. Dan’s has a list of affairs to his name, I just don’t have any proof of them. You know something? It’s Dan’s own fault I’m having an affair, and I’ve spent my whole life supporting him, and his career, and that damn firm. So you tell me what it is you want, or why you’re here, but then know this: I will take you down *in flames* if you so much as *think* about telling my husband about this.”

Wow.

I raised my eyebrows.

“You know you’d make a great corporate lawyer,” I said, lacking anything better to say.

Marie smiled.

But not too much.

“Too late for that, though, isn’t it?”

Then she sipped her wine and shot daggers at me over the rim.

I cleared my throat again, which wasn’t even a habit I had. I just needed to buy some time so I didn’t sound idiotic in front of this unexpected version of Marie. Time to adjust my strategy. “So, Marie, I’m not actually here about that, so much... well, sort of. Just not in the way you think. I think, actually I’m very glad to hear you say that because I think -”

“You know you *really* are a bit incoherent for a lawyer,” Marie interrupted.

Her face was a delicate dance of agitation and amusement.

“We have interests that align,” I said simply.

Marie was silent. Her eyes were fixed, her mind working fast.

Man. I’d really misjudged this woman.

“Tell me,” she said, a smile forming on her lips. “How on earth is that?”

Marie listened to my story, and her expression barely changed as she did.

“Scarlett,” she said at the end. I had no idea how to take it. She sounded...

Well, more impressed than angry, or jealous that Scarlett was sleeping with her boy-toy.

What a piece of work Marie was turning out to be.

She was so different from the Marie that Scarlett had portrayed in her own story. I wondered if her affair had changed her drastically, or if Marie’s entire, semi-tearful act with Scarlett had all been part of a master plan of Marie’s, to recruit someone to cover up her affair.

It was a bit ruthless. But one thing I’d learned in corporate and contract law was that ruthless people were reliable: they went after their goal, no matter what, and so you just needed to be creative and find a way to make sure them getting their goal swept you up on your way to your goal as well.

She ordered another bottle of wine. I had swallowed a good glass and a half, and Marie was really knocking it back.

She shook her head disbelievingly.

“So how is it you think we can help each other?” she said, finally, squinting at nothing in particular.

“Well, there’s... Scarlett needs Alessandro out of her life,” I said.

Marie gave a sharp, bitter laugh. “Don’t we all?” She rolled her eyes again.

“You’re not...?” I asked, letting her fill in the blanks.

“Oh, honestly,” she said. “He’s tiresome. Fun. But tiresome. I can take it or leave it at this point. And right now, he’s more trouble than he’s worth...” She pressed her fingertips together. I could see that some evil thought occurred to her. Then she smiled. “*Mostly.*”

Good God, the woman was terrifying.

“But,” she said, her face lighting up as though she’d just had an idea. “So you and Scarlett, you’re obviously not... *conservative* about your marriage?”

Hardly.

I shook my head, wondering where she was headed with this.

Marie tapped the table and watched her own fingers. “So, say, I needed Scarlett to have sex with someone, she would maybe do it?”

My heart dropped.

But not really.

Marie flicked her eyelids and looked at me. She was deadly beautiful, and my heart was cool in my chest as I waited for her to say what I was just realizing I had known all along.

“I have it on good authority,” she said, in a low, purring voice, “that Dan has a real thing for Scarlett.”

She paused, and I tried to breathe steadily, jealousy already burning freshly in my chest, excitement building up elsewhere.

“All these problems could go away pretty easily,” she said. A smile formed on her lips. “If Dan had an affair, and we had proof of that... then I’d be off the hook for my affair. Alessandro would lose all his leverage on Scarlett. And *I* could walk away with either money or a license to do what I want with Alessandro. Or whoever else. And the best part, for you, because I’m sure you’re thinking of yourself here, too, is that if we do it right, you stay completely out of it and on the road to being partner.” She leaned toward me conspiratorially. “Dan will feel *really bad* for fucking your wife.”

She leaned back and let out a sharp, bitter laugh, bringing her wine glass close to her face and giving it a swirl. “Isn’t that nice?” she asked of the universe. “Feels terrible for his guy friends, but not for his own wife.”

Her lips opened, and perhaps she had something else to say, but instead she poured wine into her mouth, tipping her head back like she was chugging a beer. Her sudden, incongruent gracelessness was frightening.

She set her glass down on the white tablecloth, and it probably would have shattered if not for the cloth.

“What a lucky day for everyone.”

CHAPTER 8

Scarlett was waiting for me when I got home. She'd texted me a few times and my head had been swimming so much that I had simply written back: *I have to tell you in person.*

She was silent when she opened the door and stepped back to let me in. She was wearing a sexy, light cream sweater that was almost see-through, and white tights that showed off her taut bottom through the thin fabric of the sweater.

I closed the door.

"So?" she asked, a hand to her mouth, the sweater caught around half of her fist. This was a gesture of nervousness, one I rarely saw in Scarlett. Her eyes were wide.

I shook my head slightly. "You would not *believe*," I started, but I interrupted my own thought. "What was Marie like when she came to you about having an affair with Alessandro?"

Scarlett dropped her hand forward, hinging at the elbow. "What was she like?" she asked, confused. "What do you mean?"

I shrugged. "Just... was she, like..." I searched for the words to describe the woman I'd just had a conversation with. "You sort of described it like she was... I don't know...." I was having a hard time getting the point.

"Sort of what?" Scarlett asked, confused.

"She was just... really had an unexpected reaction," I finally concluded.

Scarlett furrowed her brow. "What's that mean?"

I moved into the living room and sat down on the couch. Scarlett joined me. "She just jumped right in. She assumed Dan had figured out that she was having an affair, or that we were thinking of telling him, or something. She thought you had told me. When I told her that you were having an affair with Alessandro, she didn't even blink. And then... she's more worried about her prenup with Dan than anything else. I think she maybe doesn't care about her marriage, and she doesn't really care about Alessandro all that much either. She's... she's... I can't believe it."

Scarlett shook her head again. "What?!"

I turned to her, my elbows on my knees. “So it was actually Marie who came up with a plan, and it’s one that... well, I don’t know... it will probably work, if we pull it off. It gets me out of hot water, gets rid of Alessandro’s leverage over you, and if we do it right, keeps me from falling out of Dan’s favor. I think.”

Scarlett made a disbelieving face.

“The thing is,” I said. “You’re the one who has to do all the heavy lifting.”

Scarlett had her fingertips to her lips. I’d just finished outlining the plan Marie and I had concocted, and then explaining why I thought it would work. At first, Scarlett had mused aloud that she really didn’t have any reason to save Marie’s marriage; she had only cared about Marie because she had pleaded with her and seemed fragile.

But Scarlett, quick on the draw as ever, shook the thought away with a quick shake of the head almost as fast as she had it. “No,” she said. “You’re right. This would all come back negatively on you if Alessandro ever spilled the beans. Marie sounds like she’d find a way to make us pay.”

She had been thinking ever since, and I was waiting for her to arrive at the inevitable conclusion:

If she seduced and slept with Dan, and got it on tape, and Marie showed it to Dan saying that it was all her own idea, then Dan would just believe he had gotten caught in the act by his wife. Marie would then make it clear to Alessandro that he had no leverage over Scarlett anymore, and Scarlett could finally end her relationship with him.

“What’s to stop Alessandro from telling Dan about the whole thing? Wouldn’t Dan still be mad, wouldn’t he feel like I had intentionally seduced him on Marie’s behalf or something? And wouldn’t *that* just come back to haunt you?”

She had a point.

But Marie, the clever bat, had already thought of that, and already come up with a solution. All it would take was Scarlett being willing, and able, to pull it off.

“Marie thinks that Dan has a thing for you, and she can make it happen so it doesn’t seem like you’re seducing him. She even has a good excuse for the tape existing: she just built an addition on the hot tub, and she put in a camera for coyotes a long time ago that she’s sure Dan has

forgotten about. It catches a lot of what goes on in the hot tub room. As long as you can get him to do it in there, she's sure he will believe that she just got lucky taping it."

Scarlett looked unimpressed. "There's no way -"

"These two have a really funky relationship, Scar. Marie knows all about affairs he's had; they have a prenup, she doesn't want to get screwed out of money; Dan getting mad at her is a secondary thing. I think there's enough of a game there between them that you will just look like an innocent bystander. As a bonus, Marie says Dan feels really bad for the guy whose wife he fucks, so I might get preferential treatment."

I smiled ridiculously and shrugged.

This was a weird situation.

Scarlett rubbed her head. "This is all so devious," she said. "And *Dan*? Isn't that going to be awkward?"

I shrugged again, nodding. What choice did we really have?

She sighed. "Isn't it possible that Alessandro would never go through with telling anyone about any of this?"

It was a possibility, and one I'd thought about. After all, he had acted like a pretty big pussy when I'd caught him with my wife in France.

"It's possible," I said. "But do you really want to take the chance?" We looked around at our house, and I think we both realized that we were finally at a point where we liked what we had. We liked our jobs, we liked our new relationship, we even liked Santa Fe, if that could be believed.

Was it worth risking all of this on the bet that Alessandro wouldn't tell Dan about Marie and Scarlett?

And then there was Marie, who I was currently more afraid of than Dan. It was too late to put the toothpaste back in the tube.

I put my hand on Scarlett's. "Let's just get this all behind us, for good. And then get back to work on our plans."

There was no need to explain which plans those were. Scarlett nodded.

"Also," I said, "Marie is scary as fuck. I think she might murder us in our sleep if her prenup gets broken. So there's that."

Scarlett looked at me disbelievingly. "*Marie*?" she said again. She shook her head. "I can't believe it."

"Believe it."

We looked at each other and laughed.

I squeezed Scarlett's hand after a long silence. "So it all just depends now, on if you're up to the challenge of seducing Dan. And willing to do it."

Scarlett bit her lower lip.

"I'm the one who got us into this mess," she said.

Plus, it would be hot.

"One last adventure?" she said, looking at me.

"One last adventure."

*

Marie had everything all planned out, and when I say "planned out," I mean, she had every base covered. She explained the plan in meticulous detail, an unnerving calm in her demeanor.

She *really* wanted evidence of Dan breaking their prenup.

The first part of the plan was to play tennis with some friends of theirs, something which could only be done at the indoor court at the Mountain Vista Country Club. There was no doubt that Marie had considered the witticism in the fact that she would be playing mixed doubles, because she smiled wryly when she told us this detail of the plan. Scarlett and I were to be out to dinner at the club, and "run into" the whole group. Marie would then orchestrate us all going back to their place, where we could try out the new hot tub that had just been installed. From there, it was Scarlett's job to stay up until everyone went to bed, seduce Dan, and get him to fuck her in the hot tub.

The real devil of Marie was in the details she had conspired to put in place: the other couple, there to provide cover and distraction, and selected specifically because Dan always drank more when he was with this particular friend; the tennis, to make our running into each other look natural as well as have it occur at the club. The club, where Marie could suggest that we go back to the hot tub, and both Scarlett and I could exclaim that we in fact happened to have our suits handy there.

What a piece of work, Marie.

I looked over at Scarlett in the Uber to the club. We had decided on a simple black cocktail dress, not her sexiest item by far, but close-hugging and with a generous slit along her thigh. Anything too sexy would seem unrealistic: after all, we were a married couple on a date, and if this crazy

plan was going to work, it was critical that Dan never suspected Scarlett had set him up. Anyway, her swimsuit was sexy enough and would do the trick, once she into it.

She looked out the window as we drove up the winding road to the country club.

“I hope we never end up like them,” she said, suddenly. She turned to look at me. Her lips were painted a sweet coral color, very similar to her pussy when she was aroused, and the shadows fell to highlight her cheekbones, the cool valley between her breasts, and the curve of her leg, making her almost surreally beautiful.

“What do you mean?” I said, my throat dry.

“It’s just sad, don’t you think? The way Marie only cares about her prenup.” Scarlett brought a hand to her face and leaned on the door, looking out at the desert again. “She doesn’t care about anything else. Seems like she’s pretty sure that Dan won’t, either.”

“We don’t have a prenup,” I said, to lighten her mood.

Scarlett turned back to me, smiling. “You know that’s not what I mean.”

I put a hand on her thigh. She entwined her fingers in mine. “We won’t end up like them,” I said. “I promise. I think this is pretty much proof that we won’t.”

“You’re not worried that I’ll fall for Dan?”

She was smiling as she said this.

The truth was, I *was* a little worried. While Scarlett had been caught up with Alessandro, I had only thought about her with him; I had never paused to think of any *other* men in her orbit. Dan was good-looking, he was an alpha-male, he had a sort of grizzled older-lion thing going on, and he was filthy fucking rich. Also, he could be quite charming.

And he liked to win things.

I brought her hand to my lips. “Please don’t fall for Dan.”

Scarlett smiled, and winked at me.

It went straight through me like an electric current, right to my cock.

*

The French doors of the club restaurant were closed, the pool still open and glittering like a lake in front of them, even though no one could

swim in these temperatures. It was using immense amounts of heat, no doubt, just to keep it from freezing at night. But it was important for us to have a nice view.

Scarlett was poised on the edge of her chair, a peculiar way that she has always sat, as though she were going to sprint away at any moment. Her elbow was on the table, a silver earring glittering in the light of the candles on the tables. She had ordered mussels and now regretted it.

“It’s like, *impossible* to eat these things without getting juice all over yourself,” she laughed, trying to pry one open. “And forget about looking sexy.”

She was nervous, I could tell. She had gotten wildly chatty. But it was very cute, watching her fidget with these mussels, and there was nothing that would cause her to not look sexy.

“It’s probably good for our cover story,” I said.

She dropped the mussel. “I hate to do this to you,” she said. “But you’re going to have to share your steak.”

I smiled. “How is that any better?”

“Do it quickly, before they get here, so I don’t starve.”

I lifted a slice of steak and put it on her bread dish. “We can probably write a good how-to guide after this.”

Scarlett smiled, sawing away at the steak with my knife, which she had grabbed in the transfer. “Do’s and don’ts of seducing your husband’s boss with your husband to cover up the boss’s wife’s affair with the tennis instructor your wife also slept with without anyone’s feelings getting too hurt in the process or anyone getting fired. One: do not order mussels.”

“They’re coming.”

I had spotted Dan over the heads of the diners. He was in step with his friend, a dark-haired man in his late forties or perhaps fifties, salt-and-pepper, the moneyed look of an expensive lawyer dripping off both of them. It was the sort of overly-sure, relaxed appearance one could only get from having gotten wildly wealthy by being able to read big words and smile like a used car salesman.

I was seeing Dan through new eyes now: this was the man my wife was on a mission to seduce. He would soon discover that her pussy was the same color as her lipstick, that her nipples hardened into chewable, cotton-candy colored balls, that her ass spasmed when she came. I had no doubt that Scarlett would use her own proclivity for anal sex to seal her hold on

Dan for a second date; Marie had assured Scarlett that he was an ass-man. By the end of the night, if all went well, Dan would have his balls slapping against her dripping pussy and his dick inside the hot velvet channel of her ass.

They were by themselves, changed into casual clothing, hair slightly damp and gently mussed. The ladies were still in the changing room, no doubt. I had to keep my eyes on Scarlett, because it wouldn't do any good for Dan to see me watching him as weirdly as I wanted to. His dark hair looked thicker and better than ever, his jaw more square than usual, his physique imposing.

"You're staring at me like a weirdo," Scarlett said. "Where are they?"

I tried to act more naturally. "At the bar," I said. "They haven't noticed us."

Scarlett popped a piece of steak into her mouth. "Thank God, that gives me time to eat this."

I smiled at her. She delicately patted her napkin against her lips, a gesture that was more mocking than real. Still my same old Scarlett.

Dan and his friend were clinking their glasses together at the bar. Unfortunately, Dan had turned his back to us.

"Dan's not facing us," I said.

Scarlett set her napkin down and fished her lipstick from her purse. I watched her smear it on her lips, press them together, and pucker seductively for me. "Not a problem," she said. "Watch this."

She rose, picking up her purse in one hand. She gave a shake of her beautiful mane, a feline stretch of her leg, and strutted in the direction of the bar.

I wonder where it is that girls learn that hip-swaying walk that all of them seem to have for a moment just like this one. Scarlett doesn't walk like that ordinarily, only when she is putting on a show, and yet it comes back to her as naturally as if she did it every day. Her toned legs flexed as she walked, back straight, hair swaying, and hips moving deliciously side to side, her ass rolling with her gait.

It was delightful to watch the friend's face as Scarlett approached. She caught his eye, and he stared openly at her. I imagined that Scarlett had fixed her eyes on something in the distance, that she was walking brusquely toward the bathroom, intending for Dan to see her on her way out.

The friend made eye contact with Dan, and his eyebrows went up in that very specific, greasy, and utterly transparent exchange that white-collar men use to signal that a hot chick is coming their way and the other one should look at her ass.

It was testimony to just how much Dan actually *did* pay attention to, and recognize, the contours of my wife's body and the color of her hair, because Scarlett passed the pair, and he leaned out a little as the friend slowly turned to watch her ass.

And then, almost immediately, and with both enthusiasm and conviction, he called:

"Scarlett. Hey, Scarlett."

Scarlett had not been expecting this, I was guessing. She was an amazing actress, though. She turned back, still walking, scanned quickly, started to walk forward again, and then stopped, turning back again.

"Dan?" I saw her say. She radiated the perfect blend of surprise, with a very lovely, subtle expression of happiness.

Atta girl, I thought.

Dan reached for her, touching her arm, pulling her toward them, introducing her to the friend, who grasped her hand and kissed it. Dan rippled, and my cock got hard. Both of these guys were trying to charm my wife, and I could see the competition brewing.

Perfect for our plan, though I hoped it didn't get derailed by the efforts of the friend.

Scarlett smiled her most charming smile. Then she lifted a hand in my direction. I quickly focused on my steak for a few seconds, then looked up, naturally, as though I were just looking in the direction Scarlett had gone.

Dan held up a drink in my direction. Scarlett smiled brilliantly.

The next part was crucial, but I could see that it was in capable hands. Scarlett had to somehow conduct them into thinking they were not interrupting our evening, get us invited to their house.

Scarlett lingered flirtatiously. Then she excused herself and hurried to the bathroom, her legs moving at angles like a colt or a fashion model. It was a youthful, appealing gait, and very deliberate.

What a marvel.

Dan turned and looked at me. Then he put his hand on his friend's shoulder and walked over to our table.

“Look who it is,” he said, in his heavy, masculine voice. He looked over his shoulder. “Here with my buddy Corey Finnly.” He looked behind him. “You two on a date?”

“I wanted a steak,” I said.

The club’s steaks were unarguably some of the best in town.

He surveyed my food. “Well, don’t want to interrupt,” he said. I could tell that he was reluctant. He very much wanted to interrupt. He very much wanted to see more of Scarlett.

I wondered how I had missed this obvious attraction before, in Paris.

Oh yes. I must have been distracted the remote-operated bullet in my wife’s ass, implanted there by her Italian lover.

I saw that Marie was hustling into the restaurant, clinging to her friend’s arm. Scarlett emerged from the corridor with the bathrooms almost at precisely that moment, leaving little doubt in my mind that they had orchestrated the event somehow.

The high-octave peal of feminine voices that erupts whenever two or more women who know each other see each other in an unexpected place rang out at the bar. Dan looked behind him.

“You know,” I said. “I think Scarlett’s done. Let’s let the ladies jabber and have one at the bar.”

Dan was happy with this plan, I could see, and so I rose and we went to the bar.

Scarlett had been introduced to Corey, and to Manuela, his pretty, dark-haired, wife who had a very slight foreign accent that did not align with her appearance at all. We all shook hands, and there was a moment of the peculiar awkwardness that occurs when two groups smash together and find they might not mesh.

Luckily Marie was a ruthless person, and, it turned out, an exceedingly clever one. She salvaged the conversation by sucking me and Manuela over to her, to talk about German politics, which sent Corey reeling and which Scarlett deftly picked up on as a way to end up talking to the two men.

And before you knew it, we’d consumed a whole bunch of booze, Marie had called her driver, and she was insisting that we come and see the new addition to the house, a hot tub area.

“You can borrow a suit,” Marie said to Scarlett, before we could even launch a fake protest.

Dan's eyes were undressing Scarlett long before this suggestion was ever made.

"Great," Scarlett said, and the two of them twinkled at each other, for a moment looking very terrifying, hatching their evil plot together. "Oh!" Scarlett exclaimed. "We're here. I could just go grab my suit, it's in my locker."

"How convenient," Marie murmured, cradling a glass of wine to her chest.

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The hot tub addition, which I was very surprised no one had come up with a better name for, was indeed spectacular. I was most surprised by the fact that it had been completed so quickly and with so little hassle. I hadn't even seen it at the party, and I hadn't noticed it when I was sneaking into the house.

Though there could be reasons for that, more to do with my state of mind than the stealth of the builders.

It was a rounded addition, joined to the house at the end of a long hallway on the first floor, which led to studies and libraries that I had not noticed were there on any of my previous visits.

A new corridor led to the hot tub area, an extraordinarily expensive-looking tiled room with a raised hot tub finished with tiles and an intricate mosaic on the floor of it. In Dan and Marie's typical style, it was expensive.

We had some drinks and then Marie worked her magic, encouraging us to get into our suits. Dan was a big help with this, and I could tell it was because he wanted Scarlett wearing the least amount of clothing possible.

Marie knew her husband well. He was also anxious to show off his latest expensive addition to the house. So the evening barreled along, unfolding exactly as Marie wanted it to.

Scarlett emerged from a bathroom off to the side of the hot tub area in her black bikini, a strappy, flimsy shred of material that looked as though it would unravel or disintegrate. It was easy to see that she had a shaved, smooth pussy, with maybe only a hint of blonde hair somewhere leading to it. I could tell that Dan was thinking that exact thought as he stared at her walking to the tub.

Scarlett dipped a toe into the water, lengthening her leg for Dan's pleasure (though Corey enjoyed it as well). She hugged her chest and shook herself. "Whoo," she said. "That's so hot it gives me shivers."

Then she sank in slowly, sliding a thumb under the straps of her bikini in a tease. She dipped to her neck, holding her hair up to keep it from getting wet. Then she stood up abruptly, streams of water running down her chest, over the curve of her breasts, into her belly-button and out. "Too hot," she said. She walked over to sit next to Dan, who was half-in, half-out.

Her nipples hardened in the cool air, and she made sure Dan could see the outline of them beneath the fabric of her bikini.

It was difficult pretending that I was in no way cognizant of, interested in, or wildly turned on by my wife interacting with Dan. I made sure to get into Manuela's orbit, and started asking her all kinds of questions about Germany, where it turned out she was from. Corey and Dan were competing for Scarlett's attention, and Marie was sipping her martinis with the ice-cold calm of an assassin.

Everyone was getting pretty drunk, which was crucial to our plans. I noticed that Marie kept them pouring, and kept everyone circulating out of Dan and Scarlett's orbit. Mostly this involved recruiting Corey to make drinks and then keeping him occupied by spilling things.

I saw her lean in to say something to Scarlett at one point, as the two of them ended up in the kitchen together.

"You guys should just stay here tonight," Marie finally declared. "Corey and Manuela have the far back room, you can have the one at the end of the hall here. Will, you look blasted."

I contrived to look even more blasted than I was, because if there was one thing I had faith in, it was Marie's planning.

About twenty minutes later, Scarlett was hanging on my arm, pulling me out of the hot tub. "Oh, man, he's going down," she said, apologetically. "Marie, show me the room, I'll take him to bed."

They wrapped me up in a towel and escorted me to the bedroom. "Stay in here, cowboy, and pretend to be out of the picture," Marie said, with a smile.

Scarlett leaned forward and kissed me on the lips. Her hand moved down to my erection, and she smiled as she ran her hands over it. "I think it's going very well, don't you?"

I pulled her against my face and kissed her deeply.

"I just hope that Corey guy doesn't interfere," she said.

Then she turned, and dodged a playful swat at her bottom as she shimmied away. "Now play dead," she said. Then she pointed at the window, and I saw that there was a view through it, over a porch, and out to the glass-enclosed hot tub area. "I'll try to make it happen there. And if I can, I'll call you."

I said nothing, because my cock was the only thing I could feel.

"Don't yell 'hello', okay?" she said, and she closed the door behind her.

It was agony waiting through the next several hours, during which time Scarlett told me they had to get rid of Corey by feeding him an endless number of drinks. She deftly cast some looks in Dan's direction, giving him some inkling of hope that if he could outlast Corey, and get the women to bed, then he would have Scarlett to himself.

And so it slowly started to wind down. I heard footsteps in the hall, and then a baritone voice. "Don't tell me you're going to bed already?"

A pause. The water in the hot tub room was casting sparkling waves on the ceiling, they were settling down, no one was in the hot tub anymore.

Scarlett said something in a low voice, and there was a deliciously long pause, but no movement in the hallway.

"Come on," I heard Dan say. "Just one more drink. Will's passed out. Corey ditched me. The girls are going to bed."

Another pause. I wondered what Scarlett was doing. Hopefully she was chewing her lips with uncertainty.

"Don't leave me all alone. I have insomnia."

A pretty laugh from Scarlett. "Me, too."

She did not.

"I, um... just... I don't want to put myself in a, um... compromising position," Scarlett said.

Dan had moved closer to her. I saw the shadows beneath the door, heard his feet on the floor, and his voice was closer when he rumbled something in a very low, almost inaudible voice.

According to Scarlett's account, later, he had whispered: "I promise not to do anything compromising."

Another pause.

“Come on,” Dan said.
And they were gone.

There was another incredibly long hour as the two of them sat with their feet in the hot tub, made more drinks, and circled around the sexual tension between that Scarlett seemed to have set up so excellently.

I watched, my cock aching, the excitement building up so much pressure between my ears, my legs, and in my chest, that I felt I would pop. At last, they were sitting next to each other, talking, faces very close, and Dan went in for the kiss.

My ingenious wife pulled away, putting on a very good show of wanting to not be seduced, looking upset, and then giving in as Dan slid the straps of her bikini down her arm and kissed her again. They slid down into the hot tub, kissing. When Scarlett’s body emerged from the water to turn and face him, sitting on his lap, her bikini was untied, the strings stuck to her back but sliding away into the water.

My phone, which I had forgotten I was clutching so hard that my hand ached, buzzed in my hand. A jolt of fear went through me. Scarlett’s shiny wet back was arching up and back, slowly rolling her torso along Dan’s face, then back again, until she was seated on him. His hand was on her back, digging into her flesh.

I answered the call – from Scarlett, and that’s when I saw that one of her arms was over Dan’s shoulder, where her phone probably was lying on a tiled bench on the perimeter of the hot tub.

The sound filled my ears and overwhelmed me: the echo of the room, the heavy breathing, the whispers that were muffled and sharp at the same time.

“We shouldn’t do this,” Scarlett panted.

There was no reply from Dan, just a splash of water.

Their mouth met, and then there was more panting. Scarlett let out a moan, a raunchy, erotic moan that sounded nothing like her real voice. In the window, I saw Dan clamp a hand on her mouth. Scarlett’s head tilted back and he thrust up inside of her. A muffled moan of pleasure came through on the sound.

“I’ve wanted this for so long,” I heard Dan say.

For a few minutes there was nothing but the splash of the water, and the gentle rocking of their bodies in the window. Then a gasp, as Dan

dropped his hand from Scarlett's face. "Oh God," she whispered.

"Shh, little girl," Dan said, looking at her throat as she tipped her head back and her breasts rose and fell right next to his face. "There you go," he coaxed.

"It's so big," Scarlett whispered. "Oh, it's so big, mmmm."

She rode him for a minute or so, and Dan stretched his arms out along the back of the hot tub and watched her tits as they bounced in front of his face. "That's it," he said. "Make yourself come, good girl."

Scarlett let out a gasp a few moments later, and she tipped her head forward. Dan grasped her by the neck and started to pump into her, and I heard her gasping orgasm.

"Fuck that's hot," Dan said.

Through the window, I saw her grasp him, and hold him down so he couldn't keep fucking her.

Then I heard her throaty whisper. "Wait, wait. I want you to do something for me."

No sound, just splashing, and the figures changed position. Scarlett floated to the side of the pool closest to my view, and looked directly at me in the window, a smile on her face.

She turned and looked behind her, getting on her knees, showing her ass to Dan, who was standing up in the hot tub and had the expression of a man who absolutely cannot believe what was happening in front of him.

But Dan was, in the end, a man of action, and it didn't take long for him to understand that my wife was offering him the dark center of her peach ass.

Scarlett stretched a hand back to guide him. "Get it wet in my pussy, then go slow," she whispered.

When Dan began to slide his cock into her ass, Scarlett opened her mouth and let out a mewl, turning to face the bedroom where she knew I was hiding in the darkness. She tipped her head back and let out another moan as Dan's body slapped against her bottom, his cock sheathed inside of her.

"Oh, fuck," I heard Dan say. "Fuck, that's so hot, your ass is so hot."

"Go slow," Scarlett said. "I want to feel every inch of your cock."

I could see from Dan's face that he was not sure if he could slow himself down. He drew his hips back, and I pictured my boss's fat cock slowly slithering out of Scarlett's ass, the sticky sound too low for me to

hear on the phone echoing in the hot tub room. He slowly re-entered her as she mewled for him again.

“Oh, fuck, baby, don’t move, you’re gonna make me come,” Dan breathed. He reached for her hair and pulled her torso back, until she came to rest against his chest, her breasts flopping. He shoved a hand under the flimsy suit and fondled her breasts one at a time, mashing them and breathing heavily to Scarlett to hold still, hold still.

His hand moved down her torso to her pussy, which he cupped in much the same way I liked to before his fingers sank into her slit and he started to rub her furiously.

Scarlett started to squirm, and Dan pulled his free hand taut against her. “Stay still, stay still and don’t make me come, I want to enjoy your ass a little longer.”

Scarlett’s eyes closed, and her body went stiff as she tried not to squirm and massage the cum out of Dan’s sheathed cock. Her breathing was ragged and squeaky.

When she was about to come, she opened her eyes and stared at me. A loud howl began to issue from her lips, and Dan clapped a hand over her mouth to let her scream into his fingers as she came. The water sloshed, her legs shook, and Dan growled.

He pushed her forward, and she flopped onto her hands like a rag doll, looking at me, her mouth open, her eyes glazed.

Dan hammered into her from that point, hard and fast, though not for very long, her screams muffled by his hand. “Oh, fuck, oh, fuck,” he said, his mouth open, his eyes on his dick sawing into her ass. “I’m gonna give you a big load of cum in your ass, fuck, that feels good.” At last he let out a groan, bent over my wife’s body, and with three sharp, violent thrusts, filled her ass with his cum, just like he promised.

He lay down on top of Scarlett, panting.

“Fuck,” he said finally.

Scarlett pushed up, looking at me through the windows, her breasts hanging from her bikini. Dan’s dick was still in her ass. Her hair was a mess. She looked beautiful.

“That was fucking incredible,” Dan said. He was stepping away from her, she was turning toward him. He put his hand in her hair and pulled her toward him to kiss her. “What a dirty little slut you turned out to be.”

Dan sat down, pulling Scarlett toward him to climb onto his lap. She had her back to me now, but I could see that Dan was pushing her breasts around, maybe even chewing on them.

“I better go to bed,” Scarlett whispered.

Dan leaned in closer to her breasts. Scarlett gasped. She had her hands on his head, so she wasn’t resisting whatever he was doing. He was whispering, and I couldn’t hear what he was saying until he said, “aren’t you?”

And I stared, as the minutes ticked by, and then before long, Scarlett was bouncing on Dan’s lap again, and then turning around, and then re-arranging herself so that he could get into her ass again. It was Scarlett who bounced wildly on his lap, her mouth open, her breath loud and sexy over the phone.

This second time took a little longer, and Dan watched her ass beneath the water as she rode him hard. He had a hand on her chest, fingers swiping her breast, and one hand beneath the water bracing himself as she fucked him and used her hands to play with herself.

Scarlet came first, and leaned back limp after she did. Dan thrust himself up inside of her, and her body bounced as he pumped his cum into her a second time.

Water splashed, I heard a loud crack, and then the call was ended.

Scarlett’s phone must have fallen to the floor.

So I had no audio as Scarlett turned to put her hands on Dan’s shoulders, and kiss him, and they exchanged five full minutes of discussion, before Scarlett slowly climbed out of the hot tub, adjusting her suit, reaching for a towel.

Dan tugged the towel away, she smiled and said something to him, and then she managed to go. Dan watched my wife, smug, and leaned back in the hot tub.

If he felt bad, he had a funny way of showing it.

Scarlett snuck back into the room, closing the door as though she actually thought I would be asleep. She laughed at herself when she saw me. She had been so caught up in the play-acting that she hadn’t stopped, even though it was completely unnecessary.

“So,” I said. “It seemed to have worked.”

Scarlett smiled. I was already moving my hands all over her body, Her skin was hot to the touch, damp, smelling of the saltwater hot tub. Sweat and water mingled at the nape of her neck, and she tasted like a salty toffee.

I explored the squeaky wet curves of her body before I pushed my fingers beneath the stretched bikini and into her pussy. She was swollen and wet, but Dan had not blown his load into her cunt: she smelled only of herself, tangy and honeyed. I brought my fingers to my mouth and tasted her.

I pushed her back onto the bed, tugging down at her suit at the same time. She wriggled out of it and fell to the bed, looking at me intensely.

I stared at the woman that my wife had become, as she seemed to read my mind and my desire, lifting her legs to her ears and spreading herself open for me to view the distended damage done by yet another man who had fucked her tiny asshole and wet his dick in her cheating pussy.

Her red jeweled cunt was sticky wet, glistening in the dim light from the surrounding grounds and the moon that filtered into the room. I reached for her and felt her cunt, then her ass: it was seeping Dan's loads of cum and stretched to a hard opening that I could swipe my finger around with ease. She mewled as I did so.

"Are you sore from getting fucked so much in the ass?" I asked.

She nodded, biting her lip.

"Does Dan have a big cock?"

"It's so big," she said. "He's thicker than Alessandro."

"Is your ass too sore to fuck?"

She nodded. I had my cock out, and I was ready to slam it deep into her pussy, just to see how loose she was from Dan's brief foray inside of her. Instead, I fell on my knees beside the bed and lapped up the tang of her excitement.

I licked the length of her inner folds, where her juices had gathered and streaked my chin and my cheeks. Her body jerked as though I had shocked her when I bit gently on her clit with my teeth and found the exposed face of it with my tongue. "Oh God," she said, gripping my hair.

I pushed her hands up to her ankles to hold her legs in place. "Stay still," I said coyly. "If you can do it for Dan, you can do it for me."

My eyes dropped for a brief glimpse of her pulsing ass, expelling globs of Dan's cum with each throb. I lowered my face and held her thighs

down with a hand on each of them. I bit gently on her clit again until the hood peeled back from the sweet center, which I flicked at with my tongue while her whole body went rigid beneath my hands.

She made a crazy noise, and I kept at it as juices gushed onto my chin and her thighs threatened to explode with the coiled energy inside of them. She tossed her head violently on the bed and howled into the pillow she'd bitten into.

When she came, her ass gushed and her pussy erupted, covering my chin and my neck with the mingled filth of her exploits and her own pleasure.

I rose, pushing down still on her thighs so that I could take a last look at the scene before at last I sank deep inside of my wife. Her pussy was throbbing, soaked, and hot like her skin. I thrust hard until my balls pressed against her oozing ass, and the sound of me slapping into her was sticky and sloppy as I rammed my cum deep into her pussy, while she bit the pillow and dug her fingers into her own flesh at the ankles, because she was so sore and the pleasure so painful – she would tell me later – that she thought she would either yell so loud someone would call the police, or she would pass out.

I fell into bed with her, panting heavily.

I kissed her forehead when she turned to me, then moved down to her mouth, which I enjoyed in all of its wetness. “You did it,” I said.

She searched my eyes, as though looking for approval.

“It was hot,” I assured her.

I propped my head in my hand. “Just one thing worries me,” I commented, tracing my fingers down her chest, playing with her still-hard nipples.

“What if Dan wants to continue his affair with you?”

Scarlett stretched her arms up and shook her head.

“If Marie does what I think she’s going to do with that tape, there’s really no reason for him not to,” I said, as Scarlett turned to push her bottom back into me, so we could spoon.

“I thought we were supposed to be wrapping things up,” Scarlett said, yawning.

I kissed her neck.

“Well, sure, but -”

She turned to me and looked at me, a smile on her lips but a deadly seriousness in her eyes. "So wrap them up."

I kissed her cheek. "Right," I said.

She smiled, and her eyes got heavy as I drew my fingers over her body, savoring the swell of her breasts, the curve of her neck, the softness of her belly.

She fell asleep.

I stayed awake long into the night.

CHAPTER 9

There was little to do after that but let it play out however it was going to play out.

Scarlett decided that changing her number would be too much of a hassle, and there was no way she was going to stop going to the club forever. She knew she would eventually have to confront Alessandro, but she kept putting it off. He barraged her with phone calls and texts, and when she blocked his number he began to call from other phones.

The texts and the messages went from his usually sexy, seductive tone, to his bossy sexy tone, to threatening to reveal her secrets to Marie, Dan, and me, in short order.

“You have to confront him,” I said finally. “Just get it over with.”

Scarlett looked at me, and I thought I had never seen her look so pitiful.

In all the years we had dated, been married, and met every challenging legal obstacle imaginable (all on three or four hours of sleep every two days, it had seemed like) Scarlett had always been tougher than me. She was not afraid of anything, or of facing down an opponent in court.

But now, she looked afraid.

I thought about asking her if she wanted me to go with her, and I was on the verge of doing it, when I realized that then was not the time for questions, or for asking. What Scarlett needed was for me to just *do* something.

“Don’t answer him. What time does he usually go to the club, you know for sure he’ll be there?”

Scarlett looked at me, her mouth open. “Three. For Marie,” she said.

“Text Marie and tell her to skip it.”

Alessandro was shocked to see me sitting in the bar when he strode in, a smug look on his face, looking around for Marie. For a minute, he seemed to be incapable of computing what was going on: he saw me, and a flicker of recognition crossed his face. He was strolling across the room, with a strident swagger before he saw me; he stayed at the far end once he

did. But he continued looking around for Marie, not putting anything together about my presence and her absence.

I wondered if he remembered *who* I was, or if he was such a gigolo that he couldn't even pinpoint which wife I belonged to.

And then I wondered if he was putting everything together right about then, now that he had waited for Marie and she wasn't there, now that he had texted her and she hadn't answered. Now that he saw me, of all people, in the bar.

Then he awkwardly walked out, and back in again, and sat at a table at the far end of the bar, his body tense, as though I were radioactive.

I stood up, and walked calmly to Alessandro's table. I was full of myself, I had to say. It was a feeling Scarlett had described to me, of being in the courtroom, knowing you had everything covered; feeling, in a word, smug.

Alessandro fixed his eyes on the pool area, and then jerked them up at me as though in surprise when I set my beer on the table.

I immediately regretted not buying him a drink – that would have been classier – but put it out of my mind as I sat down, smoothing my tie. I felt, I admit, a little bit gangster.

Alessandro smiled a bit stupidly, then his smile turned serious and afraid, the resultant expression a little like a wild dog's snarl. "What's this?"

"Oh nothing, I just saw you here and thought I would come chat. I never got to introduce myself before. I'm Will. Scarlett's husband."

I extended my hand across the table, which he looked at as though it were a trap before taking it in a weak handshake that he revised, too late, into a firm grip.

"We met in France," I added, smiling.

He began to fidget, propping his hand on his knee, spreading his legs, bouncing his foot so that his whole body was bouncing wildly. He looked around the bar, which was empty except for the perpetually wineglass-washing James, who was discreetly not looking in our direction, but obviously eavesdropping. For him, it was probably like watching the end of a soap opera he had been following all along from behind the bar.

"So, what's this?" Alessandro said, his accent thickening. He jerked his gaze back at me.

"Scarlett's done with her lessons," I said calmly. "Really, really done this time."

Alessandro was tapping the table, and he stopped.

He looked at me, and gave out a short laugh. He leaned forward. “And what if she isn’t?” he challenged me. But he was nervous, and he knew I could sense it in him.

“She is,” I told him. I raised my eyebrows. “Oh, I see. You’ve misunderstood the situation. You think Scarlett’s afraid of you telling me about her affair.”

Alessandro’s eyes narrowed.

I took my phone out, and pressed play on the video of them in our bed.

Alessandro laughed with bravado, but he folded his arms defensively as he leaned back in his chair.

There was no way, after all, for him to know if Scarlett had been playing *him* all along, which is what I had decided I wanted him to think. It was the most likely thing to get him to stop hounding Scarlett: if he believed she had humiliated him by being the real manipulator, then I believed he was much more likely to actually leave her alone.

The wheels were turning in Alessandro’s head. I could tell it was a real grind. The guy was used to winning by just being big, athletic, and good-looking, not by outwitting anyone in an admittedly confusing game of psychological warfare.

Like most animals who have been attacked, he went on attack himself, his eyes gleaming suddenly. He leaned across the table. “And what is your wife going to do when I tell Marie’s husband that she was covering up her affair, that she was sneaking into the house to watch us together like a little pervert? Hmm?”

I picked up my phone, watching Alessandro fuck my wife for a brief moment, and then I turned it off and pocketed it. I was really, really enjoying how this was playing out like a scene in a movie, where I was the smooth operator.

“You know my wife, Alessandro. She thinks ahead. Let’s just say that she has made sure that Dan – that’s Marie’s husband, my boss – doesn’t have any real, let’s say, leverage, to get mad about something that Marie might have done. As for me, he’s probably feeling so guilty right now about fucking my wife that he’ll give me a promotion.”

Alessandro’s mouth fell open, and I could see that he was experiencing – for maybe the first time in his life – a complete breakdown

of his charm.

I stood up. “Marie will be along shortly, by the way. She doesn’t really see any reason to discontinue her lessons, unless you do.”

He said nothing. I was satisfied by the red creeping along his hairline, down his neck. A vein throbbed in his temple.

I had been planning to end the conversation by turning suddenly, holding up a finger, maybe leaning on the table, and asking him: “Oh! You don’t have a copy of my wife with you and your buddy by any chance, do you?”

But he seemed, at that moment, a lot like an actual bull. It was probably best to get out of there.

And as for Marie? Well, if she were any other woman walking in on that, I might have been concerned for her.

So I walked out, and I didn’t look back.

I was right about Alessandro. He never contacted Scarlett again.

I never found out if Alessandro told Dan about their affair, or about Marie.

I don’t know for sure if Marie ever showed the video to Dan, but I do know that Dan didn’t try to contact Scarlett for an ongoing affair. At least, that’s what Scarlett says, and I have to believe her, because I’ve taken Highster Mobile off her phone.

And me? I’ve been given some big contracts, the kind that put you on the fast-track to partner. Who knows why? It could be that I’m a helluva lawyer. It could be that Dan feels guilty for sleeping with my wife.

It could be a combination of the two.

All I know is, the idea of mixed doubles has been shelved, and Scarlett and I are working on our own game for now.

END

MORE FROM ARNICA BUTLER

Did you read the first two books in this series?

Working On Her Game

Will has landed a lucrative position at a law firm in New Mexico, but the transition to the slow-moving, scorching Southwest has been a strain on his marriage. His wife has surprised him by taking up a new sport to fill her time. But it isn't long before the couple discover that Scarlett's new instructor can give her a lot more than just tennis lessons. Her dark, handsome tennis coach might have just the thing their marriage needs...

Game For More

Scarlett and Will are not finished with the adventure they began in *Working On Her Game*. Will gives his blessing to Scarlett to return to her physical relationship with her tennis instructor. At first, their sex life is re-invigorated and the affair seems to bring them closer together. But the young, Italian bull is always pushing the limits of Will's jealousy, Scarlett's comfort zone, and the strength of their marriage. Will things go too far?

Romantic Hotwife Books By Arnica:

Hannah Gets Hot

When Hannah has a chance encounter with a younger man on a plane, Twitter goes crazy for their "budding romance." Her husband Mike sees an opportunity to seize on his long-hidden fantasies. While Hannah is attracted to the hot, young guy from the plane, she's far too loyal to her husband to have an affair... at first. This is a slow-burning story of wife-sharing for the first time, with a scorching finale.

Don't forget to check out *Game For More*, the sequel to *Working On Her Game*

A Taste For Teasing

Oren knows he's a lucky man with a hot wife: Monica is blond, stunning, and has a killer body. She was even a cheerleader in the NBA in her university days – and there are even more interesting jobs in her resume than that. But Monica is also a practical, down-to-earth, and happily married woman.

Things take a turn one year when they're vacationing with friends. Oren discovers that he has a taste for thinking about his wife with another man. And Monica has a taste for... well, something. Monica is becoming a hotwife before his eyes: but Oren can't be sure of *who* she's teasing. Is his fantasy coming true, or is it turning sour? Was there more to Monica's past than she ever let on? Is a hotwife really what he wants?

Ela's Performance

Peter's sweet-faced and fiery wife is headed back to school for a degree in violin performance. Unexpectedly, Peter finds himself becoming very paranoid about who Ela is spending so much time with, and what she is doing at school so very late. It isn't as if he doesn't have his reasons for suspicion. There's the way his own relationship with Ela started, and their own past experiment with an open relationship before they were married. A few other strange things to fuel his jealous fantasies...

And when he discovers someone from Ela's past has resurfaced, he'll take a chance and confront his own desires and obsessions...but will he get what he really wants?

The Houseguest

Sharing and temptation...and sharing temptation. An old buddy returns to Erik's hometown, down on his luck and getting a divorce. By offering to let Ethan stay with them, Erik sees a way to get closer to making his wife-sharing fantasies a reality. To his delight, Natalie seems to be game for something far more adventurous than ever before. But as things heat up, Erik can't help but wonder: Who's seducing whom?

A Conventional Hotwife

Paul Banks was thrilled when a luggage mix-up five years ago opened a window of opportunity for his long-buried desires. Since that time, he and his wife have been playing a little game at their yearly company conventions, and every year his wife ups the ante, going further into his fantasies. But Kathy Banks might be getting just a bit out of control, and things might be going a little too far...

Or not.

The Hotwife Summer

When Ben and Summer have the chance to spend the summer in Italy, their stale marriage starts to heat up in ways Ben could only have dreamed about. Summer is ready to take his hotwife fantasy all the way, and her choice is a sexy, Italian, Michelin star-studded chef. It's too late to put the brakes on what he's set in motion when Ben discovers the humiliating truth about Summer's choice of man. Summer has a taste for being naughty, and a filthy little plan of her own. Will it be everything he could wish for, or will Ben's cuckold fantasy turn into a nightmare he can't escape?

Body of Research

When ever-suspicious Chris plays private detective on his wife's phone and finds that she uses dozens of dating apps, he worries that his darkest fantasies have come true. And it may not be as delicious as he had imagined.

It turns out that Jen is up to something other than cheating, and the door is open for the two of them to explore the boundaries of their marriage. But in any experiment, the results can be unexpected...

The Hobby Job

Former career professional Laura is going crazy living her stay-at-home-mom life in a small country town. Her husband Conrad has the perfect solution: get a “hobby job.” Laura gets turned on to the idea, and to Conrad's surprise, chooses to wait tables at a run-down restaurant down the street. But she gets a lot more than a hobby job when she meets Nate, a young, hot waiter who has his eyes on her from the start.

Conrad and Laura start on separate journeys, exploring new possibilities in their marriage, and opening up to their hidden desires, fantasies, and needs. Will their journeys merge, or will Laura's “hobby job” make a hobby of their marriage?

The Hotwife Tattoo

When Greg's brother marries his wild, tattooed, ex-girlfriend Renee, he knows things will be a little complicated. But when Renee befriends his wife Sara, she starts to change in almost unbelievable ways. Greg sees that there is something more to Renee's plans than just friendly sister-in-law bonding. Is Renee's influence all bad, or can Greg get something he has always wanted and never admitted to is wife – maybe even himself?

Interracial hotwife books by Arnica:

Interracial Hotwife Bundle

Includes *The Tenant*, *Not Black and White*, and *Grand Slam* for \$5.99

Claudia Changes Tack

Mike is on his friends' luxury sailboat with his stunning blond wife Claudia, hoping for nothing more than to convince Claudia that sailing is enjoyable. It turns out that his friends are swingers, in the Caribbean for more than just the sailing. And it turns out that Claudia has a streak of voyeurism in her. The couple embark on a mild adventure of exploration and sexual

reawakening on the warm, beautiful beaches of the Caribbean, and it seems like the ideal vacation.

Grand Slam: An Interracial Hotwife Adventure

Charles keeps a secret desire about his wife Zoe. Her sizzling beauty is typically hidden under scrubs and a hair bun, so his fantasy may never happen. But a wrong turn on a weekend getaway turns out to be the opening pitch of a very naughty game, and Zoe seems determined to knock it out of the park.

The Tenant: A Very Naughty Hotwife Novel

Once upon a time, his exotic and incredibly sexy wife Anna loved to indulge Brian's fantasies...to a point. She teased strangers, and took them to cruel, tantalizing places. But she never went all the way. The game ended when Brian and Anna got married, and that was that.

Or was it?

When the gorgeous, charming, and very black John moves into their basement rental, Brian finds that his sleeping desires have been building up all these years. He doesn't just want Anna to tease. He isn't just toying with the idea. He is obsessed with driving his wife to do things with another man. Lewd things. Obscene things.

When he confesses his desires, is Anna just a little bit too willing to make things just like old times? Is she too easy to push over each new line? Brian can't help but wonder if his own obsessions have gone too far...or if Anna's have.

Not Black And White

When a photographer turns Rick on to the idea of watching his wife with another man, Rick feels an obsessive desire inside of himself catch fire. He can't help arrange for his shy, girl-next-door wife Danielle and the rugged, black photographer to cross paths. He knows that Drake Reyes' erotic

photographs are not as abstract as they appear, and that Reyes sleeps with his married models. He knows his wife is not immune to Reyes' charms – no one is. He just can't help but imagine what it would be like to stand in his gallery, looking at Reyes' lurid photos, knowing his own wife is the model, knowing how the photos were taken.

But was it really his idea, or have Drake and Danielle been as manipulative as he has?

Please note, this is the novelized version of the short story Black and White, with significant changes to all scenes depicted in the short story, as well as the point of view. There is, however, some repetition: scenarios which occurred in the short occur in the novel. There are plenty of fresh new adult scenes, however. Please enjoy.

Unlocking Noel: A Reluctant Hotwife Novel

Pretty, bookish Noel is not exactly an adventurer in or out of the bedroom, and Spencer has come to accept that. But things take an unexpected turn one year at an annual ski vacation. When they return the following year, Spencer gets to work on unlocking Noel and her (literally) dark desires.

A romantic hotwife novel with a deliciously corruptible and reluctant heroine.

Lisa Plays Her Part

Lisa and Luke married young because of an unexpected pregnancy, and Lisa never had much experience with other men as a result. But when a dark, handsome, wealthy man she almost slept with (and always wondered about) resurfaces in her life, Lisa is confronted with agonizing desires... and choices. Now that their nest is empty and they don't have the same reasons to stay together, will Lisa and Luke reconnect, or will Lisa choose to make this the final act of their marriage?

Megyn For The Win

In Megyn's view, nothing could be sillier than entering a charity contest to win a "date" with the sexy black celebrity Max Riley, not even to raise money for underprivileged youth. (Un)fortunately for her, her friend entered her in the contest anyway.

When she wins, her husband Peter sees a chance to dip into a fantasy of his. But when this brush with fate turns into a very real, permanent job offer for Megyn – one that puts her in close and frequent contact with the famed black actor – the couple has a lot more to think about than just a winning a "date."

A romantic, interracial hotwife story with a win at the end!

*Hotwife **Suspense** By Arnica Butler*

Nila's Long Con

It began with a chance encounter with a man from his wife's past. Rich knew Tennile had some skeletons – of a sexual nature – in her closet, but he never dreamed they were going to come back to haunt them both. Before he can blink, the two of them are embroiled in high-stakes intrigue, with Tennile's reputation and career, their marriage, and a lot of money on the line. There seems to be no way out but to play the game, and Tennile's past might be game-winning asset. In the style of *A Well-Laid Trap*, this is a thrilling hotwife ride that will keep you hooked until the end.

A Well-Laid Trap

It all begins when Patrick is convinced he saw his wife with another man at a downtown bar.

He begins to investigate. But the more Patrick uncovers about Jordan's activities, the less he understands.

The biggest problem is, Patrick can't decide how he really feels. On the one hand, his wife seems to be betraying him, and on the other, his sex life has reached a scorching pinnacle he never thought possible.

But he had better hold on to his hat, because when he finds out the truth, things will get much, much hotter than he might have ever imagined...

Fun Summer Swinger Titles:

Clothing Optional

Sy Price and his wife find themselves in an unexpected situation when their Belize vacation resort turns out to be “Clothing Optional.” They’re even more surprised to find out that “Clothing Optional” is code for quite a bit more. They decide to make the best of things and enjoy their vacation. But there are a lot more surprises in store for Sy when Jackie decides to fully embrace the hotel amenities...

A Summer Vacation

Poor Keith. He's been condemned to a campy cruise with his family and friends. Worse yet, he suspects something is going on between his wife and bad-boy Hank, the husband of a family friend his wife has invited along. Keith's in for a very big surprise – and much more naughty, adult fun than he expected on this cruise – when he finds out what's really going on.

Try To Have Some Fun

Helena and Steve's wealthy, sexy, swinger friends have returned to town. Helena has a child- and work-free stretch of summer ahead of her. There's nothing stopping her from spending her days relaxing by their spectacular pool. No reason not to borrow a tiny bikini, or to maybe sunbathe topless. Or skinny-dip at one of their wild parties. One thing, though, will probably lead to another...

Explore darker themes by Arnica Butler:

Well-Constructed Affairs

As a hot female construction engineer, John's wife Adria draws a lot of attention at the job site. Which isn't all bad. But when Adria opens the door for him to tell her about his sexual fantasies, he doesn't realize she has

opened the door on her own – very dark – fantasy as well. A fantasy she hasn't shared with anyone until now. The couple are off on an exploration of their desires...but is their marriage well-constructed enough to withstand the forces of their fantasies?

Nikita Gets In Too Deep

When Cole and his wife Nik arrive at their usual vacation spot in dull Cape Breton, they're taken by surprise by the most unlikely of next-door neighbors: ultra-sexy Paige and wealthy, commanding Mitch. And these new neighbors are full of surprises. Cole and Nik embark on new adventures in their marriage, trying new things and pushing boundaries they'd never even discussed. It's invigorating, but Cole can't help but wonder if his transformed wife hasn't gotten herself in too deep...

A Gamble: The Making of A Hotwife

Ryan is just an average guy, coaxing his sweet, beautiful wife Victoria into playing into his hotwife fantasy – even if they're just pretending. But a trip to Vegas with his co-worker Brad and his sexy wife Irena turns Ryan's life upside-down. To help Ryan, Brad makes a proposal that could change everything...but it all centers on Victoria's innocence. How far will Victoria go to save what she holds most dear, now that her virtues, her love for Ryan, their marriage, Ryan's desires, and even their finances all hang in the balance? This is a 52,000-word novel about risk and romance, filled to the brim with the hard, steamy scenes you love. Please enjoy!

A Dark Place: Cuckolded In Lagos

Three people are carving out their fortunes in Africa's largest city, but each of them holds a deeper, darker desire. What is the secret desire of the angelic Charlotte, who finds all men's eyes on her after dark in Lagos? What about Andrew, who keeps a secret hunger so buried perhaps he doesn't admit it even to himself? And what could be darker than Clement Ambode's already shadowy “reliability” as an all-purpose contractor in the underbelly of Lagos?

Charlotte, Andrew, and Clement will find themselves in a very dark place when their worlds collide in this ultra-sexy, novella-length cuckold story.